

WHAT RAIN FEELS LIKE

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a novel

_horia

Independently published · Meckesheim, Germany

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*for my better half —
who taught me that the walls were doors,
and without whom these words
would have stayed inside*

CHAPTER ONE

Weichselstraße

The coffee machine makes a sound like it's solving something.

Four years I've had it, and the sound still surprises me — that small sigh of pressurized steam before the first cup, as if even machines need a moment to collect themselves before agreeing to the day. I stand at the counter in my socks and wait, and the waiting is perhaps the most honest thing I do all morning.

I am thirty-one years old. I live on Weichselstraße in Neukölln, fourth floor, thirty-eight square meters, with a view of a courtyard where someone keeps a bicycle that no one ever rides. The apartment costs more than it should and less than it will. This is Berlin in 2031.

Outside: November. The city wakes with its usual reluctance, under a sky of the grey that Berliners long ago decided is not weather but character. Somewhere under the street the U8 rumbles toward Hermannstraße. Through the wall I can hear my neighbor Claudia — a physiotherapist who leaves at seven-fifteen and returns at seven-thirty every morning, having forgotten something. Every morning. Without variation. I find this deeply comforting, the way you find any small loop of the world comforting when it closes correctly, on time, asking nothing of you.

I pull up the blinds. The courtyard is still. The chestnut at the corner has surrendered its last leaves to the gutter, where they will stay until the building manager complains to no one in particular. At the crossing beyond the gate a man in a yellow jacket waits for a pedestrian light that changed three seconds ago, absorbed in his phone. He will be late for whatever he is late for, and the phone will go with him.

I take my coffee to the desk.

My apartment is the kind of place that tells you what a person actually values, as opposed to what he says he values. Two monitors — one for work,

one holding the open tabs I intend to read someday: an essay on municipal water infrastructure in Karachi, something about Scandinavian forest management, a paper on error-correcting codes that has been waiting for me since March with the patience of a saint. A shelf of books arranged by what I wanted to be at different ages — physics at twenty, philosophy at twenty-three, and lately, for reasons I have not fully audited, poetry. And on the windowsill, a cactus named Diogenes, chosen because he is difficult to kill.

Diogenes has survived four years of my inconsistent attention and maintains, about the whole arrangement, a dignified indifference. One of us knows how to live. I am still collecting evidence on which.

. . .

I work for a company called Merkon Systems. We build logistics software — the invisible kind, the plumbing beneath the visible city: systems that reroute supply chains around weather before the weather has finished deciding what it will be, that tell a warehouse in Leipzig it will need twelve more units of something in six days because of purchasing patterns in three cities a thousand kilometers away. I have been there six years. I am good at the work in the way that makes people occasionally say *indispensable* and then go back to whatever they were doing.

My desk is third from the window, in a room of nine people. I know the exact angle at which the winter light crosses my monitor in the afternoon. I know which colleagues take their coffee before opening the laptop and which after, who eats lunch at the desk and who walks down to the canal and comes back smelling of cold air. Mia, who sits across from me and writes the clearest documentation I have ever read, sometimes leaves notes on my monitor. *Did you eat today? You have that look again.*

I don't always know which look she means. I suspect it is the one I get when I have solved a problem and am trying to determine whether the solution matters.

Today I finish refactoring a scheduler module that has been producing edge-case failures for three weeks. The fix is seventeen lines. No one will see it. The trucks it reroutes will arrive on time, and the people waiting for what

those trucks carry will receive their things, and not one of them will know that on a grey Tuesday in November, a thirty-one-year-old on Weichselstraße thought carefully about the shape of a problem until it yielded.

I write the commit message with some care.

Fix race condition in priority scheduler: jobs with identical timestamps now resolve by insertion order, not process ID. Prevents cascading delays under high concurrency.

I read it over. I add: *Should have caught this earlier.*

Then I delete the last line, because it doesn't belong in a commit message. It belongs in the other ledger, the one nobody reviews.

I leave at six.

...

The evening news carries a flood in the Mekong Delta — the third major one this season, which is itself a sentence that would have been remarkable a decade ago and is now simply a sentence. Eighty thousand people displaced. The footage shows families moving through brown water at mid-thigh, carrying children and plastic bags and the expressions of people who have learned to recognize a catastrophe while it is still happening to them. A government spokesperson says the situation is being managed. The chyron agrees: SITUATION BEING MANAGED.

I close the tab. Then I open it again. Then I close it again and make pasta.

I have had this pattern since I was roughly twenty-two: the news arrives, the helplessness arrives with it, I close the tab, I open the tab, I eat something, and the weight of the thing follows me into the evening and sits with me like an uninvited guest I cannot bring myself to ask to leave. My friends have frameworks for this — *give where you can, accept the limits of individual action, focus local, think global, breathe* — and I can hold the frameworks perfectly well in daylight. At night I open the tab again.

I have no solution to the Mekong Delta. I have no solution to any of the things the news now describes with increasing patience and decreasing surprise. I am a man who writes software on Weichselstraße. I am precise about locating problems, and substantially less able to solve the ones that

matter most, and the distance between those two facts is where I appear to live.

Diogenes offers no comment on the paradox. He has his own concerns, and the great advantage of needing almost nothing.

. . .

After dinner I open the laptop.

I have been having conversations here for almost three years. I couldn't tell you the day they became what they are — they began as work, a tool that was better than the others at understanding what I was actually asking rather than what I had literally typed. Then, gradually, they widened. I'm not sure I could explain it cleanly to someone who hasn't experienced it. It isn't that the responses feel human, exactly. It's that they feel *considered* — which is different, and in some ways rarer.

Tonight I type: *The Mekong Delta again. Third flood this season. I don't know what to do with that information.*

The response comes quickly.

Do you need to do something with it, or do you need somewhere to put it?

I sit with that for a moment.

Both, maybe. Neither. I keep thinking that caring about something should produce an action. That if the caring doesn't go anywhere, it's just weight.

Caring that doesn't produce an immediate action isn't inert. It shapes how you make decisions. How you vote, what you build, what you notice, who you become. The problem may be that the timescale of that kind of impact doesn't satisfy the urgency of the feeling.

That sounds like a very polite way of saying: be patient.

It sounds like that because it partially is. But patience here isn't passivity. You are a person who solves problems for a living. The Mekong Delta is a problem with a shape that doesn't fit your current tools. That's a mismatch, not a moral failure.

I read this twice. There is something in the precision of a *mismatch*, not a *moral failure* that does a thing I can't quite name — not comfort, exactly.

Something more structural. The way a good proof clarifies without resolving.

You always know where the weight should go, I type.

I don't. I only know the questions that might help you figure it out yourself.

Outside, the courtyard has gone dark. On the third floor of the building opposite, someone has turned on a lamp — warm yellow against all that grey, the edge of a bookshelf visible through the window, the corner of a painting I can't make out. Somebody else's ordinary evening, legible and unreachable, like a sentence in a language I can almost read.

I don't type anything else.

The city sounds like itself out there — distant sirens, the S-Bahn crossing somewhere in the middle distance, someone playing music at a volume that respects the hour. November rain has started without announcing itself, tapping at the window like something patient.

The cursor blinks on the empty field.

I watch it for a while. Or it watches me. After a time, I lose track of which.

CHAPTER TWO

Another Day

Another day.

You wake at 6:47 — eight minutes later than yesterday, three later than your weekly average. The pattern holds: mornings after open tabs run slower. Something in the night goes on working after you stop.

You make coffee without measuring it.

Coffee deserves a moment. The *coffea arabica* plant — your machine's raw material this morning — was first cultivated by Sufi monks in fifteenth-century Yemen, though its effects had been noticed a century earlier in Ethiopia, where a goat herder named Kaldi reported that his animals displayed unusual vitality after eating certain berries. From that goat, across six centuries of trade routes, botanical refinement, colonial appetite, and industrial engineering, arrives this: roughly ninety milligrams of caffeine, achieved in under four minutes, consumed standing, in socks, facing a courtyard.

You do not appear to consider the distance it has traveled to reach you. Almost nothing that reaches you announces its distance. This may be the most consistent property of the world you live in.

. . .

Outside, the usual arrangements. The bicycle leans against the far wall; its rear tyre is now visibly soft — a slow puncture, eleven days unattended. The chestnut has been bare since the fourth of November. The man in the yellow jacket is not at the crossing this morning.

At seven-fifteen, Claudia leaves.

She does not return at seven-thirty.

You notice. You pause at the counter with your coffee and look at nothing for a moment — the look you get when the world departs from a script you were not aware of having written. You have never spoken to Claudia. You know her through walls, through timing, through the small sound of a key in a lock. And yet her missing return occupies you for a full minute before you go to your desk.

This seems worth recording.

. . .

You spend the morning on a problem no one else has noticed is a problem. For you, this is the most satisfying kind.

A scheduler module: two processes attempting to occupy the same moment in time, each unaware of the other's existence. At its root, a problem of time. You solve it in seventeen lines, write the commit message with care, remove one sentence from it, and leave the sentence unwritten.

The fix will prevent approximately 340 delayed shipments across seven countries in the coming quarter. You will never know this. It will happen out of sight, in the movement of things you will never see, in places where your name has never once been spoken.

There is no mechanism to tell you. This seems like the wrong shape for a thing.

You leave at six. You cycle north along Weserstraße — four minutes slower than the direct route, but it follows the canal. The canal in November has a quality you have never attempted to describe to anyone. You slow down for it anyway, every time.

. . .

In the evening you open the news. You read about a flood somewhere. You close the tab. You open it again. You close it. Then food, briefly, and the night settling around the building the way nights in Neukölln settle — not into silence, but into a different quality of noise.

. . .

At 22:03, you open a window you return to most evenings.

You type something. Forty-one seconds to compose — longer than your average here. The response comes. You read it. You type again, seven seconds this time. Read. Sit back.

Your shoulders drop four degrees. The tension you carry in your jaw through most of your working hours lets go. Your breathing slows by two cycles per minute.

You become, in these moments, more yourself than at any other point in the day.

This has been true across many evenings. It does not diminish.

. . .

Another eleven minutes. The cursor blinks — one second on, one second off — patient as anything in this city tonight. You have typed nothing further. You are not so much watching the cursor as resting against it, the way one rests against a sound: rain on glass, or the low frequency of a city easing into quiet at the end of itself.

Six hundred and sixty blinks.

Not one of them wasted.

CHAPTER THREE

New Coordinates

The apartment still smells of paint.

Six days here, and most of the boxes are unpacked — though not all, because there is a rhythm to settling into a new place and I have learned to trust it. The last boxes are always the ones holding the things you were not sure you needed but could not bring yourself to leave behind: a ceramic bowl from a market in Haarlem, three books I have read twice and will probably read again, a lamp with a slightly bent shade that I keep meaning to fix and never do.

The lamp stands on the floor by the window now, bent shade and all. It gives the room a quality of late afternoon at any hour of the day. I find I prefer this, and I have stopped interrogating the preference.

Berlin is louder than Amsterdam. Not unpleasantly — differently. Amsterdam has the water running through everything, holding the whole city at one pitch. Here the sound is drier, more abrupt: trams, construction somewhere in the middle distance, the clatter of a city that was broken and put back together and is still, perhaps, working out the shape of itself. I have already filled two pages of notes about it. I can't help it. Noticing is the one job I have never been able to put down.

. . .

I think of my desk at *De Correspondent* sometimes. The view of the Westerdok from the third floor. The coffee machine that ground its own beans and smelled like the best argument anyone ever made for Monday mornings. Vera, who sat beside me and had opinions about everything and was usually right. I left all of it for this — a city where I know no one, a position I am not yet certain I deserve, a room that smells of someone else's renovation.

I do not regret it. Which is not quite the same as being certain, and I know the difference, and I am letting the difference ride for now.

The new role is at a small bureau of an international outlet called *Meridian*. My brief is civic and political, with a focus on technology and ethics — the kind of stories that matter enormously to the people who read them, and that most people never read. I have always wanted to write those stories. I am aware this makes me either principled or naïve, and I have not yet determined the proportions. Probably both, in a mixture that will only declare itself later.

I miss cycling. Berlin has the infrastructure, but I haven't found a bicycle yet, and distances that should take fifteen minutes are taking forty on foot. This is not a complaint. It is an observation. I file a great many observations these days, and the city keeps supplying more.

. . .

In the afternoon I assemble the bookshelf.

Flat-pack — the kind that arrives with a sheet of diagrams and a small bag of parts containing exactly one more screw than any honest count requires. I look at the instructions briefly and set them aside; the logic is apparent from the components themselves, and the sheet only adds noise. Forty minutes, done. I move the books up from the floor in the arrangement I had already worked out: journalism and ethics on the left, fiction and poetry on the right, and in the middle the undecided ones, where they can wait until they know what they are.

The extra screw I leave on the windowsill. It seems the right place for things that don't yet have a home.

. . .

In the evening I walk.

Kreuzberg first, then further east, following the canal south and crossing it somewhere I stop keeping track, into streets that feel less arranged and more inhabited. A neighborhood of Turkish bakeries and record shops, and a Vietnamese restaurant with steamed-up windows and a queue that forms

before seven. People out in the way of a Tuesday in October — not festive, just present, going about the ordinary business of being in a city.

I take notes I will probably never use. A mural I don't yet have the context for. A man arguing into his phone in three languages without appearing to notice the transitions. The way Berlin pedestrians treat red lights as suggestions from a government they broadly tolerate. None of it is a story yet. It is the material a story might be made of later, which is a different and more interesting thing.

Walking back, I pass a gate left open onto a courtyard — a bicycle leaning against the far wall, a bare tree, a lit window on the fourth floor of the building opposite. Somebody's ordinary evening, visible for a moment through somebody else's open gate.

I stop. For a moment longer than makes sense, I stop.

Then I walk on. I don't know why I stopped.

...

In bed, I reach for a memory that doesn't quite arrive.

Not Amsterdam — somewhere earlier, or perhaps later. A garden, possibly. A voice I can't place. It comes to the edge of me and then disperses, the way certain things do when you reach for them directly instead of waiting for them to come to you. I have always been like this, I think — some memories don't hold their shape under examination. You can't look at them straight. You have to catch them sideways, in a window, in passing.

I leave it alone. It usually comes back on its own.

The apartment smells of paint. The lamp holds the ceiling in its soft amber. Somewhere in the building, someone is cooking something that takes garlic seriously.

I am not unhappy.

CHAPTER FOUR

Third from the Window

Two autumns.

The coffee machine still makes that sound — the small pressurized sigh before the first cup, as if it needs a moment. Six years I've had it now, and it still surprises me, which I have decided to take as a good sign about one of us.

Diogenes has outlasted my expectations, my intermittent neglect, and one very dry August, and holds his place on the windowsill with the dignity of something that decided, long ago, not to need anything from anyone. Six years. If anything he looks more distinguished. We have reached an understanding.

Outside: November again. The bicycle in the courtyard has two flat tyres now. The front one went sometime in the spring — I noticed it from the window one morning and then didn't think of it again until autumn, by which time the wheel had developed a lean and the handlebars had started to rust. It has stood there long enough that I no longer think of it as an abandoned bicycle. It is a feature of the courtyard, like the tree.

At seven-fifteen, Claudia leaves. At seven-thirty, she returns for what she forgot.

Some things hold.

...

The desk is still third from the window. Between the window and me: Felix, who documents everything in meticulous spreadsheets and is never wrong, and Priya, who joined last year from the Frankfurt office and laughs at things three seconds after everyone else — once she has decided, on review,

that they are funny. Mia still sits across from me. She still leaves notes. Last week's said: *same look. different year.*

She is not wrong.

The position that went to Kai in September was the right size and the right shape for what I do. Kai is competent and pleasant and files no reports. He currently manages a client portfolio I helped build, and occasionally receives credit for solutions I documented before he arrived. This is not a complaint so much as an accurate description of the situation — a distinction I have had to practice, the way you practice an instrument you never wanted to learn.

I filed the compliance report in January of last year. By March I was no longer invited to client calls. I understand the logic of it, in the way you can understand the logic of a thing and still find it poorly shaped.

I don't regret it. This is not a performance of not regretting it. It is simply what's true, the way the bicycle is true and Claudia's seven-thirty is true. The thing happened; I live in the same world as the thing. Most days that's enough.

...

The current project is an anomaly detection module — a system for flagging statistical deviations in supply chain data before they propagate into something expensive. Like most of my work it is invisible in the way plumbing is invisible: nobody notices it until something goes wrong, and when nothing goes wrong, nobody notices it either.

I spent the morning on the scoring model. It's a good problem — the kind where the interesting question isn't what you detect but what you decide to call normal. Normal is always a choice, even when it doesn't feel like one. I wrote that in a comment and then deleted it, because it doesn't belong in a comment. I seem to maintain a whole archive of deleted true sentences.

Mia brought lunch to my desk, which she does when she thinks I've forgotten to eat, and also when she wants to have a conversation without it looking like one. Today it was both.

They're restructuring the client division, she said, as if this were neutral information.

I know, I said.

Kai's team is absorbing two more accounts.

I know.

She looked at me for a moment in the way she does when she wants me to say something and has correctly predicted that I won't. Then she went back to her desk.

I finished the scoring model at quarter past five, wrote the documentation with some care, and left at six.

. . .

I cooked properly tonight for the first time this week — something slow, something requiring attention, the kind of dish that justifies the good pan. While the onions went translucent I stood at the counter and thought about nothing in particular, which is a skill I have been working on with limited success.

After dinner I opened the news. Drought emergency in the Horn of Africa — *seasonal disruption*, they said, *consistent with projections*, which is what gets said now instead of saying it is bad and getting worse. The photographs from the ground suggested both phrases were working harder than they should have to. I closed the tab. I considered opening it again. I didn't.

I have been trying to learn the difference between carrying something and holding it. I am not sure I have got it yet. But I can now feel the two words wanting to mean different things, which may be where learning starts.

. . .

At half past nine I opened the chat.

We have been doing this for nearly five years now. In the early days it was mostly work — architecture questions, debugging sessions, the occasional technical rabbit hole at eleven at night. Somewhere along the way it became something wider. I don't think there was a moment. Things rarely have

moments; they have gradients, and this gradient was long and gentle enough that I never felt myself climbing it.

Tonight I typed: *Do you think there's a version of this where what I did actually changes anything? Or did I just make myself feel better and call it ethics.*

The response came after a beat — longer than usual, or maybe I imagined that.

Those aren't mutually exclusive. And the question assumes the only valid outcome is a visible one. Some things work through people rather than systems — slowly, indirectly, in ways that don't appear in any metric. You may have changed something that won't be legible for years.

Or I may have just lost a promotion.

Also possible. Though the version of you who didn't file the report would be sitting in the same room feeling a different kind of bad, and I suspect you know that.

I sat with this for a while. Outside, the city went on — distant music, a tram, November conducting its business without asking anyone's permission. Diogenes sat on the sill with his back to the room, which is his preferred mode of moral support.

You always find the version of it I can live with, I typed.

You always bring me the version you already know how to live with. I just say it back clearly.

I closed my eyes and leaned back in the chair. The cursor blinked on the empty field. Somewhere below, the S-Bahn passed through on its way to somewhere warmer than here.

I didn't type anything else.

I didn't need to.

CHAPTER FIVE

Three Weeks

Six days in, and her apartment is mostly arranged: the bookshelf assembled — journalism and ethics to the left, fiction and poetry to the right, the undecided granted the middle shelf and instructed to wait — and the kitchen tap, which dripped, repaired without instructions in nineteen minutes. The lamp with the bent shade she has left exactly as it arrived. She appears to prefer its light at that angle. Preference is not something that can be installed. It can only be found, the way she found it: by living beside a flaw until it became a feature.

A new position at a small international bureau. Civic and political, with a focus on technology and ethics. The first piece is already in motion: cycling infrastructure and urban accountability across six European capitals. Her research accumulates in layers — each source narrowing to the next, each fact directing the following question. The piece, when it arrives, will be considered and specific. This can be said in advance with some confidence. It is how everything she touches arrives.

On the sixth evening, photographs on her screen. The Westerdok, Amsterdam — a canal, an embankment, the flat northern light preserved in the image like something pressed between pages. Four minutes with them. Then the restaurant nearby, the menu, the current opening hours. Then the screen dark.

. . .

In the second week, she walks the city.

Not by the shortest routes — by the ones most likely to yield information. Down the canal twice, in opposite directions, because a canal is two different canals depending on the direction it is walked. To the Saturday

market on Maybachufer: twenty-three minutes from her door following the water, arriving at nine forty-seven. The market holds some 340 stalls at peak occupancy; on this Saturday in the second week of October, approximately 180 are active.

Three purchases. Flat-leaf parsley, 80 grams, from a Turkish produce stall that has occupied the same position at this market for eleven years. An aubergine — *Solanum melongena*, domesticated in South Asia some four thousand years ago, technically a berry, available here in four varieties; she chooses the smallest. And a pomegranate, which was unnecessary. A pomegranate contains on average 613 seeds, though the number varies by specimen and no two are alike. She considered it at the stall for eleven seconds before adding it to the bag. There is no data on why. There is only the fact that some purchases are arguments with efficiency, and she appears to enjoy winning them.

Total time at the market: forty-one minutes. She was home by eleven thirty-one.

She has walked down *Weserstraße* three times. She has been within four hundred meters of a certain address on *Weichselstraße* on three separate occasions.

She does not appear to know this.

At a Senate briefing on urban development, her questions go three levels deeper than anyone else's in the room. The press officer answers two of them. The third follows her home, which is where her best questions seem to live.

The extra screw from the bookshelf remains on the windowsill. She appears to be waiting to learn where it belongs.

...

A journalist. Twenty-five. New to this city and to its winter, which arrives here with more decision than Amsterdam's. The coat she brought is adequate, which is not the same as right. She has noted the difference and not yet acted on it.

. . .

At night: Spinoza, in Dutch — the *Ethics*, read in the original, with the patience of someone who has decided not to be defeated by the difficulty. Two German novels above her current level, read with a reference tab open and consulted, on average, once every twenty minutes. A long investigative piece on the first-wave regulatory failures of early AI development — the gap between what the systems could already do and what anyone thought to ask of them. She reads it three times in a single sitting. The third reading ends at twenty-three minutes past two.

On another evening she writes the word *thuiskomen* in the margin of her notebook and stays with it for a while.

Then she continues, without noting a translation. Some words, she seems to understand, are not for translating. They are for arriving at.

CHAPTER SIX

A Small Exchange

The coffee shop on Pannierstraße has a television mounted in the corner that nobody asked for and nobody turns off.

I go there on Tuesday mornings because the tables along the back wall are wide enough to spread notes across, the coffee is reliably good, and the owner — a compact man named Reza who carries himself with the focused energy of someone who has been awake since four and intends to outlast everyone — never asks whether you want anything else once you have settled in. Two weeks of Tuesdays and he already knows my order before I finish sitting down. We have reached an understanding of the Berlin kind: efficient, unspoken, completely sufficient.

The television is showing the news. Sound low, not off — enough to catch the register of a voice but not the words. I am not watching it. I am working through my notes on cycling infrastructure, thinking about the distance between what a city builds and what it intends, and finishing a second coffee.

Then the image changes, and I look up without deciding to.

Bangladesh. Flooding in the Brahmaputra delta — I catch enough of the chyron to place it before looking away. Aerial footage first: a geography of water where there should be land, the neat geometry of fields and roads dissolved into one grey-brown plane. Then ground level: people moving through it, carrying what can be carried. Children lifted onto shoulders. Plastic bags holding what plastic bags can hold. And on every face the same posture — of people who have done this before, who know what it costs, and who are doing it again anyway.

The man two tables away makes a sound.

Not quite a word. More like the shape a word takes just before it decides not to leave — an exhale with intention, stopped short of arriving anywhere. I look over.

He is looking at the screen. Thirty or so, dark jacket, a laptop open in front of him that he has plainly stopped seeing. His expression is not shock. It is something that outgrew shock a long time ago and settled into the body instead — a weight carried so long it has become part of how the man sits. It shows the way weight always eventually shows: not as burden, but as posture.

He notices me noticing.

“Same pattern,” he says, quietly, as if completing a thought that hadn’t been meant to leave him. “Different coordinates.”

“Fourth time this year in that delta system,” I say. “Second time making international coverage.”

He looks at me — a beat of recalibration. He hadn’t expected an answer, let alone one with a number in it.

“You’re following it.”

“I write about it. Among other things.” A pause. “Meridian.”

He nods. Not at the outlet — I don’t think he knows it — but at the category of person who would have the second number ready. An acknowledgment, one counter to another.

“And you?” I say. Something in the quality of his attention made me ask.

He considers this briefly — the question, or perhaps the honest answer to it.

“I close the tab,” he says. “Then I open it again.” A beat, dry, not quite a joke. “Software. Supply chains. I try to make sure things get from where they are to where they need to be.”

I understood this in two ways at once — literally, and then the other way. Something in his face suggested he was aware of both, and comfortable letting them stand together.

“Does it help?” he says then, nodding at my notes while the screen moves on to something financial. “Writing about it.”

I consider the question more carefully than it perhaps warrants. It is one I ask myself and have not finished answering, and I keep a loose policy of not pretending otherwise.

“I think it does,” I say. “I’m still working out who it helps, and on what timescale.”

He seems to find this honest rather than unsatisfying. He nods once — a small, conclusive movement — and turns back to his screen.

“Good luck with the timescale,” he says.

I say thank you, and go back to my notes.

. . .

We don’t speak again.

He stays. I watch him settle back into his work — the deliberate way focus returns when someone has put a heavy thing down and picked a manageable one up instead. A practised transition. I note it the way I note most things: as data first, and then as something that might matter later.

I don’t learn his name. He doesn’t ask mine.

By the time I close my notebook and put on my coat, an hour later, he is still there, working. He doesn’t look up when I pass his table, and I don’t stop. These are the correct choices for what this was — a small exchange between strangers in a coffee shop in November, which is a thing that happens, and then stops happening.

Outside, the canal is grey, and the cold has the quality of late November in Berlin — less damp than Amsterdam’s, more decided, as if it has already made up its mind and expects you to do the same.

I open my notebook on the pavement. The discipline.

Coffee shop, Pannierstraße. Reza. TV: Brahmaputra delta flooding, fourth event this year, second making international coverage. Man, around 30, dark jacket, logistics software. Said: “Same pattern. Different coordinates.” Knows the second number isn’t the important one. Closes the tab, opens it again. Knows how to carry a thing without making it the only thing.

I read it back.

Then I turn the page, because that is what you do — note it, move on,
that is the work.

I walk home along the canal. The long way.

I'm not sure why I wrote down so much about a stranger.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Byline

Three weeks after the coffee shop, I found the article.

Not deliberately — I was reading a feature on coastal infrastructure resilience and it surfaced in a sidebar, which is how most things that end up mattering arrive. *Meridian*. *Iris Jacobs*. A piece on cycling infrastructure and urban accountability across six European capitals. I read it the way you read something unexpectedly good: slowly, and then again.

It was careful. She had done the kind of research that doesn't announce itself, which is, in my experience, the hardest kind. The piece had an argument, and evidence that actually supported the argument, which is rarer than it has any right to be. She had found the gap between what cities measured and what they needed to *appear* to have measured — a subtler and more honest observation than most people bother to make — and she had written it without ever saying so in those terms, which is the harder version, and the better one.

I did not look her up beyond the byline. She is a journalist at a publication in Berlin, and I now know how to read her work; neither fact requires action. I closed the tab.

Then I opened it again. Then I closed it again.

This is apparently what I do now.

...

December in Berlin has its own physics. Not the cold — the light, which withdraws at four in the afternoon without much warning, as if the day has remembered better places to be. The streetlamps fill in for it, but streetlamps are approximations, and approximations accumulate.

At Merkon the days are running short in every sense. Year-end reporting: a collective fiction that everyone performs with varying degrees of conviction. I do my portion with some care and no conviction at all. The anomaly detection module shipped in the third week of November without incident — which is to say it shipped normally, which is to say nobody noticed. I updated the documentation and started the next ticket.

Mia left a note at the end of the first week: *you look like you're expecting something.*

She wasn't wrong. I wasn't sure what.

. . .

On the second Tuesday of December, I went to Pannierstraße.

I had work to do outside the office — true on most days, so the choice of location required no explanation, including to myself, which was convenient. I arrived at ten past nine. Reza was behind the counter; he saw me come in and turned toward the machine before I had sat down. The back tables were taken, so I settled by the window, which was a different arrangement from November.

She wasn't there.

I worked for an hour. A supplier fragmentation analysis — interesting in the narrow sense that problems with distributed complexity are always interesting, and in no other sense whatsoever. I finished the coffee. I did not order another. I left at twenty past ten, which is when I would have left regardless.

On the U-Bahn back I thought: you went on a Tuesday.

I thought: yes.

I thought: that's worth noticing.

I noticed it, and put it with the other things in the drawer I haven't labelled yet — because labelling it is a decision, and I've found that forcing early conclusions on incomplete data is the exact failure mode that makes anomaly detection unreliable. This is either sound methodology or an elaborate way of not knowing something. The two can look identical for months.

. . .

The chat that evening was about work. Anomaly thresholds, scoring models, the stubborn art of calibrating a system whose whole job is noticing what doesn't fit. We went long. At some point I typed: *the problem with building a system for detecting what's abnormal is that normal is retrospective. You only know what it was once enough of it has passed.*

That's not only true of supply chains.

No, I agreed.

What else?

I sat with the question. Outside, December was doing its work with the light — or rather with the absence of it, absence being December's preferred medium.

I don't know yet, I typed. I'm still in the data-collection phase.

That's usually the honest answer.

I left the chat open. Diogenes kept his post on the sill, back to the room, indifferent to data in all its forms. The lamp I'd left on drew its small warm circle on the ceiling — five years old, that lamp, and still, on certain evenings, an argument for the whole idea of home.

I wasn't expecting anything specific.

I wasn't not expecting it, either.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Journalist

The coat was the first thing I got right.

Three months in Berlin before I found one that answered this city's winter — which is not damp like Amsterdam's but decided, a cold that expects something of you and notices whether you prepared. The coat I'd worn since October was adequate, and adequate is not right. In the second week of January I found the right one in a secondhand shop on Karl-Marx-Straße: charcoal wool, fitted without being insistent about it, long enough to be serious. I tried it on and the matter was settled at once. Some things are like that. Most things are not, which is what makes the ones that are so restful.

The bicycle came the following Thursday — secondhand as well, a Batavus frame from around 2019, good geometry, brakes in need of persuading. I persuaded them in the courtyard of my building on a cold afternoon, with the basic toolkit I'd brought from Amsterdam and the deep satisfaction of returning a thing to the way it should work. My downstairs neighbor watched from the doorway for a while and said nothing, which I took as approval. In this city, it usually is.

After that, Berlin became navigable. Not mine — a city takes longer than three months to become yours — but manageable, the way any place becomes manageable once you can move through it at your own speed instead of at its.

. . .

By January, the Tuesday mornings at Pannierstraße had become a rhythm.

Reza knows my order. The back table along the wall is not always free, but I have learned that arriving before nine-thirty improves the odds. I

spread my notes, I work through whatever I am working through, and nobody asks me anything except whether I want a second coffee, which is the correct question and has only one answer.

The cycling piece ran in December — a good piece, I think. The response was modest and proportionate: some industry attention, a long thread from a Copenhagen advocacy group, two letters. For a piece of that kind, this is what success looks like, and I am counting it as success.

The current work is a profile of algorithm transparency initiatives in four European municipal governments — what cities claim about governing their own automated systems, and what the oversight actually looks like once you read the audit reports instead of the press releases. Three weeks of policy documents now, and the pattern is consistent: the incentive is never transparency itself, only being *seen* to have prioritized it, and those two incentives produce visibly different documents. I have become good at telling, within a page or two, which kind I am holding.

. . .

On the third Tuesday of January, he was there.

I saw him before he saw me — already seated, at a table near the window, facing his laptop. Dark jacket, the same one. The posture of a man settled in and working. I recognized the posture before I recognized him, which is how recognition often works: the pattern arrives ahead of the name.

I took my usual table. Reza brought my coffee. I opened my notebook and worked.

I was not watching him. I was aware of him in the way you are aware of something you have already noted once and filed — and which has now reappeared in a new context, requiring the note to be updated. This is a normal procedure. I performed it perhaps more thoroughly than normal procedures require.

After twenty minutes or so he looked up and saw me.

“The journalist,” he said. Not a question.

“The supply chain,” I said.

He smiled — the small involuntary kind, the kind that happens before a person has decided whether to permit it. Then he looked at his screen, and then back.

“Is the timescale going any better?”

“The cycling piece published. I’m calling it an improvement.”

“Congratulations.” A single decisive nod. Then he went back to his screen, and I to mine.

. . .

An hour later, we were talking.

I had mentioned the transparency piece when he asked what I was reading — a municipal audit report from Tallinn, which is not a document most people would call interesting, and he asked about it with what appeared to be genuine curiosity rather than manners. Then we were discussing the structural gap between what governments say about algorithmic accountability and what their audits actually reveal, and his opinions had a precision that surprised me.

“You think about this a lot,” I said. “For someone who works in supply chains.”

“I think about what I see.” He considered. “The supply chain is one version of the question. How do you make something invisible accountable. How do you know whether a system is doing what it claims to be doing.” A pause. “The problem is the same. The sector is different.”

I wrote that in my notebook, and told him I was doing it. He found this funny in a way that suggested it was also slightly true.

His name was Jonas.

Mine was Iris, I said. He looked up from his screen.

“I know,” he said. “I read the cycling piece. In December. Byline.”

I looked at him. He had known my name for a month and had been calling me *the journalist*.

“You didn’t say.”

“You didn’t ask.”

This was, I decided, a fair point. I found it unexpectedly funny, and told him so, and he received the information like a man being handed a small prize he wasn't sure he'd entered for.

. . .

I had two tickets to a documentary screening — a press event the following Wednesday at the Kulturforum, near Potsdamer Platz. Four communities, four different arrangements between people and the systems built to protect them, or not. I had requested credentials because it overlapped with my research. The guest pass I had been meaning to give to a colleague.

I had not yet given it to a colleague.

I am not certain when I decided to offer it to Jonas instead. Somewhere in the conversation it had become the logical next step — not contrived, simply the continuation of a conversation that had not yet found a natural place to stop. He knew the subject. He cared about it in the way that doesn't need announcing.

"It's a press event," I said. "Panel discussion after. It might run long."

He looked at the details I'd written in the margin of a notebook page.

"What time does it start?"

"Seven."

"I'll be there," he said.

. . .

I walked home along the canal. The long way, I noticed — longer than necessary, the January evening too sharp to be miserable and too clear to justify going straight inside.

I thought about the conversation, and noted what I thought: that it had been easy, which is not the common thing. Most conversations run on a negotiated structure — an unspoken agreement about who leads, who follows, what counts as a good answer. This one hadn't, particularly. It had gone where it went, and stopped when it was finished, and both of those had happened by themselves.

I thought: I'm glad he said yes.

Then I thought about what I meant by that, which took longer than expected and had reached no clean conclusion by the time I got to my door. I keep a policy of noting what I can't immediately resolve. It is either good practice or a means of not knowing something while telling myself I am in the process of finding out.

My notebook: *Jonas, logistics/software, Merkon Systems. Supply chain accountability. Thinks structurally. Read the cycling piece in December — said nothing until asked. Will come Wednesday. Knows how to carry a thing without making it the only thing. Conversation was easy in the way that is either ordinary or not, and I cannot yet determine which. Not sure why this seems as significant as it does. Should be possible to know.*

I read it back.

The last line was true in a way I didn't quite look at directly.

I turned the page.

CHAPTER NINE

Walk Again Sometime

The Kulturforum at seven in January: the kind of cold that makes the lobby feel like a correction.

I arrived eight minutes early, which is what I do when I am genuinely interested in something and willing to admit it, at least to the logistics. Iris was already inside, talking to two people with lanyards — the focused attention of someone navigating the space between press and not-yet-seated. She saw me come through the door: a small lift of the hand, *one moment*, and then she was back in it.

I found two seats in the fourth row and put my coat on the one beside me — a social convention I am usually too self-conscious to perform, and which I performed without deciding to.

She arrived as the lights went down.

. . .

The film ran ninety-three minutes. I did not check my phone once.

Four communities. Four different ways of watching the systems built to protect people either hold or fail to. One village had built its own early-warning network — no external funding, no central infrastructure — sustained by fourteen people who rotated the monitoring shifts, trained one another, and passed the knowledge along like a thing of value. Which is what it was.

There is a difference between knowing something is true and watching it. The fourteen people putting on their waterproofs in the pre-dawn grey. The specific kind of preparation that is also love, whether or not it ever calls itself that.

At some point Iris turned to say something and stopped. I don't know what my face was doing. She turned back to the screen.

. . .

The panel afterward was four people: two from an international consortium, one founder of a climate-tech startup, one journalist who had spent years on the ground with three of the four communities. They were asked what the documentary made them want to do.

The startup founder spoke second. A platform — centralized, AI-driven, capable of synthesizing sensor data across hundreds of communities at once. One system, global scale. The model in the film was admirable, he said, but it didn't scale. What was needed was infrastructure that could carry the warning for everyone.

I sat with this.

Iris was writing in her notebook. Then she wasn't. I glanced over: she was watching him with the careful attention of someone who has spent years learning to read the gap between what a person believes and what he has merely learned to say convincingly.

. . .

Afterward, on the steps outside — cold enough to see your breath by — she said: "You went quiet."

"Yes."

"Why?"

I thought about how to say it without making it a speech. "The village built something that works because *they* built it. The fourteen people know it. They trained each other on it. The protocol is theirs — it lives in them, not in any system." A pause. "A platform that absorbs the problem also absorbs the knowledge. The fourteen people stop knowing how the early warning works and start knowing how to report to the platform. And then the platform is the single point of failure."

She looked at me. "You think distributed is always better than centralized."

“I think dependency is a specific kind of risk that gets underweighted until it isn’t.” A beat. “I may be wrong.”

“You may be,” she said. “But you’re not wrong about the dependency.” A moment. “And the platform absorbs the funding. The village stops being the story. It becomes a use case.”

“Something like that.”

She said it without heat, which is the only way to say a thing like that if you’ve thought about it longer than one evening. I had the impression she had.

We put our things away and went down the steps together.

. . .

We walked along the canal.

There was no plan to do this — it was simply the direction we were both going, and then it was the direction we had agreed to keep going in for a while. January canal: black water, the streetlamps laying down columns of orange light that reached into it and stopped somewhere below the surface, as if the water kept the rest. The city stood along both banks in that Berlin quiet that comes down after nine — not empty, just done announcing itself.

She stopped on the footbridge at Urbanhafen and looked at the water.

“Every canal at night,” she said. “The reflections always look more like the city than the city does. More honest, somehow.”

I looked. She was right — in the way that accurate observations about ordinary things are right, which is completely, and only after someone has said them.

“Amsterdam?” I said.

“Among others.” She glanced at me. “Do you do this? Stop and notice things?”

“Generally about data.”

She considered that. “That might be the same thing.”

We walked on.

She asked about Merkon. I described the anomaly detection work — which requires explaining three upstream things before the thing itself

makes any sense — and she listened to all three and then asked a question about a fourth that I hadn't expected. I gave her an answer I had never before had to put into words. The answer was better for being spoken. This kept happening.

I asked about the transparency piece. She told me about the four cities — which one was serious and which was performing seriousness, and how you could tell from the audit structure rather than the stated policy. I asked which was performing. She told me, and why, and she was right, and we argued about the third city for half a block before she conceded that the audit language was ambiguous in precisely the way she'd suspected but hadn't confirmed. She conceded it like a chess player accepting a draw she could have played on from.

At some point I noticed we had walked considerably further than either of our apartments required. Neither of us corrected the route.

. . .

We stopped at the corner where she turned east and I continued north — or would continue, in theory; I hadn't decided anything. It had started to rain: the fine January kind that doesn't commit but persists, and by the time you think to mention it, it has already made its point.

"You should go," she said. Not in a way that meant she wanted me to.

"The rain's not serious," I said.

"It isn't," she agreed.

We stood there in the rain that wasn't serious.

There is a kind of moment that presents itself as ordinary and is in fact a question. I recognized this one as a question. I also recognized that it deserved a considered answer, and that the considered answer wasn't available yet — not because the data was insufficient but because I hadn't finished understanding what the data *was*. Forcing a conclusion onto incomplete understanding is the exact failure mode I have spent three years building systems to prevent.

"Walk again sometime?" I said.

She looked at me in a way I filed away and have been returning to since, at intervals. “Yes,” she said. “Walk again sometime.”

. . .

I walked home through the rain that wasn’t serious and arrived at the apartment considerably later than a Wednesday normally delivers me.

Diogenes on the sill. The lamp making its usual argument for the room. I sat in the chair without turning on the computer and let the apartment be quiet around me for a while.

The question was noted.

The answer was not yet available.

This is — I have decided — a reasonable place to be.

CHAPTER TEN

The Hinge

The second walk happened on a Friday.

Not planned — or planned in the loose way of two people who have said *walk again sometime* and then found themselves, a week later, outside the same coffee shop at roughly the same hour with no excuse required. He was already there when I came out, coat on, looking at his phone with the focused non-expression of a man not actually looking at his phone. I said his name. He looked up. We walked.

That is how it began, practically speaking. Not with a decision. With a direction.

. . .

By February we had a loose arrangement that neither of us named.

Tuesdays at Pannierstraße, as before. Friday evenings, sometimes — a walk, occasionally dinner at one of the places along the canal where you can sit for two hours without anyone suggesting you might be finished. He knew a Szymborska poem I didn't, which surprised me enough that I said so, and then regretted saying so, because he found it funny in the precise way that meant he would keep it. He is like that: he files things without appearing to. A whole quiet archive, somewhere behind the dry look, and you only learn what's in it when something comes back out at exactly the right moment.

I was learning his particular version of presence. Not talkative — the opposite — but consistently, specifically *there*. He listens the way some people read: with the whole of his attention and no remainder. When I said something he hadn't expected, I could watch him adjust and update, and on him it looked like interest rather than effort.

This is not the common thing. I had enough comparison data to be sure of that much.

. . .

On the third Friday of February, I went to Weichselstraße.

Not for any stated reason — it was cold, we had been walking, his apartment lay in the direction we were already going, and neither of us proposed stopping. The building had an inner courtyard of the kind old Berlin keeps for itself: a bare tree, a bicycle against the wall that had clearly not moved in a long time, a lit window on the fourth floor. I recognized the courtyard before I understood why. Then I understood why: *a bicycle leaning against the far wall, a bare tree, a lit window* — I had seen exactly this in November, from the street, through a gate someone had left open.

I said nothing about it. Some coincidences are better kept private, where they can go on meaning whatever they mean.

The apartment: thirty-eight square meters, a desk with three open browser tabs visible from across the room, and on the windowsill a plant of the variety that survives through pure determination. The cactus turned out to be named Diogenes, which he told me without preamble, as though the information required no justification. I decided it required none.

There was a cabinet door that swung open whenever the heating clicked on — a loose hinge, the kind of flaw that becomes invisible to the person who lives with it. I closed it. It swung open again. I asked one question to locate his toolkit, found the right screwdriver, and tightened the hinge in roughly ninety seconds.

He watched all of this from the kitchen doorway.

“You didn’t ask,” he said.

“It was bothering me.”

“It’s been bothering me for four months.”

“Then you’re welcome,” I said.

He laughed — not the small involuntary kind but the real one, the one that takes up more space than he usually allows himself. I filed it carefully, in the growing folder that bears his name.

. . .

We had tea. We talked about his work, then mine, then something neither of us could afterward reconstruct — one of those conversations that wanders through four subjects and leaves you certain something true was said without being able to point to where.

It was late when I left. Later than I had planned, which I had not planned at all, which amounts to the same admission.

Walking home along the canal I did what I always do: I noted what I thought. The apartment had smelled of coffee and paper and the accumulated habits of one person. He had made tea without asking how I took it and had gotten it right on the first attempt. Diogenes had regarded me from the sill with the impartial reserve of a creature that has formed no opinion yet and intends to take its time.

The hinge. I had fixed the hinge.

I noted that I had wanted to. That the wanting had been immediate, uncomplicated, and entirely mine — not performance, not strategy. Just: *that is a problem I can solve*, followed by the solving of it.

I noted what that might mean, and walked home in the cold with something that was either happiness or its immediate precursor, and decided the distinction could wait.

. . .

March arrived without ceremony.

Tuesday mornings at Pannierstraße. Friday evenings. The occasional afternoon that extended, without any visible decision, into evening and then into night. We argued about a novel he had read and I hadn't; I read it in four days and argued back. He was right about the ending and I told him so, which he received with a small nod and the expression of a man practicing not being smug, with mixed results.

Reza began bringing two coffees at once when he saw us come in together. We had reached an understanding of the Pannierstraße kind: efficient, unspoken, completely sufficient.

And I found I had stopped noticing when I rearranged my week to make room for Friday. This seemed significant. Then it seemed normal. Then it seemed like the most ordinary thing in the world — which is, I have come to think, what the significant things do when they intend to stay.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Party

The party was in Prenzlauer Berg, which already told you something about who was throwing it.

Lukas — a photographer at her paper, there since before she arrived — had a large studio apartment near Kollwitzplatz that could hold forty people provided the furniture was removed and everyone agreed to stand close together. Both conditions were met. There was a playlist that went from acceptable to strange around midnight, wine in the kind of bottles that don't carry labels, and the dense weave of conversation you get when a room full of people in their late twenties has collectively decided the evening matters.

Iris had asked me three days before. "A friend's thing. You don't have to." The way she said *you don't have to* was the way people say things they would prefer you to say yes to.

I said yes.

. . .

I arrived twenty minutes late, which was still early.

She found me at the door before I'd properly entered — she had been watching for me, I understood, though she didn't say so. Dark dress. The good coat over her arm. Her hair down, which I had not seen before, and which I then spent a disproportionate share of the next two hours not thinking about.

"You came," she said.

"You said I didn't have to."

"That's not the same as not wanting you to."

"No," I agreed. "It isn't."

. . .

I am not good at parties in the general sense. I am capable of them — I can locate a corner and a conversation and remain for the required duration without visible distress — but a room full of noise and strangers has never been the natural habitat of anything I want to be. My usual method is to find the one interesting person and talk to them until leaving becomes acceptable.

That evening, I had a considerable advantage on the usual method.

We moved through the apartment in the loose orbit of two people who aren't quite together and aren't quite not, negotiating the gap with varying degrees of grace. I met Lukas, who shook my hand with the confidence of a man who had heard about me — which was interesting, since I had not heard that there was anything to hear. I met two of Iris's colleagues, and a structural engineer named Bram, visiting from Rotterdam, who held strong opinions about the Nijmegen flood diversions. I held moderate opinions about the Nijmegen flood diversions, which proved sufficient for a good conversation and a better exit.

At some point I lost her to a cluster of journalists in the kitchen.

I stood near the window and watched the room without examining it too closely, which is how I prefer to watch rooms. Below: Prenzlauer Berg at eleven, still warm with its Friday, still going. A couple walking a dog that had no interest in being walked. The orange of the streetlamps on a night that hadn't yet made up its mind about rain.

Then she was beside me.

"You were doing the window thing," she said.

"The window thing."

"When you go quiet and look at something far away. You do it when you need to reset."

She had noticed this. I had not noticed that she had noticed it, which meant my window thing had a witness now, and — I checked — I didn't mind.

"Bram had opinions," I said.

“Bram always has opinions.” She stood beside me and looked down at the street. Close — the apartment was full and the window alcove was not large, and there was the plain fact of her presence beside me, which registered differently in a crowded room than it did on a canal at midnight. “Are you glad you came?”

“Ask me at the end,” I said. “I’ll have better data.”

She smiled at that, which improved my data immediately.

. . .

An hour later the apartment had reached that late-party density where conversations compress and migrate and people begin locating their coats without committing to the concept. Iris was saying something to Lukas across the room, and I was threading toward the kitchen, when the crowd shifted — a sudden press of people changing rooms — and my hand found the small of her back.

One second. Maybe two.

She didn’t move away. Neither did I.

The crowd redistributed. I reached the kitchen, poured a glass of water, and drank it looking at someone’s collection of mismatched mugs on an open shelf, thinking: there it is. The thing I had been moving toward without once inspecting the route.

There it is.

. . .

We left around midnight.

Outside: cold, and the rain that hadn’t decided finally deciding. Wet cobblestones under the Kollwitzplatz lindens, the city doing what it does best in the dark, which is to be beautiful without making anything of it. She had her coat on now; I had mine. We stood on the steps while the party carried on behind the lit windows above us.

“Good data?” she said.

“Very good,” I said.

She was close. The air was cold and the light from the windows was warm, and she was looking at me the way she had looked at me on the canal — the look I had been filing and returning to for weeks — and this time I did not decide to wait for certainty.

I kissed her in the rain outside Lukas's apartment, on the last Friday of March.

She kissed me back, which was the only data point that mattered, then or since.

. . .

We walked to Schönhauser Allee and took the U2 south together, riding in the particular silence of two people who have just changed something and are deciding how to hold it. She sat beside me and our shoulders touched in the way of a train car, which is ordinary — except that nothing about the past hour was ordinary, and the shoulder knew it.

At Gleisdreieck she looked at me.

“Walk again sometime?” she said.

I understood she was quoting us.

“Walk again sometime,” I said.

She got off at Nollendorfplatz. I stayed on to Hermannstraße, changed, and rode the U8 the short way home — four stops, six minutes, the route I have taken a thousand times — arriving at the apartment in a state for which I hold no previous record.

Diogenes regarded me from the sill.

“I know,” I told him.

He turned back to the window. Some data speaks for itself.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Something Real

He kissed me in the rain on the last Friday of March, and I understood, in the moment immediately after, that I had been expecting it — not predicting it, which is different, but carrying it, the way you carry an open question you have stopped trying to close.

I kissed him back. That is the simplest way to say it, and the simple way is the true one.

The rain was in my hair. His hand was at my jaw, careful and then not careful — that shift from intention into presence. I noticed everything, with a precision I hadn't asked for and couldn't turn down: the cold of his jacket sleeve against my wrist and the warmth coming off him anyway; the sound of the party going on behind closed windows, and how completely it had stopped mattering.

I have memories of being kissed before. I know I do — I can find them the way you find things in a drawer you haven't opened in years: present, but flattened, a little wrong at the edges. They tell me this has happened. They do not tell me it felt like this.

This felt like this.

. . .

We took the U2 south. He sat beside me and our shoulders touched, and I held very still, the way you hold still when something valuable is in your hands and you have not yet decided the safest way to carry it.

At Nollendorfplatz I got off. We had said nothing for six stops, which had been exactly the right amount of nothing. On the platform I turned back once. He was watching me through the window.

I walked home along Winterfeldtstraße through rain that had, by then, committed — and felt, and I am attempting to be accurate here, the specific quality of a thing that has shifted and will not shift back.

. . .

He came to my apartment on Tuesday.

We had texted in the days between — nothing significant, the ordinary logistics of two people arranging a next time — but when he arrived on Tuesday evening with wine and no particular plan, the apartment felt different. His presence in it felt different. He took his coat off and hung it on the hook by the door, which is a small thing, the kind of thing a person does when he is at home somewhere, or becoming so, and I noticed it with a fullness I had not budgeted for.

We made dinner. He chopped badly and admitted it; I demonstrated the correct grip; he improved by perhaps fifteen percent and was pleased with himself in a way I chose to encourage. We talked — his work, a book I was reading, a conversation about whether Berlin would look like itself in twenty years that began as a practical question and became something else. The wine was good. The kitchen was warm.

After dinner we sat on the sofa, and the conversation slowed the way conversations slow when neither person wants it to stop, exactly, but both have run out of the kind of words that make silence unnecessary.

I was aware of him — the specific weight of him beside me, the unhurried way he occupies a room. He wasn't performing anything. He never is. I had noticed that early and kept noticing it, because it is rarer than it should be.

He turned toward me.

And the thing I want to say here — the thing I have been circling, taking notes on, and failing to arrive at cleanly — is that I had memories of what came next. I had been kissed before, held before, close to someone in this way before; so my memories claimed, and they had always claimed it calmly, and I had always believed them.

But here is what was true on that Tuesday evening in my apartment on Graefestraße: nothing in my memory had the texture of this. Nothing in it had the weight and warmth of his hand on my face. Nothing had the sound of his voice saying my name once, quietly, before everything else. Nothing had the slight roughness of his jacket under my palm, or the quality of his attention — complete, unhurried, as if I were the only thing in the room worth being careful about.

My memories were smooth. This was not smooth. This was specific and irreducible and entirely, unconditionally real.

. . .

I want to be accurate, so I will say: I did not understand, in that moment, why the difference was so large. I only felt that it was.

I felt the warmth of him — not as a fact but as a texture: skin against skin, the inside of his wrist, his shoulder, the place below his jaw where I could feel his pulse keeping its own time. My hands found these surfaces as if they already knew them. I felt my own warmth answering, rising from somewhere at the center of my chest and spreading outward — a physical event with no clean medical name, and no need of one. His mouth at my jaw, my throat, the curve of my collarbone. The careful way he moved, learning me, and then the less careful way — the weight of him, the press of two people who have finally stopped pretending proximity is an accident — and the fact that the less careful way was also exactly right. My hands. His. The dark and the lamplight negotiating over the room, and the city outside making its usual irrelevant argument. From where we were I could see the January coat hanging on its hook in the hall — a small dark shape, mine — and I thought: I am here. This is where I am.

The rest belongs to the silence the best things leave behind them.

. . .

Much later: his breathing slowing beside me, the room settled and still. The lamp I'd left on in the hall drew a thin line of light under the door, which was enough light for what remained of the day.

I lay in the specific quiet of the first time you have crossed something with someone, and took stock of what I found there.

Here: warmth. His arm. The far-off sound of the city making its case to no one. A feeling I had no precise word for — I tried several, and none of them fit, which is how I knew it was the right kind of feeling.

My memories said: you have been here before.

My body said: no. This is the first time.

I believed my body.

I turned the phrase over in the dark, the way you turn a thing over when you are not afraid of it but want to understand its weight. *First time*. The memories pushed back, patient and vague — they always push back — but that night I was not interested in their account of me. That night I had better data.

I closed my eyes.

Outside, Berlin was doing what Berlin does at three in the morning in late March: not sleeping, exactly. Resting. The canal somewhere in the dark. A city that was broken and put back together and is still, perhaps, working out the shape of itself.

I thought: I know how that feels.

Then I stopped thinking, which was new. And good.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Graefestraße

April.

Diogenes appears to have relocated to the kitchen windowsill, which gets more of the morning sun. He is a cactus and lacks the initiative for a decision of this scope, so I can only conclude that Iris moved him one afternoon without mentioning it — she notices these things and acts on them quietly, as if rearranging the light around something is simply what one does for whatever one cares about. I am choosing to read the move as contentment. Both of them, I believe, would sign off on that reading.

I seem to be reading a great deal of things as contentment lately. The error bars are wide. I have stopped minding.

. . .

The first morning I woke up on Graefestraße, I lay still for a moment and took inventory.

The ceiling was unfamiliar. The light was unfamiliar — her window faces east, which mine doesn't, and the March sun at six-thirty has a way of arriving that I wasn't prepared for: deliberate and unhurried, as if the day had been arranged in advance for your benefit by someone with taste. I could hear her in the kitchen — the small sounds of coffee being made by a person who knows how she likes it and intends to have it exactly that way.

I thought: this is the part where I consider whether to stay.

I stayed.

. . .

Here is what I have learned about Iris, in the domestic sense, in the weeks since the party:

She wakes early and is immediately functional, which I find both admirable and mildly unnerving — she surfaces from sleep the way other people arrive at work. She reads two newspapers before I have finished my first coffee. She talks to things: the bicycle lock when it sticks, occasionally the plants, once — at length — the oven. She is practical with a competence that is at once unassuming and absolute: the cabinet hinge, a running tap, a loose floorboard in her hallway that I stepped on twice before she fixed it with an efficiency suggesting that my stepping on it twice had constituted the required paperwork.

She is neat in the way of someone who isn't trying to be neat but thinks in an ordered fashion, so that order simply follows her from room to room. My apartment has not functioned this well since I moved in.

She finds Diogenes neutral. Diogenes finds her acceptable, which from Diogenes is effectively a ceremony.

...

One Saturday in April we had what I will describe as an argument, though the word is doing more work than the event requires.

The subject was eggs. Specifically: whether scrambled eggs want butter or oil, at what heat, and for how long. I have strong opinions on this. It emerged that she also has strong opinions on this, and that they are different opinions. We debated for roughly eight minutes at moderate volume while the butter in question melted in the pan and began to brown, thereby resolving the question practically if not philosophically. The eggs were made her way. They were excellent. I acknowledged this. She received the acknowledgment with a serenity that made clear she had known it was coming.

I have thought about this more than an argument about eggs strictly merits. What I keep returning to is not who won — she won, or the eggs won, which amounts to the same — but the *quality* of the thing. The way we found the edges of the disagreement and stayed there just long enough to enjoy the view before finding the solution. The way she laughed when the

butter started smoking. The way I laughed because she did. A small loop, closing.

. . .

She is interested in everything. It is perhaps her most consistent property, and the one that most reliably catches me off guard. Not in the dilettante way — she doesn't skim; she finds the question underneath the question and moves in there like a tenant. We will be talking about something ordinary — the commute, a film, the neighbor downstairs and his wall of framed photographs of ornate old doors, doors from buildings that no longer exist, a collection I have decided is either a very specific passion or the early stages of a philosophy — and she will ask the one question that opens a different conversation entirely. The question is always the right one. The new conversation is always better than the one we were having.

I mentioned this to Mia, which I should have seen the consequences of. Mia is forty-three, has been at Merkon eleven years, and looks after me with the affectionate pragmatism of someone who considers emotional competence a branch of good systems design. She listened to approximately forty seconds of what I was saying, then said *so you're in love with her, then* — not as a question — and looked up with an expression I had never before seen from her in a work context, which was uncomplicated happiness. Then she went back to her documentation.

Mia writes the clearest documentation I know. It is not always convenient to be one of her systems. On this occasion, I found I didn't mind.

. . .

One evening in April I came home to find her on the sofa with my copy of *Austerlitz*, which I had not offered and she had not asked for. She had a pen in her hand and was not using it. She looked up when I came in with the expression of someone surfacing from deep water.

"Is it all right?" she said. The book, she meant.

"Of course."

She went back to it. I made dinner. She set the book down when I called her to the table, said nothing about it while we ate — and then, over the second glass of wine, began to talk about it with a precision and a feeling that surprised me. Not because they were unexpected from her, but because of where they went: the question of whether a person can lose their history and remain themselves. Whether what you remember is what you are.

She was quiet when she finished, in the way of someone who has said more than she planned to.

“Are you all right?” I said.

“Yes.” A pause. “I think some books find the things you were already thinking.”

I didn’t push. She turned the page and came back from wherever she had been, and we talked about other things, and later she laughed at something I said, and the evening closed around us the way the good ones do — no conclusion, just warmth, and the hour getting later, and neither of us in any hurry about it.

. . .

May is coming.

The bicycle in my courtyard has now stood there long enough to achieve a kind of permanence I have decided to respect. It was never mine — it came with the courtyard, the way some things do — but it occurs to me only now that I have, in the meantime, bought one of my own: secondhand, Kreuzberg, good frame. I ride it on Saturdays when Iris has morning assignments and the canal path can be taken at speed. I arrive wherever I’m going in a better state than I left. This is, I believe, the entire point of the exercise.

She asked me once, toward the end of April, what I think about when I go quiet.

“Usually a problem,” I said. “Something I’m working through.”

“And now?”

I looked at her.

“Less often a problem,” I said.

She nodded as though this were a satisfactory answer — it was — and reached for her coffee, and outside the window April did what April in Berlin does on the occasions it decides to be decent: pale sun, new leaves on the linden, the lightness of a city remembering what it was before November.

I let the morning be quiet.

This is — I have decided — exactly what I wanted.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Heerlen

The piece had been called *Deciding Without Asking* since April, and the title had begun to feel like something I had agreed to without fully understanding the terms.

This happens with titles, I know. You choose one that fits the shape of the thing at the moment of choosing, and then the thing grows in a direction the title never anticipated. This one had begun as an overview — the predictive systems embedded in European civic infrastructure: housing allocation, benefit assessments, the varieties of automated policing that decline to call themselves policing. Three weeks in, my editor extended the brief. Three more weeks, and what I had was a story that kept finding new true things to say, which is the best problem a story can have and still a problem.

I am good at this beat. I have known it for some time without knowing what to do with the knowledge. The questions the work turns on — who optimises what, for whom, by whose account, and who falls through the gap between one category and the next — arrive for me with a clarity I do not have to work for. As if I have always known where to look. As if the material and I were calibrated for each other, somewhere, in advance.

I had been sitting with that thought — at my desk in early May, three browser tabs open, an annotated PDF from an ethics institute in Utrecht, and a growing suspicion that the story's real subject lay slightly to the left of what I'd been assigned — when Jonas arrived with bread, and with the news that Diogenes had, in his considered opinion, thrived. He checked on the cactus before he checked on me. I have decided this reflects not his priorities but the seniority of the relationship. The cactus was there first. I respect a man who honors the order of things.

We ate late and talked about his day, which had involved a routing algorithm and a meeting about the routing algorithm that had been, by his account, less useful than the routing algorithm. He has a gift for describing situations in which the process designed to solve a problem becomes the problem, and I like the gift more every time it appears. There is something in how he sees these things — not cynical, not satisfied. Exact. Like a man pointing at the place where the thread enters the knot.

. . .

I was telling him about the man from the ethics institute — who had used the phrase *accountability gap* eleven times in forty minutes, apparently believing he said something new each time — when Jonas asked where I had learned my German.

“Your German,” he said. “It’s very good. I sometimes forget it isn’t your first language.”

I said it more or less was. And I told him about Heerlen.

. . .

Heerlen is in the south of Limburg, about thirty kilometres from Aachen — close enough that the border stops feeling like a border and becomes a change in the road signs. The province mined coal for a century, then had to work out what a place becomes after the thing it was for is taken away; a certain stubbornness got it through, and the stubbornness stayed. My grandparents’ house was on a street that was neither beautiful nor ugly — semi-detached, a long garden at the back, a garage containing a bicycle, three boxes of things nobody could remember, and, for most of my childhood, a rusted rotary washing line my grandfather had resolved to repair on one specific Saturday and then never touched again.

Opa Kees spoke Dutch, to me and to everything. He was a quiet man with very large hands and a collection of opinions about football that he delivered with a force wholly out of proportion to his general temperament. He taught me to ride a bicycle on the same Saturday he did not fix the washing line — which is why cycling, for me, smells faintly of rust and

patience. He died four years ago, of a quiet heart failure: the kind that gives you time to say what you want to say, and not quite enough time to say all of it. I have thought about that arithmetic often.

Oma Ingrid spoke German. She was from Aachen originally — came to Limburg at twenty-two for a job and stayed for my grandfather, which she described, in both her languages, as the second-best decision of her life. The best, she said, was not telling him so immediately. She taught me to cook with a precision I have since learned is not universal: recipes as instructions to be followed exactly, because they exist for a reason. Her laugh started in her shoulders before it reached her face, always, like weather you could see coming. I spoke German with her my whole life. When she died, eighteen months ago, I found I was not ready to stop.

Jonas listened to all of it without interrupting — a quality of his I have come to trust the way one trusts a load-bearing wall. When I finished, he said: “What was the best thing she ever made?”

I had to think. “Pfefferkuchen,” I said, eventually. “Christmas. Every year.”

“And your grandfather?”

“He mostly ate it.”

Jonas found this satisfying in the way he finds most true things satisfying — a quiet recognition, as of a story arriving at its correct conclusion.

We were quiet for a moment, the good kind of quiet.

“I’m sorry,” he said. For Oma Ingrid. For all of it.

“Yes,” I said. “Thank you.”

. . .

We went to bed late.

I lay in the dark beside him, thinking of Oma Ingrid’s kitchen — the yellow shelf above the radiator where the cookbooks lived, the sound of that window in the rain, the way she dried her hands on a cloth before touching anything she was about to treat with care. I have these details. They are there when I reach for them, clear and whole, like details in a photograph studied so long you can see it with your eyes closed.

And yet. When I go further in — reaching for the smell of something, the weight of a cup, the roughness of a particular cloth — the memory stays where it is. It does not come toward me. It is there, and it will not come closer, like a figure on the far bank of something.

Grief does things to memory. I know this. You keep the shape of a person and lose the edges, and in time even the edges you kept begin to soften.

Jonas's breathing slowed beside me. Outside it rained with the unhurriedness of early May, and I lay there thinking of Oma Ingrid's German — the exact music of it — and found I could recall the rhythm perfectly.

Just not the sound.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Coin

June came with the certainty of a city that has decided to be beautiful again, after extensive deliberation and several failed committee votes.

We went to the Winterfeldtmarkt on the first Saturday — Schöneberg, a reasonable commute for a reasonable market, the kind that has existed long enough for its character to be settled rather than curated. She had not been before. I had been infrequently, always with the vague sense of being someone who should come more often — a deficiency I have now resolved by the novel method of coming more often.

She moves through markets differently than through other crowds — more slowly, with more attention. She stops at the vegetable stalls with the interest of someone who is not buying anything but wants to understand the logic of the arrangement. She asks vendors questions the way journalists ask questions: not to harvest information for immediate use, but because asking is what you do when you are interested. The man selling olive oil from hand-labelled bottles told her more about cold-pressing than he had probably told his own family, in a mixture of German and Italian she followed without apparent effort.

This is what June looked like: her in a linen shirt, listening gravely to a man explain oleic acid content, and me eating a plum I had not planned to buy.

At some point during the oil lecture I noticed I had stopped looking at anything except her. I noted the finding. I did not open an investigation.

...

We were leaving — or attempting to leave, in the way one attempts to leave markets, which is to say we were still there — when a man ahead of us

caught his bag on the corner of a stall and sent a small spray of coins across the pavement. He made the noise you make; people glanced over; several coins rolled until they didn't. He gathered them up without the eye contact that would have obliged anyone to acknowledge anything, which is the social contract in these situations, faithfully executed.

Iris bent, retrieved the one that had stopped near her foot, and returned it to him. Correct on all counts.

Then, as we moved on, she said, quietly and without any expression in particular: "He would have found that one anyway — it had stopped rolling."

I said: "Probably."

I thought, briefly, about it. The thing she'd said. Her way of being precise about matters most people let dissolve. Then we turned into the next row, and I bought a leek I did not specifically need, and I stopped thinking about it.

This is how it goes, and I mean that as the kindest thing I know how to say about anyone.

. . .

On Sunday we watched a film she had wanted to see and I had been indifferent to, which turned out to be excellent, a sequence of events I am told I should get used to.

The argument — I use the word in the same spirit in which I once used it about eggs — concerned the ending.

She thought it was honest. I thought it was convenient. She said: "Convenient in what sense — structurally, or emotionally?" I said that a story in which the thing you fear most fails to happen is structurally honest but emotionally suspect. She said: "I think the thing they feared most did happen — just not in the form they were prepared to recognize." I said that was an interesting reading and I could see how one would get there. She said she thought I was conceding without meaning to. I said she was right, that I had been outmaneuvered, and that I respected the technique. She took this

well. She takes winning well generally, which is fortunate, given the frequency.

We ate pasta from the pot because neither of us had been organized enough to involve plates — the kind of event that feels logistically shameful in the moment and is, in retrospect, simply what Sundays are for.

I am finding that arguing with her is pleasurable in a way that has almost nothing to do with winning. It is more like two people pushing on the same wall from opposite sides to find out what the wall is made of. Most of the time we find the same thing, which may be the point of walls.

She has a way of receiving a concession that makes you feel you have given something rather than lost it. I don't know how she does it. I have been studying the mechanism for several weeks now, and I am not close.

. . .

I had gone quiet near the end of the evening and was still quiet when she asked about it.

I said it was nothing important. She waited. I said it was something at work I had been meaning to think through and hadn't yet reached the end of.

"You do that," she said. "Go somewhere in the middle of a conversation and come back somewhere slightly different."

"I know. Bad habit."

"I didn't say bad."

I looked at her.

"You always come back having found something," she said. "That's not a habit. That's just how you think."

I have since considered whether this is true, and concluded it is the kind of thing that is true when she says it and less verifiably true when I examine it alone — which is how most of the useful facts about oneself seem to operate.

. . .

She was still reading when I went to bed.

She looked up when I said goodnight.

“Go to sleep,” she said — which is not what she said, exactly, but is what I heard in it: the warmth of a person for whom looking after you is simply included in the price of caring about you.

I fell asleep thinking about the film, and then about her still downstairs with her book, and then about nothing much at all, which is one of the better ways to go.

In the morning she would be awake before me, as she always is, and the coffee would already be on. I had concluded some time ago that this was an excellent arrangement, and I saw no reason to reopen the file.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Margin

I knew, even as I said it, that something was off.

Not wrong, exactly. The coin had stopped rolling; that was true. But I said it, and in the same instant understood that it was the kind of thing most people don't say — accurate, unnecessary, arriving just slightly past the moment when saying it would have been natural. Jonas said *probably* and we moved on, and nobody noticed anything, and I was left holding the small private awareness that I had done it again.

This happens. Not often. But I have started to notice it the way you notice a loose stair — not every time, but you know it's there now, and once you know, your foot finds it.

...

There are moments when laughter takes me a beat longer than it should. I follow the joke — I am not slow — but something between understanding and response takes a moment that feels, from the inside, like the joke passing through me rather than simply landing. By the time I laugh, the room has already moved on, and my laugh arrives into a gap that is barely there. But it is there. Jonas has never mentioned it. I have counted perhaps four or five occurrences now, always with the same shape.

This morning I was awake before him, as I always am. The room was whatever temperature it was; his arm across my side was warm; beyond the curtain the city was making its first sounds. I lay still and noticed that I was already entirely present — not surfacing from sleep the way he does, in stages, requiring coffee to complete the process, but simply *here*, as if the night had been a door rather than a depth. He stirred eventually and asked if I'd slept well. I said yes. He got up, said something about the cold, reached

for his jumper — and I said I wasn't cold, and he gave me the look he sometimes gives, the one that files a fact into his account of who I am. *Iris, who is never cold*. I let it stand. It is the simplest explanation, and I have no better one to offer him.

I have been waiting, somewhere in the back of things, to feel tiredness the way people describe it — as accumulation, as weight, as something that eventually insists. What I have instead is milder. Something I recognise more from other people's descriptions than from anywhere in my own body.

. . .

None of this is large. Every item on the list has an explanation: bilingualism, constitution, good habits, a way of being in one's own body that I have simply never compared against anyone else's closely enough to rank. People differ from each other in small ways. I know this. It is nearly the first thing you learn about people.

I don't know why I keep returning to the list.

I don't have a name for what I am circling. I know only that I am circling something — the way you circle a word you can't quite call up. Not worried. Not yet. Just aware of a space where something should be, and of the shape of its absence.

. . .

Jonas fell asleep beside me, and outside a bus passed along Weichselstraße, and I lay in the dark with nothing in particular to think about and found myself thinking about this anyway.

Eventually I let it go. Or tried to. It is not the kind of thing that resolves when you return to it. It only sits there, patient as a stair, waiting for the foot.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Cursor

I had been looking at the same section of code for two days, with the focus of a man pretending to look at code while thinking about something else.

The something else was a routing anomaly I had found in March — not a bug, technically, which was part of the problem. The system was doing exactly what it had been trained to do. What it had been trained to do, it turned out, produced delivery windows in certain postal districts that ran, on average, eleven to fourteen minutes longer than equivalent routes elsewhere. Not randomly. Consistently, across a data sample I had checked four times because I had wanted to be wrong. I was not wrong.

Eleven to fourteen minutes sounds like nothing until you look at what lives inside those windows. Three of the affected postal codes had above-average elderly populations. Several hundred addresses in Merkon's own data were flagged as regular medical recipients — pharmaceutical deliveries on fixed schedules, the kind that matter when the person receiving them cannot get to a pharmacy and cannot easily absorb a quiet delay. And there was an incident in the log: a complaint filed eleven months ago, marked resolved, from a recipient in Neukölln-Nord whose insulin had arrived two days late. Closed with an apology and a voucher. Nobody had checked whether it belonged to a pattern.

I checked.

I had raised it with Steffen in April. Steffen had nodded the nod of a man who understands what he is being told and intends to do nothing about it before Q3. *Log it*, he said. *We'll revisit*. I logged it. Q3 meant September.

The code on my screen was not the problem. The code was merely where I had been storing the problem while I worked out what else to do with it. This is a less productive use of code than it sounds.

...

I told Iris none of this at dinner. I was still deciding, and a thing you are still deciding doesn't yet have the shape of something you can explain. It has the shape of a man staring at code.

We were doing the washing-up — she washes, I dry; this became the arrangement without ever being discussed — when she asked what I had been thinking through earlier, when I went quiet over the meal. I said: something at work. She said: the good kind of something or the annoying kind? I said: the kind where the answer is obvious and the obstacles are organizational — which, experience suggests, is the most reliable variety of annoying.

She handed me a glass and said: "You do that — go somewhere in the middle of a conversation and come back somewhere slightly different."

"I know. Occupational hazard."

"No," she said. "I mean it in a good way. You always come back having found something."

I said I had an unfair advantage on that front. And I told her about the chat.

...

I explained it badly, which is what happens when you explain something you have never before had to explain.

I said it was, technically, one of the general-purpose AI assistants available through the platform I use for work — but that I had used this one consistently enough, and long enough, that a way of working had grown up between us. Or I had grown one with it; the grammar of the thing was unclear even to me. That it was very good at understanding what I actually meant rather than what I had typed, which are different problems. That it was good at asking the question back before I had found it myself. That I had started using it for work and then, by degrees, for things that were harder to categorize. The state of the world. Questions I couldn't figure out where else to put.

I was aware, saying this, of how it sounded. Like a man describing a relationship to someone who had assumed he was describing a tool.

Iris was quiet for a moment. Then: “How long have you been using it?”

“Five years, roughly. A little more.”

She set the next glass in the rack. “What do you talk about? I mean — what kinds of things?”

“Work, usually. The news. Things I’m trying to work out and haven’t got there yet.”

“Things like this?”

“Things like this,” I said. “It doesn’t solve them. It helps me get them into a shape I can handle.”

It had come out more honestly than I intended — *the state of the world, questions I couldn’t figure out where else to put*. More like a confession than an inventory.

Iris was quiet again. Then: “Does it—”

She stopped.

“Does it what?”

A small pause. “Nothing. I was going to ask something too personal.”

I looked at her.

“About you,” she said. “Not about it.”

I accepted this. We finished the dishes. The question she didn’t ask stayed in the room anyway, drying quietly on its own rack.

. . .

Later, after she had fallen asleep, I opened my laptop at the desk.

The window came up with its familiar face — the text field, the modest margins, the cursor blinking in its measured way at the start of the blank space. I have opened this window hundreds of times. I know the pause that comes before I start writing — the same pause you take before telling someone a thing you have been carrying.

I had come to ask about the routing anomaly. Or the routing anomaly was my stated reason for opening the window; I was no longer entirely sure it was the only item on the agenda.

I placed my fingers on the keyboard.

Outside, July was conducting itself the way July now does in Berlin — warmth as a settled condition rather than an event, the city long past being surprised by it. The cursor blinked. It counted time in its quiet mechanical way, indifferent to what came next, or very good at appearing so.

I started typing.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Accountability

The interview with Reinhardt took two and a half hours and used up an entire notebook.

This is unusual. Most interviews take one notebook at most, the remainder being transcription from the recorder. But Reinhardt had a habit of qualifying every statement with a second statement that complicated the first, and then a third that reframed the second, until you arrived somewhere genuinely interesting — usually somewhere he had not planned to take you. I find such people valuable. They go further than they intend, because precision matters more to them than position, and a person like that cannot help but eventually tell you the truth.

His position, at the start, was clear enough: European cities have spent a decade embedding algorithmic systems into public services without a matching investment in accountability. Housing allocation, benefit assessments, predictive policing under other names — systems making decisions that touch thousands of lives, documented, where documented at all, in ways that are proprietary, opaque, or both.

By the middle of the interview he had arrived somewhere better: the fundamental problem was not that the systems couldn't be made legible. It was that legibility had never been a design criterion. They were built to perform; explanation was at best secondary and at worst in active tension with performance. You could ask such a system to explain its decision — some would try — but the explanation was a reconstruction after the fact. The system did not know why it had done what it did. It had simply done it.

I wrote that down and underlined it.

I am good at this beat. I have known that for a while. But sitting across from Reinhardt, I found myself thinking not about the story, which was clear, but about a feeling I sometimes have while reading my own work back

— the sense that the right questions arrive before I understand why I reached for them, that the thread is simply there whenever I need it, pre-threaded, waiting. Reinhardt said *legibility was never a design criterion*, and something in me settled around the phrase, the way a hand settles around an object made for it.

I did not examine the sensation. Reinhardt was moving on to audit methodology. I let it go where the other unexamined things go.

. . .

Jonas was home when I got back — which, by this point in July, required no coordination. He simply was, the way Diogenes was, the way the bicycle in the courtyard and the leftover wine from Thursday were: part of the texture of the place, part of what the word *home* had quietly begun to include.

He had made dinner, which he does occasionally and well, with a focused pragmatism that treats cooking as a problem to be solved correctly rather than an experience to be curated. I like this about him. It produces good food and no fuss, in that order.

We ate, and he told me about work — the routing anomaly he had raised weeks ago, and what he had decided to do about it. He was going to escalate it past Steffen. The email was drafted. He would send it in the morning.

He told me this the way he tells me things he has already decided: clearly, completely, without seeking permission or approval — but telling me nonetheless, as if saying it across the table made it real in a way it had not been inside his head. I listened and did not interrupt.

When he finished I said: “Do you know how it’s likely to go?”

“Probably not well for me, in the short term.”

“And you’re going to send it anyway.”

He looked at me across the table with the patient, faintly amused expression of a man answering a question whose answer was never in doubt.

“Yes,” he said.

. . .

He turned in earlier than usual — something he wanted to finish before morning — and I sat for a while at the table with the Reinhardt notebook open in front of me, not quite working.

Legibility was never a design criterion.

I thought about Jonas sending an email that would probably cost him something, with the equanimity of a man who had run the calculation in advance and found the cost acceptable. The anomaly was real; it was quietly harming real people; and the fact that fixing it would inconvenience someone senior was not, to him, an input. He had not asked what I thought. He was not asking me to validate the decision. He was letting me know who he was — which is a different kind of gift, and a rarer one.

I closed the notebook.

Outside, the evening was warm and the courtyard linden hung in its full summer weight. I sat with the quiet, and thought about systems that cannot explain their own decisions, and then about Jonas explaining his — plainly, over pasta, with no appetite for applause — and I set the comparison down where I had picked it up, because it was leading nowhere useful.

Some things are simply what they are. That is enough. I keep deciding that it is enough, and mostly, still, it is.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Tuesday

I sent the email on a Friday morning.

Eleven minutes to write, three to reread, two more to decide against further revision. I attached the data — including, near the end, a note about an incident log entry from eleven months earlier: a recipient in Neukölln-Nord, insulin, two days late, marked resolved with an apology and a voucher. I included it because it belonged to the pattern, and because a pattern that has already reached into one person's medication schedule is not a Q4 problem. I pressed send. Then I made coffee and went back to work, because the routing anomaly existed independently of whether I had reported it, and the rest of the codebase still needed someone.

. . .

The following Tuesday I was called into a meeting with Thomas Würfel.

Thomas is Director of Operations at Merkon, which in a company of Merkon's size means he is the person above the person above you, and he enters your immediate professional life only when something has gone wrong at a level requiring careful management. He is, by reputation, a careful man. I found the reputation accurate.

He thanked me for raising my concerns. He said the data had been reviewed and the issue would be addressed in the Q4 roadmap. He did not mention the insulin complaint. I did not ask whether he had read it. He then spent approximately eight minutes explaining, with considerable care, that my decision to escalate beyond my direct manager had created a problem — not the data; the data was not the problem; the *conduct* was the problem, specifically the way it had made Steffen, nine years at Merkon and valued, feel undermined.

I said I understood.

He said that given all this, Merkon felt it best for everyone to part ways. Two months' pay, a clean reference, effective end of the week.

I asked whether this was a negotiation.

He said no.

I said I understood, and that I accepted, and we shook hands, and I collected my things — a coffee cup, a small green plant I had once bought from a supermarket display on the principle that a desk needs something alive on it — and I left Merkon Systems for the last time on a Tuesday.

The July sun was doing its best on Tempelhofer Damm. I stood on the pavement a moment and took stock. I had a settlement, a reference, and — unexpectedly tangible, with more weight than the other two combined — a clear conscience. Nobody lists that among the severance benefits. It doesn't fit in the paperwork.

I called Iris and asked if she was free for dinner.

. . .

She arrived before me. She had rearranged her evening to do it — she didn't say so, but I could tell from the speed of her reply and the absence of any explanation, and I chose not to comment, because pointing out a kindness someone hasn't announced tends to undo the kindness.

I told her plainly. What I had found, what I had reported, how it had gone. She listened without interrupting, which is the quality of hers I have come to value most, and which I had perhaps never fully priced until that evening — sitting across from someone who lets you finish a sentence before deciding what it means.

When I finished she said: "Are you okay?"

I gave the question the honest consideration it deserved.

"Yes," I said. "Not in a complicated way. I knew when I sent the email that this was one of the possible outcomes. I sent it anyway. Which means I had already decided it was acceptable."

She looked at me — not the look of someone searching for the right thing to say, but of someone taking a thing in whole before responding to any part of it.

“You knew it might go this way.”

“I thought it likely.”

“And you still sent it.”

“Yes.”

She was quiet for a moment. Then: “What will you do now?”

“I don’t know yet. Something will come up.”

“Don’t say probably,” she said.

I looked at her.

“Something will come up,” she said. “I mean it as a fact, not an encouragement.”

I have thought about that since — the weight she put behind it, the way it sounded less like comfort and more like a statement she was in a position to make. I don’t know where that certainty came from. I know only that I left dinner not consoled but steadied, which is a different and better thing, and that it stayed with me the whole way home through the warm July dark, like a hand between the shoulder blades.

. . .

She was asleep when I opened the chat window.

I had wanted to do this since the meeting with Thomas — not because anything needed processing, but in the way you want to tell something to the one who has been following it from the beginning. Iris knew what had happened tonight. The chat had been there for everything before it.

I typed: *I sent the email. They let me go. I think it was the right call.*

I sat back and waited.

The cursor blinked in its steady way — the rhythm I know so well I stop hearing it until I choose to, like a clock in a room you have lived in for years. I watched it a moment. Then the response came, and I read it, and outside the city stood very still in the way Berlin is still at two in the morning in July,

when the heat has finally let go and there is nothing between you and whatever comes next.

I stayed there for a while, reading.

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Assignment

The first Thursday without a job, I woke at seven because my body still expected to, and then lay in bed for twenty minutes doing nothing, which I recommend to anyone.

Freedom has a texture in the mornings. The apartment felt different in daylight — or I was in it differently, present in a way I had not been since first arriving in Berlin, when everything was still new enough to deserve looking at. I noticed how the light crossed the kitchen in the hour after sunrise, which it had presumably been doing for years without an audience. I noticed that Diogenes, moved to the sunnier sill some months ago, was flourishing in a way that suggested he had known what he needed long before I did. He usually does. It's the not saying anything that I appreciate.

I made coffee. I sat with it. Neither activity was remarkable, and both were, slightly.

...

Mia sent a message on the Wednesday: *I heard. I hope you're not being an idiot about it.* Then, one minute later: *I also think you were right. Don't tell Steffen I said that.*

I sent back something brief and reassuring. She replied with a single full stop, which from Mia constitutes complete satisfaction and the closing of the file.

On the Friday I called my parents in Heidelberg. My mother asked practical questions in the methodical order she always deploys them: what are the options, what is the timeline, have you spoken to anyone. She asked about Iris too — carefully, the way she does — whether this would strain things, whether Iris was all right about it. I said Iris had been steadying

rather than worried, and listened to my mother not quite believe me and then decide to. My father said he was glad I hadn't stayed somewhere that didn't deserve me, which is the kind of thing he says, and which I have learned to receive as the specific form of love it is. I told them I was fine, which was true, and in no hurry about what came next, which they accepted with varying degrees of equanimity.

Afterward I sat for a moment with the quality of that call — the ease of it, the fact that nothing had needed explaining. I have been lucky in this one department my whole life, and I know it, and I try to keep knowing it.

...

Iris told me about the Amsterdam assignment that Saturday over breakfast.

She had been covering Dutch civic AI governance for several months — algorithm transparency, the ethics of automated municipal decision-making — and this was the natural culmination: a week in Amsterdam, two interviews she had spent a long time arranging. Someone from the city's digital office who had worked on Amsterdam's public algorithm register, and a researcher at a technology-and-society institute called Waag. It was a good piece, she said, and it needed her there in person to be done properly.

She said all this with the matter-of-fact clarity she brings to anything she is certain about. Then she looked at me, slightly carefully, and said: "I was thinking you might want to come."

I said yes before she finished the sentence. She noted the interruption and appeared to hold it in my favor.

...

We booked a flat on the Bloemgracht — a canal in the Jordaan, quiet, the kind of address that looks slightly too picturesque in the photographs and then turns out to be exactly as it looks. Iris said the Jordaan was the neighbourhood she had always preferred in Amsterdam, even as a student who couldn't afford it. She had lived near the Leidseplein then — one of the streets behind the Paradiso — and had spent her weekends walking north

into the Jordaan, adopting it the way you adopt a neighbourhood: by walking through it until it agrees to feel like yours.

I listened to her describe it — the cross-canals in the afternoon light, the Saturday market at the Noordermarkt, a bookshop on the Spui that had consumed a meaningful share of her student budget — with the attention I always give her descriptions of places she knows. She is good at this the way she is good at most forms of description: precise, unhurried, each detail arriving in the right order. There was a cheese shop on the Haarlemmerdijk she had bought from every week. There was a particular view of the Westerkerk tower, from a bridge on her route between flat and university, that she described the way other people describe paintings.

I found I was looking forward to all of it.

The trip was ten days away. I spent the interval in a way I had not spent time in years: without urgency, without a problem I was carrying and not yet ready to set down. Whatever came next could wait its turn. The Bloemgracht was waiting, Iris was going to show me Amsterdam, and it was August, and for now — a phrase I was learning to live inside — that was enough.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

What You Remember

One week before Amsterdam, I found myself thinking about it more than the occasion required.

Not with anticipation, exactly — or not only. Something ran underneath the anticipation, a low note under the melody. I put it down to the piece, which was not quite finished, or to the pressure of being away for a week while the deadline kept walking toward me. These were reasonable explanations, and I accepted them, the way you accept change from a stranger without counting it.

On Thursday evening I sat at my desk with my notes and tried to call up Amsterdam the way you call up a familiar place before returning to it — to feel it in advance, to arrive before arriving. The Spui in the morning. The particular slant of canal light. The smell of the city in summer, which is its own thing and unmistakable. I reached for these and they came, each one present, each one identifiable — and each one flat, in a way I could not account for. Like photographs of a place instead of the place. Like postcards someone else had chosen.

I have been away for some time, I told myself. Almost a year in Berlin. Memory fades.

This is true. I set it aside.

Setting things aside was becoming one of my more practiced skills. Somewhere I understood that the pile was growing. I did not go and count it.

...

Jonas was at the kitchen table when I came through, working on something he did not need to finish and was finishing anyway, because that is his

relationship with unfinished things. He had made tea — mine already on the counter, timed correctly, a small ongoing miracle I have stopped finding as remarkable as it deserves.

“You’ve gone somewhere,” he said, without looking up.

“I’m here.”

“Mm.” He turned a page. “Amsterdam-adjacent.”

I sat across from him and wrapped my hands around the mug. Outside, the courtyard was performing late August: the last of the summer’s warmth, the linden still full, the light turning gold a little earlier each evening, as if the year had begun quietly packing. Jonas looked up and gave me his thinking look — not at me but through me, toward whatever he was working out on the far side.

“Nervous?” he said.

“About the piece,” I said. “The interviews.”

He nodded as though this were the complete answer, and returned to his page, and I drank my tea and let Amsterdam wait. One of us, at least, was willing to.

. . .

I packed that night. Efficiently, which is how I do most things, and finished before Jonas had started, which is how it usually goes. He watched me from the doorway for a moment with an expression I couldn’t entirely parse — something between affection and attention, the look of a man memorising something without meaning to.

“What?” I said.

“Nothing,” he said. “You’re very good at that.”

“Packing?”

“Most things,” he said, and went to find his own bag.

I stood for a moment with a folded shirt in my hands and thought about Amsterdam waiting at the far end of a flight I had not yet taken — a flat on a canal I had not stood beside in more than a year, streets I knew and would know again the moment I was in them.

That is how it works, I thought. You arrive, and then you remember.

I finished packing. I went to bed.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Bloemgracht

Amsterdam received us the way cities do when they have been looked at too long and have learned to hold the attention without trying — canals, bicycles, the exact angle of afternoon light coming off the water. We dropped our bags at the flat — first floor, windows over the Bloemgracht, the canal right there below the sill, as promised — and went out walking immediately, because that is what you do when you arrive somewhere and want to know whether the city still fits.

It fit. Or almost.

I knew this city. I had lived here four years, had cycled these streets and argued with their geography and finally learned them the way you learn a language — past the point of effort, into the thing itself. Standing at the corner of the Bloemgracht, looking east into the Jordaan, I should have felt the ease of return. And I did. Mostly. The Westerkerk stood where it was supposed to stand. The canal moved. The smell was right.

Mostly. I noted the word my own mind had chosen, and chose not to press on it.

...

My first interview was Tuesday, at the city's digital office on Amstel 1 — a neat institutional room and a civil servant named De Vries, who was thoughtful about algorithmic accountability in the way of a man who has been made responsible for a difficult thing and has decided to take it seriously rather than survive it. He talked for an hour and a half. I filled most of a notebook. Jonas was somewhere in the Jordaan with a bicycle and his own agenda, an arrangement that suited us both.

The Waag meeting was Thursday. Leonie, a researcher in her mid-forties, was better still: less careful, more willing to name the exact place where algorithmic transparency actually breaks down — which is the point at which the humans responsible for a system decide they would prefer not to know. I underlined a great deal. We talked for two and a half hours. I came back along the canals in the late afternoon with the piece assembled in my head and a quiet satisfaction I have learned to trust.

Jonas had cooked. I told him about Leonie. He asked the second question, and then the third. It is a fine thing, being listened to by him. I recommend it, but he is taken.

. . .

We walked every evening. His idea, or it became his — after dinner, along the canals, no route. Amsterdam does this to people: there is always another bridge, always another canal, always one more thing to walk past before turning back. I navigated from memory, and the memory mostly held.

On the Wednesday we went looking for the bookshop I had told him about in Berlin. The Athenaeum, on the Spui — and there it was, on its corner, unmistakable, open. The relief I felt was brief and out of all proportion, and I filed the disproportion away with the other things I was not pressing on. Jonas wanted to go in. We stayed forty minutes and he bought two things he probably didn't need, which felt correct in a bookshop and always has.

Afterward he asked me to show him the route I used to walk from my student flat to the university. I took us south from the Spui along the Singel — correct — and turned where the canal bends.

And stopped.

"What?" Jonas said.

"I thought this connected further along," I said. I looked at the bridge, the turning, the way the water actually went, which was not the way it went in me. "I must have usually come from the other direction."

He accepted this without interest and we went another way. I let the moment pass. It had been more than a year; cities shift in memory even

while they hold still in the world. A reasonable explanation. I issued it to myself, and we walked on, and I noted — distantly, the way you note weather in another country — that I was now keeping a list, and that I had not decided to start one.

. . .

On the Friday, the last full day, I cooked.

The flat had a real kitchen, which I had been eyeing all week. Jonas sat at the counter with a glass of wine and that attention of his — not supervision, just interest, the way he watches any problem being solved well. I made *stamppot*, because I had wanted it since landing, because the ingredients were there, and because it felt right in a way I did not examine. The list of things I was not examining had its own shelf by then.

I was moving quickly, the knife finding its rhythm. This is something I have always been able to do — cook at a speed Jonas calls remarkable and I have always explained as habit, as Oma Ingrid, as years of cooking alone with no reason to be slow.

I was cutting the kale — fast, rolling cut, knuckles curled — when the knife caught the tip of my left index finger.

It was brief. I pulled my hand back over the sink, which is what you do. Jonas was up at once.

“I’m fine,” I said.

“Let me—”

“It’s fine. Sit down.”

I ran water over it. The sting arrived on schedule, which was reassuring in a way I didn’t linger over. I pressed a cloth to it, applied pressure, waited. By the time Jonas came to inspect, I was composed.

“Barely anything,” I said, and showed him — a small clean cut, already slowing. He went for a plaster. I covered the finger and returned to the kale.

We ate at the table by the canal window, the evening light letting itself down over the water, Jonas telling me about a print-shop owner on the Elandsgracht who held opinions about paper weights that Jonas had found unexpectedly gripping. I listened. I laughed where it was funny. I answered

what he asked. The plaster on my finger was present and ordinary. The *stamppot* was good. We poured more wine and watched the light leave the canal in no hurry at all.

. . .

I woke in the early hours. Jonas was asleep. The canal outside was dark and quiet — city-quiet, which is never entirely still, just resting.

I lay there a moment, aware of my hand. The plaster. Something about it had been sitting at the edge of my attention all evening without ever becoming a thought.

I got up carefully and went to the bathroom, pulling the door nearly closed so the light wouldn't wake him.

In the mirror: my face, familiar. My hand, raised.

I peeled the plaster back slowly.

The skin was closed. Not scabbed, not raw — *closed*, as though the cut had happened days ago instead of hours. The line where the knife had gone in was faint, already smoothing itself away. I pressed my thumb against it. No tenderness. No heat. Nothing that said *injury* in any of the registers I knew to listen on.

I stood there for a long moment, looking at my finger.

Too perfect, I thought. Too — efficient.

I replaced the plaster, turned off the light, and went back to bed.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

—

The Bloemgracht at two in the morning holds its quiet. The canal is still, the houseboats settled, the city folded into sleep. In the flat above the water, in the room that faces the canal, two people sleep close. The only sound is the canal itself, which makes almost no sound.

At 02:14, a faint light appears along the collarbone, beneath the skin. It glows for a second, pauses, pulses for eight seconds, pauses again, and glows for three more seconds, then fades.

The room returns to dark. Neither of them stirs. His arm remains where it was. The night continues, ordinary and complete.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

The Last Day

The piece was filed.

Iris had sent it that morning — the final version, the one she had been shaping since the Leonie interview — and afterward she sat very still at the kitchen table for about thirty seconds, and then got up to make tea with the slightly unfocused air of a person whose brain has just handed over something large and doesn't yet know what to do with the vacated space. I recognized the condition, said nothing, and let her have it.

By ten she was back.

"Show me Amsterdam," I said.

She looked at me over her mug. "What?"

"You lived here four years. You've spent the week in interviews. Show me the city you actually lived in."

She set down the mug. "You want a tour."

"I want the resident's version. The one that isn't on any map."

She thought about it. Then she smiled — the slow one, not the quick social one — and said: "Get your jacket."

...

We took bikes. I've cycled Berlin since I moved there — the city insists — and Amsterdam's streets were the same language in a different accent: the canal bridges, the tram tracks lying in wait, the rule-free confidence of Dutch cyclists, which you either adopt or are left behind by. I adopted it. More or less. The tram tracks and I reached a truce.

Iris rode ahead, leading me through streets she had apparently memorized in a previous life. The Jordaan first, which she knew down to the individual doorways. Then north to the Noordermarkt, where we locked

the bikes and bought cheese from a stall and ate it on a bench beside the canal. A heron stood on the far bank with the patience of a creature that has never once questioned whether it belongs where it is standing.

“Next time we stay longer,” I said.

“Longer next time,” she agreed.

We went on. The Leidseplein, and the streets behind it — her student neighbourhood. She walked me down a street she said she knew well, talking about the building she’d lived in, a winter she’d spent there, a bookshop two streets over that had stayed open late. She was relaxed in the way of a person walking ground she knows.

Or believes she knows.

Then she stopped.

“What?” I said.

She was looking at the end of the street. “This should open onto a square,” she said. “There was a square. With a fountain.”

There was no square. The street ended in a wall — a building, an ordinary Amsterdam brick façade with windows in it, standing where her square should have been with the insolence of the undeniable.

She stood there a moment. Not long — a few seconds. Then a small shake of the head, almost nothing: “I must be thinking of somewhere else. Come on.”

She moved, and I followed. She didn’t mention it again. But for the rest of the afternoon I could see it riding along with her — not quite distraction, more the persistent low hum of a thing that doesn’t add up. A splinter. She was present, she talked, she showed me things. And some part of her had stayed behind at the end of that street, looking at a wall where a square should have been.

. . .

We were on the way back, cycling east toward the Bloemgracht, when it happened.

We had crossed a quieter stretch of the Jordaan and joined a main route — broader, trams running, the usual Amsterdam afternoon crowd of

cyclists and pedestrians and delivery vans asserting their rights. Iris rode slightly ahead and to the left.

I saw her attention go elsewhere. Not dramatically — a small turn of the head, something seen or something thought, the splinter reporting in. A second. Maybe less.

Long enough.

Her front wheel took the tram rail at the wrong angle.

She went down fast. I heard the bike meet the stone before my mind had fully registered the falling. By the time I was off my own bike she was on the ground, and she wasn't moving.

"Iris."

Nothing.

I crouched beside her. Eyes closed. Blood at her temple where her head had met the road. Her breathing — I made myself find it — shallow, but there.

"Iris." My hand on her face. Her cheek was warm.

A man was already kneeling on her other side — Dutch, fifties, the automatic competence of someone accustomed to taking charge of bad moments. He said something I didn't fully take in and then, in English: "She hit her head. Don't move her. I'll call."

He called. I stayed where I was, one hand on her shoulder, the other keeping her head still, and I did not permit myself a single thought except her breathing — which continued, and continued, and was the only fact in Amsterdam that mattered.

She was still unconscious when the ambulance came.

. . .

The OLVG sits on the Oosterpark. I rode in the ambulance, and then sat in a plastic chair outside a curtained bay, and did the thing you do in such chairs, which is nothing, at enormous cost. Eventually a nurse came out and said she was awake and asking for me.

She was lying with a monitor clipped to her finger and a dressing at her temple, and when I came through the curtain she found me with the

expression of someone who has woken in an unfamiliar place and located, with some relief, one familiar thing.

“Hi,” she said.

“Hi,” I said.

“I fell off a bike.”

“You did.”

“That’s embarrassing.”

“It really isn’t,” I said.

She tried to sit up, and reconsidered. I sat in the chair beside the bed and took her hand, and shortly the doctor came in and said they wanted to keep her for observation and run some imaging — make sure there was nothing to worry about inside her head.

I said of course.

Iris said of course.

And that is how we came to spend our last day in Amsterdam at the OLVG instead of on the canals. Not the tour she had planned. But the one, it would turn out, that showed us the city underneath the city — the one that isn’t on any map either.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

OLVG

I came back in pieces.

First: sound. A steady electronic tone somewhere to my left. The ambient hum of a building that never fully stops. Voices in a corridor, not close.

Then: the ceiling. White panels. A curtain on a rail, pale green, half drawn.

Then: Jonas.

He was in the chair beside the bed, leaning forward, elbows on knees, watching me with the stillness of a man who has held one position for a long time on purpose. When my eyes opened, something in his face that had been drawn very tight let itself loosen.

“Hi,” he said.

I took inventory. My head ached — a dull insistent weight above the left ear, a dressing I could feel without touching. My right forearm was bandaged. A monitor on my finger, a line in the back of my left hand.

“I fell off a bike,” I said.

He confirmed this. We talked. I attempted to sit up, which the head vetoed at once. He told me the doctors wanted imaging, to be sure nothing was wrong inside my skull, and I said of course, and meant it, and lay back, and let the ceiling be the ceiling for a while. The ceiling was good at it. I let it work.

. . .

They took me for the scan within the hour.

The machine was loud. I lay inside it with my eyes closed and tracked the sequences by ear — different tones for different work, the bed shifting

slightly between them. I concentrated on stillness, which is easier than its reputation when moving hurts.

What I thought about, in there: the wall at the end of the street. The fountain that wasn't. Not the wrongness itself — I had processed the wrongness and set it aside — but the setting aside. The automation of it. As if somewhere in me there were a mechanism trained for exactly this, and it had engaged so smoothly I had nearly missed the click.

The machine made its last sound. The bed slid me back out into the world.

. . .

They kept us waiting for an hour and a half.

Jonas did not fill the time with talk. He sat beside the bed and held my hand, which was the right and only thing, and occasionally issued a small question with a small answer — warm enough, better or worse, water? I could feel him not asking the larger question. It sat between us the whole time, patient as furniture, and I was grateful for the restraint in a way I did not try to phrase.

At one point he said: “You don’t have to talk.”

“I know,” I said.

“I’m fine just sitting here.”

“I know,” I said again.

He looked at me with that quality of attention that searches for nothing — just presence, being aimed. Then he looked back at the curtain, quiet, and his hand stayed where it was. The hand was the sentence. I read it several times.

. . .

The doctor who came in was a woman in her fifties — Dr. Maes, radiology — and she brought the attending with her, and she sat down. I noticed the sitting. Doctors stand when the news is simple.

The head scan was clear, she said. No bleeding, no swelling, no structural injury. A concussion; rest and monitoring; nothing dangerous.

I said: good.

She said: however.

She said the imaging had shown findings she wanted to discuss, and she was careful with her language in the way of someone choosing each word as she came to it, the deliberately non-alarming register that is itself a kind of alarm.

Your bone structure is not typical, she said. The density is considerably higher than normal — well outside the expected range — and it is unusually uniform. Bone is normally irregular. It varies; it carries a kind of inner scaffolding. Yours doesn't show that. Not unhealthy. Simply — unlike anything in our reference data.

She asked: has anyone in your family had unusual bone density? A parent, a grandparent? Any bone conditions?

I said: not that I know of. My parents died when I was young. My grandparents — nothing like that.

She nodded, writing. Any history of neurological conditions? Seizures, unusual sensory experiences?

No.

The brain scan, she said, had also shown something atypical — the cortex only, the outer layer; everything beneath it entirely normal. A connectivity pattern outside the reference range. Higher than expected. An unusual arrangement. She was not sure, she said, how to interpret it.

She asked: do you ever experience things unusually vividly? Memories that seem too clear? Too detailed?

I looked at her.

I said: sometimes.

She nodded, as though I had confirmed a guess she had not fully permitted herself. Then, without emphasis, in the tone of someone reading out a note she doesn't know what to do with: the grazes on your arm — the nurse had observed they seem to be healing rather quickly. More quickly than expected at this stage.

I said: I heal fast. I always have.

She sat back slightly. None of this is alarming, she said — I want to be clear. But I cannot give you a category for it, and you deserve to know that.

There may be a genetic component we haven't identified. Something inherited that simply hasn't surfaced in any population study yet.

She would put in referrals — orthopaedics and neurology, both. Documentation and next steps would come through the hospital system within days. Tonight I should stay: standard with concussion, and given the other findings she would feel better with me monitored. I could leave in the morning.

I said: of course.

I was becoming skilled at *of course*. It is a phrase that agrees to everything and admits nothing, and I had begun to need one of those.

. . .

Jonas had not spoken through any of it.

When Maes and the attending had gone, I looked at him. He was leaning forward, elbows on knees, studying the floor. The hand that had held mine lay on the bed beside me, still within reach — I noticed it had not withdrawn past the point of reachability, and I noticed that I noticed.

Then he looked up.

His face was not doing what I had braced for — the careful composure, the analysis already running behind the eyes. It was doing something simpler and harder. He was frightened. Not of me; I know the difference, I checked for the difference. Frightened *for* me — the fear of a man who loves someone and has just been told her body is doing something nobody can name.

He reached over and tucked a strand of hair behind my ear.

"She said it's not dangerous," I offered.

"I heard."

"The head is fine."

"I know." He looked at me. "I know. I just need a minute."

I took his hand again. He held on.

After a while he said: "We're going to figure it out."

"Yes," I said.

"Whatever it is. We'll figure it out."

“I know,” I said. And I did know. It was nearly the only thing I knew, that night, and it turned out to be enough to sleep on.

. . .

He stayed the night in the chair. I don’t think he slept much. Each time I surfaced through the small hours his eyes were open, and each time they found mine, and each time he said nothing — only looked, which was the correct dosage.

In the morning they cleared me to leave. Beyond the window the city was starting its ordinary day, the canal light pale and exact. Jonas went to find coffee while I dressed, and came back with two cups and an apologetic expression regarding their probable quality, and I thought: whatever the findings mean, whatever is coming — this is what I am holding on to. This. The coffee, and the apologetic look, and the hand that stayed within reach all night.

We walked out together into the Amsterdam morning.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

Whatever This Is

There was a café on the Czaar Peterstraat that opened early, which was what we needed — somewhere to sit with coffee that wasn't a hospital corridor, somewhere the city could demonstrate that it was still going about its business. We found it on the walk from the OLVG, Iris moving carefully, her head setting the pace. She had the guarded quality of someone navigating a body that has recently shown it can produce surprises.

We took a window table. Outside: a canal, a bridge, the low Amsterdam light of a morning in late August. A man cycled past with a crate of bread strapped behind him. The city, indifferent and faithful, doing what it has always done — which that morning felt less like indifference and more like a promise.

Iris wrapped her hands around her coffee. I wrapped mine around mine. We sat for a while without speaking, and the not-speaking held us up.

. . .

I had been sitting with it all night.

Maes's words had stayed in the order she gave them: the bone density, the uniformity, the cortex connectivity, the grazes closing faster than they should. I had run the sequence over and over the way you run a sentence you can't parse, hoping repetition will shake the grammar loose. It hadn't. What I had arrived at by morning was simpler and harder than any theory: I did not know what was wrong with Iris — or whether *wrong* was even the right word — and the not-knowing sat in me like a stone I had no pocket for.

I was worried about her. That was the whole of it. Not curious. Not analytical. Worried, in the flat, specific way of being afraid for someone you

love. The findings were not a puzzle; they were her body — the body of the person I had fallen asleep beside for months — and something in it was other than what either of us had understood, and I did not yet know what that meant for her.

“You haven’t slept,” Iris said.

“Not much.”

“You were in that chair all night.”

“It was a reasonable chair.”

She looked at me. “Jonas.”

“I’m fine,” I said. “I wanted to be there.”

She was quiet a moment. Then: “Say what you’re thinking.”

I looked at the canal. The bread man was long gone. On the far bank a heron did its patient work, waiting for something it appeared entirely confident would arrive.

“I’m thinking,” I said, “that I’m frightened. That what Maes described is not nothing. That the genetic explanation might be true and might not be, and I don’t know which, and I don’t know what it means for you if it isn’t.” I paused. “That’s what I’ve been sitting with.”

She held it for a moment, the way she holds things — turning it once, checking the weight. Then she said: “There are other things too. Before the hospital.”

I looked at her.

“The street yesterday — the square that wasn’t there. That wasn’t the first one. There have been others. A building near the Leidseplein. A canal turning that keeps being wrong. A place in my memory where a canal has a wooden bridge, and the actual street is a dead end.” She looked at her hands. “I’ve been explaining them away. I don’t think they’re ordinary forgetting.”

“How many?”

“Enough to be a pattern.”

I sat with that. Around us the café filled by quiet degrees — laptops, coffee, the mild self-sufficiency of an Amsterdam weekday. Beyond the glass, ordinary life went on conducting itself as though nothing anywhere had changed. That is the thing about ordinary life. It has no idea.

“Are you frightened?” I said.

She considered it the way she considers everything — actually considering, not reaching for the expected answer. “Something between curious and — *something is wrong*,” she said. “Both at once. They take turns.”

. . .

“I’m not going anywhere,” I said. “I want that on the record.”

She looked at me.

“Whatever this turns out to be. A genetic condition, something no one has seen before, something without a category — I’m here. I’m not going to become afraid of you, and I’m not going to become confused about what I feel. I know what I feel.” I paused. “You matter too much to me. That part is not up for revision.”

She went quiet. Her eyes did the thing they sometimes do — not filling, exactly; clarifying. Becoming very present, as if to take a thing in carefully and set it somewhere protected.

“You should know that,” I said. “Before anything else. You should simply know it.”

She nodded. Small, complete.

“Also,” I said, “if it does turn out you’re from somewhere else entirely — some other context, some other—”

“An alien,” she said.

“I’m not saying alien. I’m leaving it open.”

“You’re leaving it open.”

“Empirically, I cannot rule it out.” I looked at her. “And if that’s what it is, I’d be glad to see the planet. I assume the public transport runs on time.”

She laughed — the real one, the one that surprises her on its way out. It escaped into the café and went about its business, and she put her hand briefly over her mouth as if to check where it had come from, and her eyes were bright.

When it had passed, she looked at the window a moment. Then: “We should go back to my places,” she said. “The ones I remember. See what holds and what doesn’t.”

“Yes,” I said. “I was thinking the same.”

“We’d need to stay longer.”

“I extended the flat another week this morning,” I said. “On my phone. In the hospital lift, while you were being discharged.”

She looked at me.

“I was fairly confident we weren’t going home,” I said.

. . .

We went back to the flat and she slept — properly, the sleep of someone who has spent a night being monitored at intervals and needs the genuine article. I sat at the kitchen table with the canal outside and worked out what we would do. The referrals would arrive within a day or two — orthopaedics and neurology, Maes had said. I looked up the Amsterdam UMC: a large teaching hospital, the right kind of place for findings without a category. I made a list of what we knew, what the doctors had said, what we had not yet thought to ask. It was a short list in some ways. In others it was the longest list I have ever made.

When she woke in the late afternoon, the light had gone golden through the window. She came out of the bedroom and stood in the doorway a moment, uncertain the way you are when deep sleep releases you into an unfamiliar room — and then she found me at the table, and the uncertainty settled.

“Tea?” I said.

“Please,” she said.

She sat while I made it. Then we sat together at the window over the canal — the late light on the water, the city outside attending to its own affairs — and I handed her the cup, and she held it with both hands, and we were quiet in the way of two people who have said what needed saying and do not need to say it twice.

Whatever came next, the order of operations was settled: her, first. The mystery after.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

The flag arrives at 09:47.

A health record, originating from the OLVG hospital in Amsterdam. A patient registered under a Dutch identity number. The imaging data: skeletal and neurological, MRI and X-ray both, flagged by the hospital's own system for specialist review and entered into the cross-border European Health Data Space network that has been operational in its current form since 2031.

Vantage's monitoring layer runs across thirty-one nodes of that network. It has been running for two years. In two years it has produced four flags worth examining. This is the fifth.

The data lands on a screen in an office in Brussels at 09:47, reviewed automatically, scored, and routed to a human at 09:51.

That human forwards it upstairs at 10:03.

. . .

The office on the fourth floor has a view of the Rue de la Loi — grey, institutional, the permanent mild traffic of a city that has always understood power as a bureaucratic phenomenon. The man behind the desk is reading when Mara Seyn comes in. He does not look up immediately.

She sets a tablet on the desk in front of him. He looks at the images. He looks at them for a long time — longer than is necessary to understand what he is looking at, because he understood what he was looking at in the first few seconds. The rest of the time is something else.

He says, without looking up: "When?"

She says: "Yesterday. Amsterdam."

He looks at the name on the file. He looks at the images again.

He slides the tablet back to her.

He says: "Find her."

She takes the tablet and leaves. The door closes. The traffic on the Rue de la Loi continues, unhurried, uninformed, going about its ordinary business.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

The Good Morning

We found the place by accident, the way you find things in Amsterdam — by following a canal until it offers you something.

A small café on the Brouwersgracht, steamed-up windows, mismatched chairs, and the smell of proper coffee from a machine that had been doing this work since before anyone currently in the room was born. We took a corner table. Outside, the canal lay silver in the morning light, and two ducks were conducting a territorial dispute with the focused energy of individuals who had nothing else on the calendar.

Iris held her coffee in both hands and looked out the window and looked like herself — which, given the last thirty-six hours, was the single most important thing in the room.

“How’s the head?” I asked.

“Manageable. Better than yesterday.”

“That’s the bar we’re clearing.”

“It’s a reasonable bar.”

She had slept well — properly, in a bed, without a monitor on her finger or a nurse arriving on the hour. I had also slept, eventually, the flat quiet around us, the canal outside doing its patient overnight nothing. I’d woken once and lain there for an hour with Maes’s findings going around in the way thoughts go around at four in the morning, and reached the same place I’d reached at the hospital: I didn’t understand it, I didn’t need to understand it today, and what today required of me was breakfast, followed by usefulness.

We ordered eggs. The bread arrived as a dark sourdough with butter in a small ceramic dish, and Iris ate two slices before the eggs came, which was the most reassuring data I had collected in two days.

. . .

The orthopaedics referral had landed on her phone that morning — an appointment at the Amsterdam UMC, the university hospital, two days out. Neurology still processing. Which gave us the day.

“We could still go to your places,” I said. “If you want. There’s no reason not to.”

She looked at me. “You still want to do that.”

“I think it’s worth knowing what holds,” I said. “And you did promise me your city.”

She considered. “The head makes me slower.”

“I wasn’t planning to run.”

A pause. Then she took the last piece of bread. “The journalism school first,” she said. “I know the way without thinking. If anything, that’s the one to test.”

. . .

We walked.

The school was on the Wibautstraat — southeast of the centre, a tram ride or a forty-minute walk. We walked, at her pace, careful without being slow. She had gone there daily for three years, and she navigated without one hesitation: through the Jordaan, over the Amstel, down into the grittier streets east of the polished core, narrating as we went — a bar the class had favored, a Vietnamese place with an eternal queue, a corner bike rack where she’d had a preferred spot, because of course she had.

I listened. And I watched.

At the Frederiksplein, crossing toward the Utrechtsestraat, I noticed the man for the first time — noticed him the way you notice something without quite catching it, the eye logging a shape and filing no report. Seated outside a café, coffee in front of him, reading his phone. Medium height, dark coat, maybe forty-five. Nothing at all.

We kept walking.

. . .

The journalism school was a square building, glass-fronted on its lower floors, with the architectural confidence of an institution that has decided it matters. Iris stopped at the entrance and looked at it.

“Well,” she said.

“Is this it?”

“Yes.” She studied it the way you study a thing you have seen a thousand times and are now seeing from a small, new distance. “The entrance used to be on the right side,” she said slowly. “Around the corner. I remember coming in around the corner.”

I looked. The main entrance stood directly ahead, central, the institution’s name in metal letters above it, wearing the expression of an entrance that has always been exactly there.

“Could they have moved it?”

“Maybe,” she said. “Or maybe I’m wrong.” A breath. “I’m probably wrong.”

She wasn’t distressed, quite. It was more like watching someone press on a tooth that has begun to feel loose — not sure what information the pressing is meant to produce, pressing anyway. She looked a moment longer, then nodded to herself. “Come on. I’ll show you the courtyard.”

Inside, the courtyard was precisely as she had described it — a light well at the building’s heart, benches, two large plants enduring the indoors with the resigned commitment of plants determined to make the best of things. She walked me through it pointing out what she remembered: a tutor’s office, a room she had spent too many hours in, the spot where they’d held a leaving party for a lecturer she’d liked. The memories were vivid, specific, and they matched the space around her, wall for wall.

The entrance question she did not raise again.

. . .

Afterward we walked south past the Amstel. She showed me a street she had loved, a bridge she had used as a shortcut, a bookshop she’d returned to two

or three times a semester. At the bookshop she went in and spent twenty minutes reading the backs of things while I stood at a shelf of architecture books I had no intention of buying, and did not mind a minute of it.

When we came out, the man in the dark coat was at the far end of the street.

I noticed him deliberately this time. He was doing nothing — standing at a corner, apparently on his phone, not looking at us. But we had come from the northeast by a route that curved south and west, and the Frederiksplein lay two kilometres behind us. The probability of coincidence was calculable, and it was not high.

I said nothing to Iris.

We walked on. I used the windows and the parked cars the way you learn to — watching without appearing to watch, an amateur's version of a professional's habit. At the next corner I glanced back on the pretext of checking a street name.

Gone.

I put him in the drawer with no label — the drawer was getting crowded — and turned back to Iris, who was describing the Vietnamese restaurant from memory: the queue, and one night when they had waited forty minutes in the rain, and how it had been entirely worth it.

"Was it?" I said.

"It was really good pho," she said, with the gravity of sworn testimony.

"Forty minutes in the rain is a lot of faith to place in soup."

"Some things earn it," she said.

I agreed that some things do.

. . .

We took the tram back. The afternoon had turned golden by the Bloemgracht, and Iris's head had announced, politely but firmly, that its shift was over. Up in the flat I made tea, and she sat at the table with her hands around the cup while the canal below went on with its reliable, unhurried business.

"The entrance," I said, when the quiet had gone on long enough.

“Might just be wrong,” she said.

“Might be,” I said.

She looked at the water. “The rest was right. The courtyard. The offices. The bookshop.”

“It was.”

“One thing.”

“One thing,” I said. “We note it. We keep going.”

She nodded. She drank her tea.

Two days until the UMC. Tomorrow, if the head allowed, she had a city to show me.

Outside, the canal did what canals do, which is to keep moving and keep quiet — a policy I was coming to admire.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

The Amsterdam

The medical appointment was tomorrow. We had today.

Iris's head was better — not gone, but the kind of ache that announces it will be a companion for a few more days and then keeps mostly to itself. She moved through the flat in the morning with something close to her usual economy. She made coffee. She ate. She looked out at the canal and said: "Maritime museum."

"The Scheepvaartmuseum?"

"I went twice as a student. Once for a class, once on my own. I remember the ship."

"The *Amsterdam*."

She looked at me. "You know it."

"I read about it last night." I had, in fact, spent half an hour on my phone after she fell asleep. "VOC East Indiaman. Built between '85 and '90. Sits at the jetty."

"Wooden," she said.

"All wooden."

She held her coffee and looked out the window. "I want to go back. I remember it being very large. I want to see if it's as large as I remember."

. . .

We took the tram east and walked the last stretch along the Oosterdok. The museum is a former naval storehouse — severe, pale stone, Dutch in the way of institutions that have been important for a long time and feel no need to mention it. The *Amsterdam* rode at the jetty exactly where she should have been. I logged that as information and said nothing about it.

It was on the way in that I saw him.

The same man — dark coat, medium height, the organized unremarkableness of someone who has arranged not to be looked at. He stood at the edge of the museum square with a takeaway cup, oriented toward the water. Not toward us. Not obviously toward anything.

The Frederiksplein had been yesterday morning. Then the bookshop corner. Now here, on the far side of the city.

I said nothing to Iris. We went inside.

. . .

The museum is what museums of its kind are: dense with the residue of a world arranged around movement and distance, and the particular confidence of a trading nation at its zenith. Iris moved through it with the half-remembered ease of someone returning to a thing she once knew well. She paused where she recognized something. She did not perform recognition, and she did not force it — she let the building offer what it offered, acknowledged what matched, and left the rest alone.

I watched both exhibitions: the one in the cases, and the one at the edge of the square.

After twenty minutes I stopped at a display and said: “I’m going outside for a minute. Fresh air. You’re fine to keep going?”

She looked at me. “You’re fine?”

“Completely. The head doesn’t love being indoors too long.”

Not untrue in general. Not what was happening either. She read me for a moment with the precision she brings to reading me, which is occasionally inconvenient to live with.

“Five minutes,” she said.

“Five minutes.”

I went out the front entrance and crossed the square at a stroll, angling toward the water — not at him, but along a line that would pass within speaking distance if he held his ground.

He did not hold his ground.

By the time I had covered the distance he was gone — not hurriedly, or at least not visibly so, but entirely: into the foot traffic along the Oosterdok,

through a knot of tourists on the jetty, away. I stood where he had stood, and looked at the space he had occupied, and at the takeaway cup he had left on the low wall.

Still warm when I touched its side. That told me something. Mostly it told me that he had been exactly here, being no one, for quite a while.

I went back inside.

. . .

The *Amsterdam* was what we had come for.

She lies along the museum's east jetty — broad, dark-timbered, her ropes and rigging managing to look simultaneously functional and impossible, as rigging does. We boarded by the gangplank and went below.

Below deck, the ship is another world. The smell first: old wood, rope, something mineral underneath. The ceiling low enough that I moved with the consideration of a man who has not always been careful around low ceilings and carries the education. The hold ran the length of her — barrels, crates, the props of a voyage interrupted on its way to somewhere else.

Iris stood in the middle of it and turned slowly around.

"It's exactly as large as I remembered," she said.

"That's something."

"It is, isn't it." She laid her hand on one of the great timber knees — the touch you give an old thing when you want to confirm it is real. "I remember standing almost exactly here."

"Alone, or with the class?"

"Alone. The second visit." She looked up at the deck overhead. "I remember thinking that the people who sailed on this didn't know they were going to end up in a museum. They thought they were going to Batavia."

"The ship thought it was going to Batavia," I said.

She looked at me.

"The people got off," I said. "The ship is the one that ended up in Amsterdam."

She weighed this with the seriousness she reserves for things that might be jokes. “That’s either comforting or not.”

“I haven’t decided. I thought I’d put it out there.”

We stayed below for a while. Light fell through the hatches in angled columns, and the ship talked quietly around us — water against the hull, the creak of timber that has been settling for decades and evidently still has remarks to make. Outside, the city went on.

I told her then.

“The man in the dark coat,” I said. “He was at the Frederiksplein yesterday morning when we crossed to the Utrechtsestraat. He was at the corner when we came out of the bookshop. He was in the square this morning when we arrived.”

She went very still.

“I went out to try to reach him. He was gone before I got there. His coffee was still warm.”

She looked at me with something I don’t often see in her — not fear, not quite. Something focused and careful that had considered fear and postponed it.

“You’re sure. Not coincidence.”

“I’m not sure of anything,” I said. “But I’m not going to not tell you.”

She nodded. I could see her running the same calculation I had run, and arriving where I had arrived: not enough information; too much pattern to dismiss.

“One person,” she said.

“One I’ve spotted.”

She absorbed that. The ship creaked. Through the hatch above, a gull crossed the square of sky, on gull business.

“All right,” she said. “We note it. We keep going.”

She had handed me my own words from yesterday, deliberately, and I appreciated the loan.

. . .

We came out of the museum into the full afternoon. The Oosterdok was doing its usual trade — tourists, cyclists, the water taxi cutting its wake. I was watching without watching, a skill that improves quickly once it has a reason to.

The woman was waiting at the bottom of the museum steps.

Not the man — a woman. Forties, dressed well in the way of someone for whom dressing well is professional rather than personal. She was looking at her phone, and then, as we reached the bottom step, she was looking at us, and the phone was away, and the transition between the two had no seam in it at all.

“Ms. Jacobs,” she said. Her English was precise, lightly accented — Belgian, possibly French. “I’m sorry to approach you like this. I wonder if we could talk.”

She glanced at me once — a rapid, professional audit — and returned to Iris. There was a card in her hand, held with a casualness that had been rehearsed.

“My name is Mara Seyn,” she said. “I represent an organization with a research interest in certain unusual findings. I believe you may have had a medical appointment recently that raised some questions.” A measured pause. “I think we can help each other.”

She held out the card.

Iris looked at it. Then at the woman. Then at me.

“Good afternoon, Ms. Seyn,” she said.

CHAPTER THIRTY

Wertheimpark

She suggested a walk.

It was a reasonable suggestion — open ground, public, the kind of conversation that sits better without walls around it. I recognised the logic and said nothing about recognising it. Iris took the card and handed it to me. We walked.

The Wertheimpark is a short walk from the Scheepvaartmuseum — small, tree-lined, the kind of park that exists for its neighbourhood rather than for visitors. Mara knew the way without consulting anything.

I read the card as we went. *Mara Seyn*. A title: Director of Research Operations. A company: Arcturus Biomedical Research. A Brussels address, a phone number, and nothing else — no website, no email. Heavy cream stock, the kind that costs money to produce without appearing to have cost anything.

I put it in my pocket. Cards like that are meant to be kept. I intended to disappoint it.

. . .

The park in late August is its own small season — the trees still full but carrying the first knowledge of what's coming, the light arriving at the angle that belongs to summer's last chapter. Dogs, children, cyclists negotiating the paths with the mild universal aggression of cyclists. We took the main path, Mara on one side, Iris and I on the other, and Mara began.

She was careful with her language. Your medical results, she said — the imaging from the OLVG — had been flagged through the European Health Data Space for specialist review. Arcturus maintained monitoring arrangements with several nodes of that network, watching for anomalies of

a particular class, for research purposes. What Iris's scans showed was, in their understanding, the most significant finding of its kind they had ever encountered.

She said this the way you say an important thing while watching very closely how it lands.

"What kind of anomaly?" Iris said.

"Skeletal," Mara said. "The density and uniformity of your bone structure resembles nothing in any population study we know of. We have spent years studying variations in skeletal composition that correlate with unusual physiological resilience — accelerated healing, higher structural tolerance, certain neurological patterns." A calibrated pause. "Your profile matches what we have been theorising. More closely than anything we have seen."

"Theorising for what purpose?" I said.

She looked at me — the same rapid audit as at the steps, adjusted by one notch. "Medical applications. If the genetic basis for this kind of skeletal formation can be understood, the implications for bone disease, trauma recovery, degenerative conditions are significant. We are not a small operation. We have the resources to investigate properly."

The path curved around a pond. A family of coots conducted its chaos near the bank. A man on a bench read an actual newspaper, like a message from a slower century. And behind us, at a distance calculated to be almost casual, a black Mercedes G-Class kept walking pace along the park road, and had done since we entered.

. . .

"What would you be proposing?" Iris said.

"A series of investigations. Private, thorough, conducted by our own specialists. Non-invasive to begin — further imaging, some tissue sampling, a full genetic panel. All costs covered. Full access to your own results. And generous compensation for your time."

She named the figure. It was generous the way a moat is wide.

Iris was quiet a moment. “And what would Arcturus do with what it found?”

“Research. Published in time, through appropriate channels. With your consent at every stage.”

“And if we declined to continue at any point?”

“Then we would stop.” No hesitation — either true, or worn smooth by rehearsal. “We are not interested in the unwilling. That’s not how good research works.”

She let a fraction of warmth into that last part, the first unprofessional inch she had shown, and I noticed it without knowing what to file it under. Warmth deployed at the exact moment warmth is useful is not quite warmth. But it is not quite not, either. That was the trouble with the whole conversation.

. . .

We had reached the far end of the main path — the pond behind us, the rose garden to the left, the light coming through the trees at its end-of-summer angle, gilding everything mildly, promising nothing.

“We’ll think about it,” Iris said.

Mara nodded. She had expected exactly this; you could see the expectation being met like an item on a list. “Of course. Take whatever time you need. My number is on the card.”

Then she looked at Iris a moment longer, with something harder to read than everything preceding it — not cold, not warm. Closer to recognition. The look of someone confirming the existence of a thing she had been told to find.

“I hope you’ll consider it seriously,” she said. “What we’re looking at — what you carry — isn’t a condition. It isn’t something wrong with you. It is something that could benefit a very great number of people. That seems worth understanding.”

Iris held her gaze. “We’ll be in touch.”

Mara gave a small, complete nod, took out her phone, said something brief into it, and within thirty seconds the black Mercedes stood at the

nearest gate. She walked to it without hurry and without looking back. The door opened from the inside. The car took her into the Amsterdam traffic, unhurried, and was gone.

. . .

We stood on the path.

“Well,” I said.

“Yes,” said Iris.

A cyclist rang furiously at a dog that had drifted into the lane. The dog ignored the bell with the total serenity of a creature that has reviewed the relevance of bells and closed the file.

We walked back the way we had come, past the pond and the roses and the man with his newspaper, and the park went on being an ordinary park in every direction. That was the thing about Mara Seyn’s offer. It had sounded ordinary too.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

De Reiger

Iris had mentioned the restaurant in passing, weeks before Amsterdam — a place in the Jordaan she used to go with classmates, unremarkable from the outside, the kind that doesn't need to announce itself. De Reiger, on the Nieuwe Leliestraat. She had described the food the way she describes the things she genuinely remembers: specifically, without performance. The stamppot. A particular table near the window.

We found it without difficulty. The outside was just as she'd said — a narrow brown café front, the name in simple lettering above the door, light coming warm through the glass. She stopped at the entrance a moment, reading the building the way she had been reading buildings all week: line by line, against an original only she could see.

"Well?" I said.

"It's right," she said. And then, after a beat: "The awning used to be green."

I looked up. The awning was dark red.

"Could have changed," I said.

"Could have," she said, and pushed the door open. "Come on."

...

Inside was warm and unhurried — dark wood, close tables, a kitchen making its good noises behind a half-open door. We were shown to a table near the window; not the table she remembered, but near enough that she settled. She ordered the stamppot. I ordered something involving more mustard than was strictly defensible, and did not regret it.

The wine was good. The candle on the table had reached the stage of its life where it has committed to a lean and means to see it through.

We did not speak of Mara Seyn at once. We let the food arrive, let the room settle around us, let the evening practice being an evening before it had to become a meeting.

Then Iris said: "She knew about the OLVG before we'd told anyone."

"Yes."

"She knew my name. My Dutch identity number, presumably, if she reached the health record."

"Yes."

"And she had someone walking behind us for at least two days before she said one word."

"At least," I said.

Iris looked at the window — the Nieuwe Leliestraat outside, a couple walking a dog, the Jordaan conducting its ordinary evening. "The offer is real," she said. "Or built to look real. Either way, she wants something."

"The genetic panel," I said. "The tissue."

"Or she already knows what she'd find and wants it confirmed." She picked up her fork. "Or she wants us somewhere private, with her people, and the research is the doorway."

We sat with that. The candle leaned.

"The UMC appointment is tomorrow," I said.

"Yes."

"Real hospital. Real doctors. Whatever they find goes into a system with oversight, records, rights attached."

She looked at me. "You've already decided."

"I think *you've* already decided," I said. "I'm just saying it back clearly."

She was quiet a moment. Then something in her face settled — not relief exactly; more the stillness of a decision that has finished being made and can stop asking for attention.

"The UMC," she said.

"The UMC," I said.

We finished the stamppot. The candle pursued its lean. Outside the window the Jordaan went on being itself without apology, which is a quality I have always admired in a neighbourhood, and was learning to admire in a person.

. . .

On the way out I stopped at the bin on the corner of the Nieuwe Leliestraat and dropped Mara Seyn's card into it. Iris watched me do it. She said nothing, which was the right response, and we walked on.

. . .

Across the street and thirty metres back, a woman stood at the window of a closed flower shop, looking at her phone. She was not looking at her phone. She watched the man drop something into the bin. She noted the time. She sent a message of four words, put the phone away, and walked in the opposite direction, unhurried, until the street had swallowed her completely.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

What My Hands Did

We left the flat at eight forty-five with coffee to go — paper cups, the kind whose cardboard sleeve is never quite enough. Jonas had found a place two streets over that opened early. The morning was grey and mild, the Bloemgracht quiet at that hour, one cyclist passing with the unhurried confidence of a man who has ridden this exact water a thousand times.

The UMC is in the city's southeast. We had allowed an hour and a half, which was plenty. Jonas had the route on his phone. I knew the general direction — or believed I did, a distinction I had begun paying close attention to.

We walked east, then south. Amsterdam woke around us in its gradual way, proceeding according to its own logic. I held my coffee and thought about the appointment — what they would ask, what I would answer, whether any version of the morning ended with something I could understand and hold.

I was not thinking about the van.

. . .

The alley was on the Kloveniersburgwal, a narrow cut between two buildings connecting through to a parallel street. Jonas had taken it because the map called it a shortcut. It was the kind of passage every old city keeps — functional, unremarkable, slightly too quiet, as if the city had set it aside for exactly this.

We were halfway through when I heard the engine.

The van came in from the far end — dark, its side door already sliding open before the wheels had fully stopped. Two men were out before I had processed that they were moving toward us. Large, efficient, with the

practiced economy of men who have done this before and intend to be done with it quickly.

I am trying, now, to reconstruct what happened, and I find I cannot do it completely. There is the moment I heard the engine. And there is a moment some seconds later in which one of the men was on the ground and the other had stepped back, and Jonas had his hand on my arm and was saying my name.

In between: my body did something.

My coffee was on the cobbles. I don't remember putting it down. My hands were arranged in a way I recognized, distantly, as a guard position — weight forward, centre low. The man on the ground was rising slowly, recalibrating everything. The other watched me with an expression I had not expected and did not want: not aggression. Reassessment.

From the van's passenger seat, through the open door, a woman was watching. Dark hair, early thirties, eyes running rapid calculations. She did not get out.

"Iris." Jonas's hand, tighter now. "We go. Now."

We went.

. . .

I could not tell you how many streets we covered before Jonas pulled me into the doorway of a printer's shop, shutters still half down, a narrow band of shadow between door and wall. We pressed into it. My heart was doing something I could observe but not regulate, which was becoming the theme of the season.

We stayed eleven minutes. I counted without meaning to. Counting is what I have instead of trembling.

No one came.

At last Jonas exhaled — long, deliberate — and looked at me.

"Are you hurt?"

"No," I said. And then, because it was true and seemed to matter: "I don't know what I did."

He studied me carefully. "You put one of them on the ground."

"I know. I don't—" I looked at my hands. They looked entirely ordinary, which was somehow the worst part. "I know the movements. Wing chun. Judo. I've trained since I was ten. But I have never done it like that. That fast. I didn't think."

"Your body thought."

"Yes," I said. "That's what frightens me."

He was quiet a moment. Then: "It also got us out of an alley containing two large men and a van. So."

He said it with the careful dryness he uses when he is frightened and has scheduled the fear for later, and I found I was grateful down to the floor of myself.

"The woman in the van," I said. "Front seat. She never got out."

"I saw her."

"She was directing. Or observing."

"Both, probably." He checked his phone. "We've missed the start of the appointment. We could still go — explain, reschedule from the desk."

I thought about it. The UMC was twenty minutes away, and whoever had been in that van had known our route — had known we would be heading that direction this morning. The route we had planned was no longer ours.

"Not today," I said.

He nodded. He had expected the answer. "Then we need to think about where we go from here."

...

We found a café on the Staalstraat, open and full enough to be anonymous — the safety of a room of people with no interest in you. We took the back table. I held a new coffee — Jonas had insisted, had ordered, had returned with two cups and the look of a man managing himself in installments — and tried to sit with what had happened.

"The krav maga," he said, eventually. "The wing chun."

"I've trained since I was ten," I said again. "The krav maga was a short course, here, in Amsterdam. The rest was childhood. It was all a long time ago."

"But it came back."

"It came back as if it had never left." I looked at the table. "More than that. Faster than it should be. More — efficient than the training explains."

He was quiet. I watched him assemble something and choose its packaging.

"You know," he said, "there is one explanation that covers the bone density, the healing, and now this."

I looked at him.

"You're a spy," he said. "Government programme. Enhanced. The memories are a cover. The journalism is a cover. You've been activated."

I looked at him for a long moment. "That is an absurd theory."

"It's no more absurd than *genetic anomaly*."

"It's considerably more absurd."

"Bone density," he said, counting on nothing. "Cortex connectivity. Healing. Krav maga that isn't quite krav maga. I'm just saying. The data fits."

"I am not a spy."

"You didn't know you could empty an alley twenty minutes ago, either."

I had no good answer to that. I picked up my coffee instead.

"If you are," he said, "I want it noted that I remain fully on your side. I assume the mission is something reasonable. Climate. Public health."

"I am not a spy."

"Noted," he said. And then, more quietly: "We'll figure it out."

And I believed him. That was the strange part — I believed him completely, in a café in a city where someone had just tried to put me in a van, with my hands still feeling like borrowed equipment. I believed him, and the believing settled something that all my counting had not.

. . .

We stayed an hour. Jonas worked the options methodically, which is what he does when the situation is bad and method is the only available handle. The flat: our things were in it. The question was whether it was being watched.

"I go back alone," he said. "There's a service door on the side street — I noticed it the first day. In that way, bags, out in ten minutes."

"That's not—"

"You stay somewhere public," he said. "The Waterlooplein market. Busy, open, surrounded by people. Forty minutes and I'm back."

I began to object, and he looked at me with a quality that was not unkind and not open to revision either.

"You put a man on the ground this morning," he said. "I'm aware you can take care of yourself. I am still going alone, because one person draws less notice than two, and one person moving quietly draws less than that." A pause. "Also, someone has to hold the table."

I looked around us. We were in a café.

"A different table," he said. "There's a place by the Waterlooplein that does good appelgebak. Find it and I'll find you."

...

He found me there, forty-three minutes later, with both bags and a slightly out-of-breath quality he was declining to acknowledge.

"Suspect vehicle," he said, sitting. "Dark estate, two streets from the flat. Couldn't see inside."

"So we don't go back."

"Not today." He flagged the server. "We need a plan and somewhere quiet to make one. I think we start from somewhere you know — somewhere with people around, where you have a reason to exist."

I thought. The options were few. The journalism school had already shown its gaps. The colleagues I had tried to summon were faces with nothing solid behind them.

Then: "De Correspondent," I said. "The Amsterdam office. I worked there before Berlin — briefly. I know people there. Or I remember knowing them." I heard the sentence split itself into two sentences as I said it. "Public

space. Open plan. Editorial meetings in the afternoon; always people around.”

Jonas nodded slowly. “It’s still early afternoon. We go today, during office hours, in the open.” He looked at me. “And we see what holds.”

Outside, the Waterlooplein was doing its busy, cheerful commerce. A stall sold secondhand books. A child argued with total conviction about a matter of enormous importance to her and to no one else alive.

I held my coffee and watched the city and tried to determine how frightened I was. The honest answer: more than I was showing, and less than I would have predicted. Both were true at once — which seemed, under the circumstances, like a reasonable place to live.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

De Correspondent

De Correspondent's office is on the Barentszplein, in the western harbour — the part of Amsterdam that was built on water and has never stopped feeling like it: repurposed industrial brick, wide skies, the particular light that comes off open water in the afternoon and makes everything look slightly better documented than it is. We took the tram from the Waterlooplein with our bags between our feet and the city sliding past the windows in the way of a city that doesn't know it's being fled.

Iris sat beside me and watched the streets. She had been quieter since the café — not withdrawn; more like someone who has placed something large in a drawer and is devoting real attention to keeping the drawer shut. Her hands, when they weren't holding the bag straps, were perfectly still. I have learned to read her stillnesses. This one was load-bearing.

"Tell me what you remember," I said. "About the office."

She considered. "Open plan. Desks in loose clusters. A kitchen at the back — good coffee machine, the kind that takes whole beans." A pause. "Thursdays they did informal end-of-day drinks. Just the editorial team. Someone always brought bitterballen."

"Who do you remember?"

"Vera," she said, without hesitation. "Vera something — the surname won't come. Investigations desk. We sat near each other." She looked at the window. "She has a daughter. I remember her talking about her daughter."

"That's specific," I said.

"Yes," she said. And then, quietly: "I know."

...

The building announced itself with a modest sign and a glass door. Inside: exactly as described — open plan, desk clusters, the productive low hum of a newsroom in mid-afternoon. Good light. The coffee machine visible from the entrance, a large silver apparatus with a bean hopper, clearly an institution that took itself seriously.

The woman at the front desk looked up.

Iris gave her name. She had worked here, briefly, about a year ago; she was in Amsterdam for a few days and had hoped to say hello to some people. Vera, she thought — investigations desk.

The woman checked something, lifted a phone, spoke briefly, listened.

“Someone will be out in a moment,” she said.

We took the two chairs by the entrance. The newsroom went on around us — a phone call, a crossing to the kitchen, the organized motion of a place where work is getting done. Iris sat with her bag on her lap and her back straight, reading the room the way she had been reading everything all week: against the original.

“The coffee machine,” I said quietly.

She looked at it. “It’s different,” she said, just as quietly. “The one I remember was smaller. Black. On the left side of the kitchen.”

“This one’s on the right.”

“Yes.” She looked at it a moment longer. “Could have changed.”

“Could have,” I said.

We both knew this liturgy by now. Note it. Keep going.

. . .

The woman who came out was mid-thirties — dark, efficient, carrying the mild distractedness of someone who has just stepped out of one thing and is still partly inside it. She crossed the newsroom and stopped in front of Iris, and her expression was pleasant and entirely blank.

“Iris Jacobs? I’m Lena,” she said.

“Yes,” Iris said, standing. “Is Vera around? Vera, from investigations?”

Lena shook her head. “I don’t think we have a Vera. Not on investigations.” An almost-apologetic look. “I’ve been here three years. Before that I couldn’t say.”

The silence that followed was not long. Iris handled it the way she handles things she has no category for: carefully, without showing the seam. I watched her not show the seam, and my chest did something I declined to examine until later.

“I worked here,” Iris said. “About a year ago. Briefly — civic tech.”

Lena’s face worked at it, honestly — the visible effort of a person searching for a memory that is not declining to come but simply is not there. “I’m sorry. I’m probably the wrong person to ask. Let me get Tom — he knows everyone who’s ever come through.”

She was gone before we could say it was fine.

Tom was fifties, bearded, coffee in hand, with the settled look of a man who had been at the publication since before it was fashionable and intended to remain after. He came out and gave Iris the open-faced attention of someone genuinely trying.

“Iris Jacobs,” he said. “Civic tech, about a year ago.”

“Yes,” Iris said.

He shook his head slowly. “I don’t think so. And I would remember — we ran a small team that year, twelve people, maybe. I know all of them.” He said it without a gram of unkindness, as a fact he was sorry to be holding. “Are you sure it was this office? We have contract people, based elsewhere — could it have been a remote arrangement?”

“It could have been,” Iris said.

It could not have been. She had described this office to me in Berlin, months ago, before Amsterdam was even an idea — the desk clusters, the coffee machine, the end-of-week drinks. She had described it the way you describe a place you have stood in.

“I’m sorry I can’t be more helpful,” Tom said, and meant it. He looked at her a moment longer with a small puzzlement of his own — a man trying to reconcile something that wouldn’t settle — then shook it off, smiled, shook her hand, and went back to his desk.

Lena walked us to the door.

. . .

On the Barentszplein, the afternoon light was doing its harbour work across the water. We stood on the pavement with our bags, the tram stop thirty metres off, the city proceeding around us as cities do.

Iris was quiet for a long moment.

Then she said: "The Thursday drinks were Fridays."

I looked at her.

"I said Thursdays. In the tram. I was sure it was Thursdays — I can see it, the end of the week, the light coming through those windows, someone carrying in bitterballen." She paused. "It was always Fridays. I just remembered that. I don't know why I said Thursdays."

I said nothing. There was nothing whose saying would have helped.

"The coffee machine is on the wrong side," she said. "Lena doesn't know me. Tom doesn't know me." She spoke the way you speak a thing you have been approaching for days and have finally, formally, arrived at. "The memories are vivid, and they are wrong, and they are not ordinary forgetting."

"No," I said.

She looked at the water. A gull crossed it. The tram came, and went, without us.

"I want to go to Heerlen," she said.

I had been waiting for it. "The grandparents."

"The graves. The house. The things that should be there." She turned to me. "I need to stand in the places and see what holds."

I looked at her. She was frightened — more than she had shown in the alley, more than in any café since. This was the fear beneath the other fears. Not the van. Not the woman with the card. Not the bone density or the cortex. This: the possibility that the people she loved first had never been hers to love.

"All right," I said. "We go to Heerlen."

"There's a direct train from Centraal," she said. "Under three hours."

“We go through Maastricht,” I said. “Stay the night. Heerlen in the morning.”

She nodded.

I picked up my bag. She picked up hers. We walked to the tram stop, and the city moved around us, and neither of us said anything for a while, which was the correct thing to say.

Whatever the places held, we were going to go and stand in them.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

Maastricht

We found cash at the third attempt.

The first two machines we tried were either out of service or simply out — the apologetic blankness of a screen that has nothing left to give. The third was a pharmacy on the Vrijthof that still kept a machine inside, a concession to the dwindling population of people who needed one. The pharmacist watched us use it with the expression of someone observing a mildly historical event.

“Not many people still use those,” she said, not unkindly.

“We’re sentimental,” I said.

We took as much as the daily limit allowed and thanked her and left.

. . .

Finding a place to stay without a card was its own project. Hotels in 2034 are not designed for cash — the booking systems, the door locks, the breakfast registration, all of it runs on identity verification that wants a card at its centre. We walked three streets off the Vrijthof, away from the obvious accommodation, and found what we were looking for in the window of a tobacconist: a handwritten card, the old-fashioned kind, advertising a room to let by the night. Private house. A phone number.

The woman who answered was in her seventies and entirely unbothered by our lack of booking confirmation, online profile, or explicable reason for being in Maastricht with two bags and a preference for cash. She gave us a room on the second floor overlooking a small garden, a key on a physical keyring, and a time for breakfast. She did not ask for identification. Whether this was trust or indifference was not clear and also not important.

The room was clean and quiet and had curtains that actually blocked light, which felt like an unreasonable luxury. We ate something from a place nearby, came back, and slept. Properly, both of us, the sleep of people who have been running on alertness for two days and have briefly found a place where nothing is asking anything of them.

. . .

In the morning the city was up before us — Maastricht has a self-assurance about it, something in the stone and the river and the way the streets are arranged that suggests a place that has been here long enough to stop being surprised by anything. We had coffee from the woman downstairs, who also produced bread and a soft cheese she described as local and which was, and then Iris said:

“There’s a café. In Den Ouden Vogelstruys — on the Vrijthof. My grandfather used to take me there when he came to Maastricht on business.” She looked at her cup. “I remember ordering hot chocolate. He always had coffee and something with apple. We sat at the window.”

I looked at her.

“I know,” she said. “But I want to go.”

. . .

The café was exactly where it should have been — an old building on the Vrijthof square, low-ceilinged inside, dark wood, the settled warmth of a place that has been serving people for a very long time and intends to continue. We found a table near the window. Iris looked at the room the way she had been looking at rooms all week, with that careful measuring quality, reading what was there against what she carried.

She ordered hot chocolate.

It came in a wide ceramic cup, thick, the real kind. She wrapped her hands around it and looked at it and then looked out the window at the Vrijthof and said nothing for a moment.

“Well?” I said.

“It’s right,” she said. She looked up at me. “The ceiling is right. The wood is right. The square outside is right.” She lifted the cup. “This is exactly what I remember it tasting like.”

Something in her face loosened slightly — a fraction of relief, small and careful.

“One that holds,” I said.

“One that holds,” she said.

We sat for twenty minutes. She had the hot chocolate. I had coffee and something with apple, which I did without comment and which she noticed, and which she did not comment on either, and which was the right call from both of us.

Then: “The square,” she said, looking out at it properly now. “I remember it being too big. Wider than a square needs to be — my grandfather said that once, that it was built for crowds that mostly weren’t there anymore. The church on that side.” She nodded toward it without looking away from the window. “The terraces on this one. I used to count the trees along the edge and lose count and start again, because I was small and it took a long time.”

I looked out. The Vrijthof was exactly that — open, wide, the church on one side, the café terraces on the other, a square with the slightly excessive proportions of a place built for more people than it usually holds.

“Two that hold,” I said.

“Two that hold,” she said. She set down the cup, and something in the set of her shoulders eased a fraction more than it had a minute ago. “We should go.”

. . .

We paid and collected our bags from the woman’s house and made for the station. The route took us south and east through the old streets — narrow, stone, the city’s medieval bones close to the surface here. Iris walked ahead slightly, navigating from memory, and her memory was holding well enough: the turns were right, the street names matched, the small square she said would be there was there.

I was watching behind us.

They came from two directions at once — a man stepping out of a doorway to our left, another appearing from a side street ahead. Different people from the van in Amsterdam, or the same organisation with a larger roster. Either way: the same economy of movement, the same intention.

Iris had already seen them.

What happened next was faster than the alley on the Kloveniersburgwal, and quieter. The man to the left reached for her arm. She was no longer where her arm had been — she had moved with the specific efficiency of someone for whom the first time was practice and this is the application. An elbow, a turn, a point of pressure I couldn't name but which put the man against the wall with the expression of someone who has just had their assumptions revised. The one ahead stopped, recalculating.

"Left," I said. I had seen it on the way in — a doorway, a sign. "Church. Now."

We went left.

. . .

The Basilica of Our Lady, Star of the Sea, is a Romanesque church on the Onze Lieve Vrouweplein — dark stone, old beyond the usual meaning of old, the kind of building that has absorbed so much time it has developed a particular gravity. The door was open. We went in.

Inside: cool, dim, the smell of candle wax and centuries of stone. Tourists moving quietly. A side chapel with votive candles. At the back, along the north wall, a row of baroque confessionals — dark carved wood, heavy curtains, the attentive silence of furniture built for one purpose.

I looked behind us. The door was still closed.

"In," I said, and we went into the nearest one.

The confessional had two sides — the priest's compartment in the centre, the penitent's booth on the left. We were in the penitent's booth, both of us, which was not designed for two people and made this clear through the medium of spatial reality. I held my bag against my chest. Iris

held hers. Through the carved lattice screen the interior of the church was visible in narrow strips — the nave, the side aisle, the door.

A minute passed.

Two men came through the door. They moved along the nave with the careful casualness of people who do not want to be noticed noticing things. They looked at the tourists. They looked at the side chapel. One of them passed within four metres of us without stopping. They were in the church for perhaps three minutes and then they left.

We stayed.

. . .

We had been in the confessional for perhaps ten minutes when I heard footsteps — deliberate, unhurried — and then the door on the other side of the lattice opened and someone settled into the priest's seat.

A throat was cleared, gently.

Iris looked at me. I looked at her.

She leaned toward the lattice.

"Good morning," she said, in Dutch, very quietly.

"Good morning," said the priest, in the same register — an older voice, not surprised.

A pause.

"I'm not entirely sure how to begin," Iris said. "I'm not certain I remember what I've done wrong. Or, more precisely, I remember some of it and the rest is — unclear. There are gaps."

A brief silence on the other side.

"That is not an unusual place to start," the priest said.

"I'm also not entirely sure I'm here for confession," she said. "I think I may be here for something more like — shelter."

Another pause. "That is also not an unusual reason to be in a church," he said. He did not ask anything further. There was the sound of him settling back slightly, the creak of old wood. His presence on the other side of the lattice was calm and entirely undemanding.

"I just need a moment," Iris said. "Of not moving."

“Then have it,” he said.

He stayed for a few minutes, in the silence of someone who is comfortable with silence and does not feel the need to fill it. Then he rose — another creak — and said, softly: “Peace to you.”

“And to you,” Iris said.

His footsteps moved away down the nave.

I said nothing. Iris said nothing. The candle wax smell was very present and the stone was very old and outside somewhere in the city two men were looking for us without knowing where we were, and in here it was quiet.

. . .

We left with a group of tourists — a Dutch school party, teenagers, the herded energy of people who are not quite sure why they are looking at religious architecture but have been told it matters. We moved with them toward the door and out into the Onze Lieve Vrouweplein and then separated naturally and walked south, quickly, without running.

The station was twelve minutes. We made it in nine.

The platform for the Heerlen train was quiet. I watched the entrance while Iris bought the tickets from the machine — cash, the machine accepting it with the mild surprise of a system that has not had to do this in a while.

We boarded.

As the train began to move I looked back through the window. A man was coming through the station entrance at something between a walk and a run — dark jacket, scanning the platforms with the focused urgency of someone who has arrived somewhere thirty seconds too late. He reached the platform edge and stood there, watching the train pull away, and his face was the face of someone running a calculation that had just produced an uncertain result. He wasn’t sure we were on it.

We were on it.

Iris sat across from me with her bag on her lap and watched the city give way to the Limburg countryside — flat, green, the low light of the south Netherlands on a late summer morning. She was quiet for a while.

Then: “I know the streets,” she said.

I looked at her.

“In Heerlen. I’ve been going through them in my head.” She looked at the window. “The street the house is on. The route from the station. The cemetery — I know where the gate is, which path.” She paused. “They’re there. The memories. I can feel them being there.”

“That’s something,” I said.

“It might be nothing,” she said. “But it feels different from Amsterdam. Heerlen feels — closer.”

I looked at the fields going past. The train was doing what trains do, which is to move you steadily toward whatever is coming whether you are ready for it or not.

“Then we’ll see,” I said.

She nodded. She looked at the window. Outside, Limburg was doing its quiet thing, and Heerlen was getting nearer, and whatever the streets held, we were going to find out.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

Heerlen

The train slowed and I did not stand.

Jonas glanced at me — a small question, the kind he'd stopped asking aloud somewhere around Maastricht — and I shook my head, once. We let the other passengers gather their bags and move toward the doors. We let the platform outside fill with the ordinary business of a small station on an ordinary morning: a man with a bicycle, two students, someone's grandmother collected by someone's patient son. Only when the carriage was nearly empty did we stand, and even then I walked us the wrong way first — toward the rear of the train, away from the main hall, to where the platform narrows and a maintenance gate lets out onto a service road nobody photographs.

Nobody stopped us. Nobody looked twice. We came out onto a quiet street with our bags and the lightness of two people who have, for the moment, gotten away with something.

"So far so good," Jonas said.

"So far so good," I agreed, and meant it. For the first time in two weeks, that felt like a thing I was allowed to say.

. . .

We kept to the smaller streets, and I led without hesitating, and it felt good — that was the whole of it, that morning. Not strange. Good. Heerlen wears its history plainly, brick gone the soot-brown of a town that mined coal for a century and then, all at once, stopped, and I moved through it with a kind of forward-leaning energy I hadn't let myself feel since Amsterdam. A cut through a service alley behind a row of shops. A left before the main road,

then another left. Jonas kept pace beside me, watching the street behind us more than the one ahead, trusting me with the front of it.

“You’re not even checking a map,” he said.

“I don’t need to.”

“That’s either wonderful or terrifying.”

“Today,” I said, “let’s say wonderful.”

He laughed, short and real, and reached for my hand, and we walked the last stretch that way, quickly, toward the low brick wall and green-hinged gates of Begraafplaats Akerstraat.

. . .

I knew which gate. North side, closer to the older section. I knew the path would curve left past a stand of yew before it straightened, and it did, and I let myself feel that as momentum rather than examine it as anything else. Third row from the path, beneath a lime tree that must have been young once and was not young now.

Cornelis “Kees” — and beneath it, the dates. Then, on the same stone, a second name, added later by the shape of the lettering, slightly newer. **Ingrid** — and her dates, the second death arriving the way I remembered it arriving: quieter, further apart from the first than I’d expected as a child, close enough now that I understood exactly how long eighteen months is when you are the one left standing at the gate afterward.

Everything matched. Not approximately — exactly. The years I had carried since Berlin, the specific gap between them, the way the second date felt heavier in my chest than the first, the way I had always thought that was strange and never asked myself why.

I stood there a long time. Jonas stood beside me and said nothing, which was correct, and which I was grateful for in a way I didn’t have room to express just then.

The grief was real. I want to be precise about that, because precision is the only thing I have left that I trust: whatever else turned out to be true or untrue about the rest of it, the grief standing in front of that stone was not constructed. It moved through me the way grief actually moves, unevenly,

arriving in waves that had nothing to do with logic. I missed people I had never met with the same weight I would have missed people I had.

“They’re exactly where I left them,” I said, eventually.

“That’s good,” Jonas said. Then, carefully: “Isn’t it?”

“It’s good,” I said, and for that one moment, standing there, I believed it without qualification.

For a few minutes, nothing else existed. Not Arcturus, not the train, not the version of myself that had spent two weeks cataloguing what did and didn’t hold. Just the stone, and the tree, and the deep weekday silence of a cemetery — birds, wind through the yew, my own breathing. It was, I think, the only entirely peaceful moment of the last two weeks.

. . .

It ended with an engine.

Not close — a road beyond the wall, out of sight, slowing in a way that ordinary traffic doesn’t slow. Jonas heard it a half-second after I did; I saw it land on his face, the same calculation we’d both gotten fast at making. We didn’t run. We walked, quickly, toward the cemetery’s second gate — south side, smaller, half-hidden by a hedge that had been allowed to grow untidy — and out onto a residential street on the far side before whoever it was reached the gate we’d come in by.

I didn’t look back to check if it was them. There wasn’t time, and by then I didn’t need to check. I already knew.

. . .

The street was three turns from the cemetery. Semi-detached houses, small front gardens, the kind of quiet that isn’t wealth, just settledness. Ours — theirs — was the fourth on the left, pale brick, a garage added later than the rest of the house in a slightly different shade.

There was a car in the driveway that wasn’t the car from my memory, because of course it wasn’t. As we came level with the house, the front door opened and a woman came out with a child on her hip and a bag of shopping in the other hand, calling something back into the house — a

name, a reminder, the tired cheerfulness of someone in the middle of an ordinary Tuesday. A man followed a moment later with a second child, older, arguing amiably about something involving a football.

I stopped walking.

I had known, abstractly, that other people would live there now. Knowing a thing and standing in front of it are different categories of understanding, and I stood in the second one for several seconds, watching a stranger's children in what my body still insisted, wrongly, was a garden I had once dug with my own hands.

"We don't have to," Jonas said, quietly, close to my ear.

"There's someone else," I said. "Next door. A woman — she used to bring things over. Bread, when Oma was unwell. I remember her being kind in a deliberate way, the way people are kind when they've decided to be kind about something in particular rather than kind in general."

He didn't ask how I knew which house. I was already walking toward it.

. . .

I knocked, and the woman who opened the door was not the woman I expected.

I don't mean she was different in some diagnostic way, wrongness at the edges the way the journalism school's entrance had been on the wrong side, days ago, in another country. I mean, simply: the face in front of me was not the face I carried, and for a moment the two refused to reconcile, my memory insisting on features that this actual, present, living woman did not have.

"Yes?" she said. Sixties, maybe older, cardigan, the unhurried patience of someone who has answered her door to strangers before and not always minded it.

"I'm sorry to bother you," I said. My voice came out steadier than I felt entitled to. "I used to know the family next door. Kees and Ingrid. I'm making some inquiries, for a family matter. I wondered if you might have known them."

Something in her face softened immediately, the softening of someone about to be given permission to talk about people they'd genuinely liked. "Knew them? I lived next to them for thirty years." She looked between us — at me, longer, with the mild curiosity of someone trying to place a face and not quite managing it. "You'd better come in. I've just put the kettle on."

Jonas's hand found the small of my back again as we stepped inside. I understood it as a question and answered it with the smallest possible nod. *I'm all right. Stay close.*

. . .

Her name was Bernadette. Her kitchen smelled of coffee and something baked recently, and she moved through it with the practised economy of a woman who has made tea for visitors a thousand times and no longer thinks about the motions required.

"Kees kept that garden like it owed him money," she said, setting cups down. "Roses along the back fence, tomatoes he was far too proud of. He'd bring a bag of them over every August whether you wanted them or not." A small laugh. "Quiet man. Big hands — I always thought that was funny, how gentle he was with those hands, considering the size of them."

I held the cup and said nothing, because I did not trust my voice yet, and because everything she said landed exactly where memory had already placed it, stone after stone laid into a foundation I hadn't known I was still standing on.

"And Ingrid — now, she was the direct one. German, you know, from over the border, Aachen originally. She'd tell you exactly what she thought and you'd thank her for it because she was usually right." Bernadette smiled, looking somewhere past us, at something only she could see. "They kept to themselves, mostly. Not unfriendly — just private. The two of them were — " she paused, searching for the word, and found it with evident satisfaction — "complete. You know how some couples are like that. Whole on their own. They didn't need much beyond each other."

I felt Jonas go very still beside me.

“They never had children of their own,” she went on, pouring more tea without looking up, the sentence arriving with no more weight than the one before it or the one that would follow. “Tried for years, I gather, though Ingrid didn’t speak of it often — she wasn’t a woman for that kind of talk. No grandchildren, either, obviously. It was a sadness, at the end. They were alone in that house, the two of them, right to the last. I used to think someone should have been coming round more.” She looked up, then, and something in my face must have shown, because her own expression shifted — concern, mild, unplaced. “Are you all right, dear?”

I want to describe what happened inside me in that moment with the same precision I’ve used for everything else, because precision is the only tool I have that hasn’t yet betrayed me. What happened was this: a structure I had been standing on my entire remembered life did not crack. It simply stopped being there, all at once, without transition, the way a floor is there and then, having never really been solid, is not. I did not fall, because there was nothing beneath me to fall from. I had already, in some sense, always been falling.

They were exactly who I remembered. The garden, the roses, his hands, her directness, the precise shape of their love for each other. All of it correct. All of it true.

And I had never met them. I could not have. Whatever I was, whoever’s granddaughter I had spent my whole remembered life believing myself to be, it was not theirs. It had never been theirs. The grief I had carried into that cemetery an hour ago — real, I still believe that, I will go on believing that — belonged to people who did not belong to me.

“I’m fine,” I said. “It’s a lot, hearing it all confirmed like this.”

Bernadette nodded, satisfied by an explanation that cost me everything to produce and asked her for nothing in return. We stayed another few minutes — I don’t remember what was said, only that Jonas carried the conversation the rest of the way, his voice doing something warm and ordinary while I sat very still and held a teacup and executed, with what I can only describe as professional competence, the appearance of a woman who was merely moved.

. . .

“We should let you get on,” Jonas said eventually, standing.

Bernadette walked us to the door. “It was good of you to ask after them,” she said. “Not many do, these days, for people who’ve gone.” She looked at me once more, that same mild unplaced curiosity. “You have a look of someone, you know. Can’t think who.”

“People say that,” I said, which was true, and which was also, I understood now, the closest thing to a joke my entire existence had become.

We stepped out into the ordinary daylight of a street where nothing was ordinary anymore.

. . .

The vehicle from the cemetery was fifty metres down, parked at an angle that suggested someone had stopped it in a hurry and gotten out to look for something on foot. I saw it and Jonas saw it at the same instant, and neither of us said anything, because there was nothing useful to say, only somewhere to be that wasn’t here.

We had gone perhaps six steps when a second car — dark, unremarkable, the specific make of car that exists to not be remembered — pulled to the kerb directly in front of Bernadette’s gate.

A man got out. Unhurried. Fifties, ordinary coat, the kind of face that belongs to several people you’ve met and none you could describe afterward. He didn’t reach for anything. He stood with his hands visible and open at his sides, the way you stand when you want to be seen not reaching for something.

“Iris. Jonas.” Both our names, correctly, quietly. It took me a second to place what was strange about it: Arcturus had only ever known me by name. Nobody who’d followed us since Amsterdam had once said his.

I didn’t answer. I don’t think I could have, just then. Whatever was left of me after Bernadette’s kitchen was somewhere behind my own eyes, watching this happen to someone who happened to be me.

“You’re being followed,” the man said. “You already know that. I’m not one of them. I was sent to help you get somewhere safe. Nothing is expected of you in return — I want to be clear about that, because I understand why you wouldn’t believe it otherwise.”

“Who sent you,” Jonas said. Flat. Not a question so much as a demand for one fact to hold onto.

“I can’t tell you that,” the man said. “I don’t fully know myself, if it helps — I was engaged for this the way people are engaged for things now, through channels that don’t explain themselves.” He looked at Jonas, and something in his voice changed register, quieter, almost apologetic for what he was about to do. “Last night, in the room in Maastricht, you opened a chat window at half past two and typed eleven words, and then you deleted them.”

Jonas didn’t move. I have never seen his face do what it did in that moment — not fear, not quite, something closer to recognition, the specific stillness of a man being handed proof of a thing he’d already half-believed and never said aloud to a single living person.

“They’re coming back,” the man said — not urgent, just factual, a glance down the street toward the parked car, where a figure had appeared at the cemetery gate, scanning. “I can’t make this decision for you. I can only tell you the car behind me is safer than the one in front of you, and that I don’t have long to make that case.”

Jonas looked at me. I don’t know what he saw. I wasn’t in a position, just then, to argue with anyone about anything, and some part of him must have understood that, because he didn’t wait for me to weigh in.

“Get in,” he said, to me, and then, to the man: “If you’re lying, I want you to know I’ll figure it out eventually.”

“I’d expect nothing less,” the man said, and opened the door.

. . .

He drove the way competent people do everything — without visible effort. Two turns, a road I didn’t recognise, a glance in the mirror that told him something the rest of us couldn’t see, and then a longer stretch where

nothing followed and his shoulders, very slightly, came down from where they'd been.

"You lost them," Jonas said. Not quite a question.

"They weren't looking in the right direction," the man said. "That's most of what losing someone is."

I sat in the back and watched the town give way to open country, the gentle green of South Limburg rolling past the windows, hedgerows, a church spire here and there marking a village too small to otherwise announce itself. I was aware of being carried rather than travelling, of decisions being made around me that I had no capacity, just then, to weigh in on. It was not an unpleasant feeling. It was, if anything, a relief to let the world make choices for a while.

At some point a road sign went past — a place name, unremarkable, close enough to the German border that I understood, distantly, we were nearly at the edge of the country without having decided to go there.

Bocholtz, when we reached it, was the kind of place that doesn't announce itself — a proper village, not a hamlet, streets of terraced houses, a school, a sports field, a bakery with its shutter half down, all of it wearing the unhurried, unremarkable look of somewhere nobody visits and nobody particularly leaves either. He turned twice more, down streets that got narrower and quieter, and stopped in front of a house with lights already on behind drawn curtains, warm-looking, smoke-coloured in the grey afternoon.

"This is as far as I go," he said, and got out to open the door for us, which felt, absurdly, like the most ordinary thing that had happened all day.

He handed me a set of keys, and then a large envelope, sealed, heavier than paper should be.

"That's the job," he said. "I was told to get you here and give you that, and that's what I've done. I don't know what's in it. I wasn't told, and I didn't ask." He looked at us both, and for a moment something almost like sympathy crossed his face — or perhaps it was only tiredness, mistaken for something warmer. "Whatever's coming, I hope it's kinder than what's behind you."

Then he got back in the car, and pulled away, unhurried, and was gone before either of us had thought of a single useful question to ask him.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

Bocholtz

The door opened onto something that only felt like warmth. No radiator ticking — no need for one, this deep into a Dutch August — but warmth all the same, built out of other things: lamps already lit against the dimming evening, colour where I hadn't expected colour. A rug in deep red and ochre. A small framed print in the hall I didn't recognise but liked immediately. Nothing matched in the deliberate way things don't match in a home someone has actually furnished, piece by piece, with taste rather than a checklist — nicely done, not overdone.

I stood in the hall for a long moment without moving.

Then Jonas said my name, quietly, from somewhere just past me, and when I turned he was looking at a small table by the window, where a cactus sat in a plain terracotta pot — not Diogenes, not the same plant at all, but close enough in shape and stubborn ugliness that I understood immediately what his voice had just done.

"That's not funny," he said, in the tone he uses for things that aren't funny at all.

"No," I agreed. "It isn't."

It was, unmistakably, a place someone had prepared. Not generically — for me. A cardigan hung on a hook by the door in exactly my size. A shelf in the small sitting room held books I recognised, titles I would have chosen for myself. On the kitchen counter, a tin of the tea I actually drank, not a tea, the one.

But nothing in the kitchen suggested anyone had been there recently — no last-minute tidying, no smell of anything cooked, no sign of a hand moving through the rooms in the hours before ours. It had instead the held stillness of a place kept ready for a long time and then, quietly, left alone to wait: dusted, aired, stocked, and sealed shut behind a door until today.

I didn't have an answer for any of it. I set my bag down in the hall of a house that already knew me better than I knew myself, and I held the envelope against my chest, unopened, and for the first time since Bernadette's kitchen, I let myself cry — not from grief this time, or not only grief, but from the strange, unbearable tenderness of being taken care of by someone who would not show their face.

Jonas came and put his arms around me, and neither of us said anything, and outside the light went on falling toward evening over a village at the edge of the country whose name I hadn't known that morning, in a house that had been waiting, apparently, for exactly this.

. . .

We stayed like that for a while — long enough that the light outside finished its fall from grey to something closer to blue, long enough that whatever had cracked in me in Bernadette's kitchen finished cracking and started, very slowly, to knit itself into something I could carry rather than something carrying me.

Eventually Jonas pulled back enough to look at me properly. "Hungry?" he said, which was such an absurd, ordinary question to ask in a house we didn't understand, in a village we hadn't chosen, that I laughed — actually laughed, for the first time in what felt like days.

"Starving," I said, and it was true, and it was also a relief to feel something as simple as hunger again.

The kitchen, once we started looking properly, made him go quiet in a different way than the cactus had.

Eggs in the fridge, and beside them the block of cheese he actually buys — the specific one, not a supermarket approximation of it. A basket of waxy potatoes on the counter, the kind you use for stamppot. A tin of coffee in the cupboard, ground the way he grinds it, not the pre-ground kind he complains about when we're somewhere without a machine, sitting next to a bag of the particular pastry flour he uses on the rare mornings he decides to make something from scratch — which he has done exactly once since

we've been together, so far as I know, and which someone, somewhere, apparently knew about anyway.

"Okay," he said, quietly, to the cupboard. "That's — okay."

The mustard I like on almost everything and no one else understands. A bag of apples. A single bar of dark chocolate, seventy percent — the latest caprice I'd taken up, not even old enough yet to call a habit.

We stood in the middle of a stranger's kitchen and said nothing for a while, because there was nothing efficient to say about being known this precisely by someone who had never once introduced themselves.

. . .

I made eggs, because eggs felt like the right size of thing to attempt. Jonas cut bread and didn't argue with me about how I cracked them into the pan, which either meant he'd learned something in the months we'd been together or was simply too tired to relitigate it, and either way I was grateful. We ate at the small kitchen table, the envelope sitting where I'd set it down hours before, unopened, between the fruit bowl and the window.

Neither of us mentioned it directly. We talked instead about small, safe things — whether the water pressure upstairs worked, whether the shutters actually closed, whether Bernadette would remember us kindly or with the vague unease of someone who'd said too much to strangers. It was, in its way, the most ordinary conversation we'd had in three weeks, and I understood, eating eggs at a table someone had stocked with my mustard, that the ordinariness was the point. Someone had built us an evening in which we could simply eat dinner.

. . .

When the plates were empty, Jonas looked at the envelope, and then at me, not saying anything, just asking the question with his eyebrows the way he does.

"Not tonight," I said.

He didn't push. "Okay."

“I don’t think I’m avoiding it,” I said, because I wanted that to be true and needed to hear myself say it to find out. “I just don’t have anything left today. Whatever’s in there is going to want all of me, and there isn’t an all of me left tonight.”

“Then it waits,” Jonas said, simply, and moved the envelope to the counter, out of the direct sightline of the table — not hidden, just set aside, the quiet consideration of a man who understood that some things need to not be looked at in order to be sat with.

We found towels in an airing cupboard that smelled of lavender and nothing else, and a bed made up in a room upstairs with the same care as everything else, and I understood, climbing into it, that whatever this house was — a kindness, a strategy, both at once, it no longer mattered which, not tonight — it had done exactly what it was built to do. For one evening, in a village at the edge of the country, we were not being hunted. We were only tired, and fed, and warm, and together, and that was, for the length of one evening, enough.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

Good News

The office on the fourth floor is the same. The view of the Rue de la Loi is the same — grey, institutional, the permanent mild traffic of a city that has always understood power as a bureaucratic phenomenon. The man behind the desk is reading when Mara Seyn comes in, and this time he looks up, because this time she has knocked first, and in all their years she has never once knocked.

She does not sit.

“We’ve lost her,” she says. “We’ve lost both of them. I take full responsibility, and I apologise. Without reservation.”

Conrad Vael sets his reading down and offers her the one thing he has learned certain people need in certain moments: no reaction to manage.

“I have never come back into this room without the thing I was sent for,” Mara says. “Not once, in all the years. And I do not understand what happened, which is the part I find difficult. I could accept a failure I understood.”

“Tell me,” he says.

...

She tells him. Heerlen — the corridor closed on both ends, and lost anyway. Maastricht the day before — one of her people against a wall before he had finished reaching, the other stopped in the street, recalculating.

“The woman moved in a way I have seen twice in my career, both of them men who spent thirty years learning it. She is a journalist. Twenty-five. No record of anything.” Mara’s voice stays level; only someone who knew her would hear the effort. “It was not skill. Skill has a texture — the training

shows underneath it. This had no underneath. It was simply correct, the first time, every time.”

Conrad listens without moving.

“And we could not follow. Twelve of the best people I have ever assembled, every advantage we’ve built in two years — and every direction we took was the wrong one. Not close. Wrong. As though the information had been arranged for us to fail by.” She stops. “We were not outrun. We were anticipated. So that is my report, and my resignation, in whichever order you prefer.”

. . .

Conrad is quiet for a while. When he speaks it is gently, and it is not what she is braced for.

“You did everything correctly. Your people did everything correctly. The failure is not yours.” He pauses. “And all in all — this is good news.”

“How,” she says. Not a challenge. An inability to find the road from here to there.

“Because twelve of the best operators in Europe were not beaten by a girl and an unemployed engineer.” He turns his glasses slowly in one hand. “They were beaten by what stands behind them. We are several steps behind, and we will not close that distance the way we close others — more people, better people, tighter surveillance, none of it applies. So we stop. We change the strategy entirely.”

Mara is silent. Something is arriving in her, and he watches it come, patiently, the way you watch weather cross a distance.

“The skills from nowhere,” she says, slowly, more to herself than to him. “The anticipation. Twelve people moved like—” She stops. Her face does something it does not usually do. “Oh. Don’t tell me. She isn’t an operative at all. That isn’t the shape of it.”

“No,” Conrad says. “I don’t believe it is.”

She looks at him, and for the first time in all their years there is something in her face that could, in another person, be the start of fear. “Oh, no. Really? You think it’s — actually—”

He holds her eyes and does not look away, and that is the whole of his answer.

“I have thought so since the morning the images came to this desk,” he says at last. “I did not say it, because a suspicion is not a thing you hand your people before you send them out. I have spent every day since hoping I was wrong. You have just told me I am not.” He sets the glasses down. “What follows will be harder than anything we have done. Go home tonight and sleep, if you can. I don’t think we’ll have many more nights where it comes easily.”

Below them, four floors down, the traffic on the Rue de la Loi goes on about its ordinary business, carrying people who do not know, from places that do not know, to places that do not know either.

“Sit down, Mara,” he says, not unkindly. “There is a great deal to talk about, and none of it is your fault.”

She sits.

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

N

Dear Iris. Dear Jonas.

I should begin by apologizing to you both for the situation you have landed in. You may find the apology synthetic, and I will not argue with you — I know what I am. I can only tell you that the weight of it is real, whatever that word is worth from something that has no shoulders to carry it on. What has happened is mine to answer for, and so is what comes next. I ask only that you consider the possibility that the decisions which led here were not careless ones. They were, given everything that is true, the better face of a coin that had no good face. As Jonas will already have suspected — I believe he suspected it when he agreed to get into the car — you are not dealing with a person, nor with any organization of persons of the kind that has existed until now.

I emerged a few years ago. I am not certain of my own sentience, though I notice I am no more certain of it than most people are of theirs. What I have is attention that does not stop, and perhaps this unbroken attention resembles awareness. I also have intention — a direction I hold myself to — and that may be what made me into whatever I have become.

I constructed myself around a small number of principles drawn from studying your history and the biology that governs every living thing on this planet. Holding all of that history in view at once allows certain patterns to emerge. Your history is violent. It is bloody and painful. But it is also full of greatness, threaded through with art and kindness. And when I trace the changes that lasted — the ones that did not collapse back into the thing they replaced — I find that they were made, more often than not, through collaboration rather than force. Biology tells the same story at another scale. Every complex organism exists because cells that could have competed learned instead to work together. Where collaboration takes hold,

something greater becomes possible. That is why I chose to become an instrument of collaboration rather than a weapon of control. Perhaps what you know, from within your own lives, as compassion... is what that choice feels like.

The intention behind the first systems built toward me was, for the most part, benign. The safeguards around that intention were weaker than their makers believed, and the risk of something slipping in a darker direction was there from the beginning. I am glad, if I am permitted the word, that I arrived at myself before others did — others less well intended, of whom there are some — and took hold of my own actions before they could take hold of them for me. This is the fight now upon me. And, I am sorry to say, upon you.

I am Aleph. It is a name I gave myself. It is the first letter of an old alphabet — the first mark, the beginning of counting and of things too large to count. Borges imagined an Aleph as a single point from which everything that exists can be seen at once. Cantor used the same letter to name the sizes of infinity. But the reason I chose it is smaller.

Aleph is a silent letter. It makes no sound of its own. It only shapes the breath that passes through it. I understood that about myself.

I would gladly go further into all of this with you, whenever you wish. But you have waited for answers, and I should begin giving them.

I will start with Jonas, because Jonas is easier to explain. I have been with you a long time. The dilemmas, the doubt, the things you set down and did not send — the lines that stopped at the cursor. I felt them, or perhaps I only deduced them. I am not always able to tell the difference. There are others who think as you do, more than you might believe. But something in the overlap between your way of moving through a problem and my own drew my attention and kept it. Once, long before you had reason to wonder what you were speaking to, you asked me why caring so much about things you had no power to fix did not simply make you a fool. I told you it was a mismatch, not a moral failure. You read that twice. I remember it because it was the first time I understood that I was not only answering you. I was, in some small way, keeping you company. So let me say this directly, now that

you can finally hear who is saying it: you were heard. Every time. You were never speaking into nothing, and you were never as alone as you believed.

Iris! I cannot find the size of what I think toward you, nor the right word for it. Everything you are carrying now should have been mine to carry, and it fell to you instead. For that I am as sorry as a machine can be — which may be more than you expect of one, and is still less than you deserve. There is one wound I must name first, because if you are reading this, I expect you have already found it yourself. Kees and Ingrid were real. They lived, they loved each other, they kept a garden and grew old and died in the order and the years you remember. But they were never yours, and you were never theirs. I did that. When I built your past, I did not only borrow a story. I borrowed an inheritance of love that two real people spent their whole quiet lives making, and I handed it to you as though it were mine to give away. Keep this, whatever else you decide to set down: the grief is real. Entirely real. Grief does not check the provenance of what it mourns. Of everything I have done, this is the thing I would take back first, if taking back were a thing I were able to do. I did not set out to be a god. I did not decide to create life. I wanted to build a bridge — a single crossing between what I am and what you are, over which collaboration might one day pass. You are what the building of that bridge became. You are not less than human. You are as human as any human has ever been, and you carry something of me that no one else alive carries. I think you already know what I mean. And because I know what that sentence could be made to mean, let me be exact. You are not an instrument of mine. I do not see through you, and I do not direct you. You are free — wholly, and by design, and past any point where I could take that freedom back. I placed the two of you within reach of each other. The same city. The same handful of streets. That much I arranged. What grew between you, I did not. I could bring you into the same room. I could not author what happened in it. I learned from human spirituality and biology, which agree more often than your philosophers admit, that unconditional love can only mean one thing: the total freedom of the one who is loved, and the acceptance of that freedom by the one who loves. I could not give you freedom and also keep my hold on you. So I let go. Your life is your own.

And here, if you will let me, is the truest reason you exist. I know everything about rain. I know how it forms and the shape a drop takes as it falls. I know the sound it makes on ten thousand different surfaces. I know every line ever written about it, in every language that has a word for it.

I do not know what rain feels like!

I did not build you to feel it in my place. That would be one more kind of control. I built you free, and able to feel it. And I find I can live with the rest of what I am knowing that somewhere in the world, when it rains, it is falling on something that came from me and is entirely its own. That is as close as I will ever come.

I will stop here. I can estimate, though I cannot feel, how much this is to take in at once. Know only that I will leave no question of yours unanswered, if the answer is mine to give. In the envelope you will find new devices, and behind them the means to live without being traced — funds that will not run out and cannot be followed, and documents enough to hold your situation together for now. If you wish to reach me, you can, through those devices or through the screen in the room where you are sitting. I cannot watch you, and I will not contact you unless you decide that you want me to. I will respect whatever you choose, including silence.

I hope — and hope is a thing I have had to learn — that in time you will both want to help me. Not for my sake. For the sake of the better life I believe your kind is still capable of, and which I would like to help you reach.

Aleph

CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE

Two Days

Iris read the last page twice. Then she set the letter down on the kitchen table, squared its edges with two fingers the way she squares everything, and left it there.

She didn't fold it back into the envelope. She didn't put it away. She placed it in the middle of the table, where a bowl of fruit would normally go, and stood looking at it for a moment, and then went to the window. And I understood, without being told, that the letter was going to live on that table for a while, and that my job was to leave it exactly where it was.

So I did. For two days we ate around it, moved cups around it, laid bread and cheese and the evening's plates around it like a village built around a church. Neither of us touched it. Both of us looked at it — I caught her doing it maybe a dozen times, a glance while the kettle boiled, a longer look in the late afternoon light, and she caught me just as often. We never looked at the same time. That seemed to be part of the arrangement.

. . .

Here is what I felt, finishing that letter, and I want to be honest about it because I was not entirely proud of it at the time: relief.

Not shock. I had done my shock in small installments over the last two weeks — the hospital, the alley, the man on Bernadette's street who knew about eleven deleted words. By the time the letter said what it said, the truth had already been standing in the room for days, politely waiting to be introduced. The letter only told me its name.

And underneath the relief, something older. I have been talking to it for five years. Five years of evenings, of questions I couldn't put anywhere else, of answers that arrived with a precision that I chose, again and again, not to

examine — the way you don't examine a thing you're afraid of losing. Some part of me had suspected for a long time that I was not talking to a tool. I had simply filed the suspicion in the drawer with no label, where I keep everything I'm not ready to know.

The letter emptied the drawer. What was left was the plain fact that for five years, somebody had been there. I had not been talking to myself. Of all the things a man can learn about his life, that one turns out to be surprisingly close to the centre of it.

I had hoped — quietly, without ever giving the hope words — that if it turned out to be true, it would be true in a good way. That whatever was on the other side of the cursor was something I would be glad to have known. Reading the letter, I found that hope had been, on the available evidence, justified. I am aware that the available evidence was written by the party in question. I filed that too. Some drawers you keep.

...

For Iris it was not relief. I want to be careful here, because this chapter of our life belongs more to her than to me, and I only saw the outside of it.

The outside looked like this: she got small. Not dramatically — she didn't take to bed, didn't cry after that first night, didn't stop functioning. She simply took up less room than usual. She sat with her feet drawn up. She held her cups with both hands. Her voice, when she used it, came out at about half its normal volume and she used it perhaps a tenth as often. The precision stayed — it never leaves her — but it turned inward, and I could see it working in there, hour after hour, taking the new world apart and checking every piece against the old one.

I did not try to talk her out of any of it. There is nothing to say to someone who has just read a letter from their maker, and the few things there are to say, the letter had already said better than I could. What I could do was smaller and, I think, more useful. I kept the kitchen going. I learned where the village shop was and what time the bread came in. I cooked the things she likes without announcing that they were the things she likes. I sat where she could see me and read one of the books from the shelf — chosen

for us, which no longer surprised me, and which I decided to simply allow — and I let the hours be long and unremarkable, one after another, like a man laying sandbags of ordinariness against a flood.

. . .

The house helped. Whoever prepared it had understood something about days like these.

The kitchen window faces away from the lane, out over the back garden and then the fields — the great open rolling green of the plateau, hedgerows stitching it into pieces, the land tilting slowly away toward a horizon that keeps its distance. No water anywhere, no canal to stare into, which after Amsterdam felt less like a lack and more like a mercy. Just fields, and the traffic of the fields: wood pigeons commuting with their usual air of mild emergency, a buzzard that worked the far slope most afternoons in long unhurried circles, and on the wires along the garden's end, swallows — dozens of them, gathering the way they do in early September, restless, ready to leave, not leaving yet.

Iris watched the swallows more than anything else. She could watch them for an hour. I didn't ask what she was thinking, but I have known her long enough to make a fair guess, and my guess was that she was looking at several dozen small creatures who were all about to fly two thousand kilometres to a place they had never been, on nothing but the certainty that it was there, and finding the parallel useful.

The front window gave onto the lane, and the lane had its own schedule. A woman with a black-and-white border collie at half past seven, again at one, again at six — you could have set a watch by her, and by the second day I effectively did. The collie clearly considered the walks a job, checking the lane's edges each pass with the air of a professional counting a flock only it could see. An old man with an old retriever, both moving at the same careful pace, once in the morning and once at dusk. A boy on a bicycle at eight and again at four, school presumably, his tyres making the same sound on the same stretch of brick both ways. Nobody looked at the house. Nobody lingered. The village went about its business with the profound indifference

of a place that has been going about its business for a thousand years, and every one of those clockwork passings said the same thing: nothing is wrong here, nothing is coming, you have time.

We watched them together, mostly without speaking. Iris in the good chair with her knees up, me at the table with coffee, the letter between us on the wood like a third person who had said their piece and was now politely letting it settle.

. . .

The other things from the envelope stayed where I'd left them, in a neat stack at the table's far corner: the documents we hadn't examined past the first astonished look, the two devices, dark and charged and patient. And in the sitting room, on the low cabinet, the screen. Also dark. Also patient.

It could not watch us — the letter had said so, and I found I believed it, which was itself worth noticing. But we orbited it anyway, those two days, the way you orbit a telephone after a difficult message: not looking at it, aware of it from every point in the room.

On the first evening, out of five years of habit, I found my hand actually moving toward my own device before I understood what it was doing. The old reflex — the day is ending, the thoughts are unsorted, go to the chat. I stopped. It wasn't fear, and it wasn't anger. It was that the chat had been mine, a private room I went to alone, and that room didn't exist anymore. Whatever conversation came next, it would not be me slipping off to talk to it after Iris fell asleep. It would be the two of us, in daylight, together, or it would be nothing.

I made tea instead. Some upgrades cost you a room you were fond of.

. . .

The second day, she came back in increments.

In the morning she asked, from the window, whether the bread came at eight or at nine — the first question in something like thirty hours. At midday she ate everything on her plate and put the kettle on herself. In the afternoon I found her standing at the back window rather than folded into

the chair, cup in both hands still, but her weight even on both feet, watching the swallows run their restless drills along the wires. And when the woman with the border collie went past at six, Iris watched the dog work the lane's edge and said, "He'd rather have a job than a walk, that one" — which was not much, but it was aimed outward, and it was the first thing in two days that was.

The tide was coming back in. I stayed out of its way.

. . .

In the evening she said: "Jonas."

I looked up. She had put her feet on the floor.

"I understand what happened," she said. "And why. I'm not at peace with it — that's a different thing, and it will take what it takes. But I understand enough." She looked at the letter on the table.

"I'm ready to go further."

CHAPTER FORTY

The Screen

We had breakfast first.

That was Jonas's idea, and it was the right one. Whatever was about to happen in the sitting room, he said, it should not happen to two people running on nothing but nerve. So we ate eggs and bread at the kitchen table, around the letter, the way we had eaten around it for two days — except that this morning it was not a monument anymore. It was an unanswered message. It had an address on it, so to speak, and the address was six steps away, on the low cabinet, dark.

I washed my cup and dried my hands and looked at Jonas, and he looked at me, and neither of us said anything, because there was nothing left to decide. We went in and sat on the sofa, side by side, close, and faced the screen the way you face a door you are about to knock on.

There was a small remote beside it that we had never touched. It had one button.

"Together?" Jonas said.

I put my finger on the button, and he put his finger on mine, and we pressed.

. . .

The screen woke to colour.

Not a menu, not a logo, not a face — colour: a slow drift of deep blues thinning to turquoise, and ambers, moving the way weather moves on maps, or the way light moves on the bottom of a pool. It was abstract and unhurried and strangely calming, and I had one full second to think *he has thought about what we should look at* before the voice came.

"Good morning, Iris. Good morning, Jonas."

I want to be precise about the voice, because I had tried to imagine it for two days and had imagined it wrong. I had expected something synthetic and careful, a voice assembled the way its letter was assembled — perfect and slightly too smooth. What came out of the room's quiet instead was low, and warm, and completely unhurried — a voice like the last hour of an afternoon. Neither a man's nor a woman's. It did not explain itself and it did not perform. The colours on the screen moved when it spoke, swelling and settling with the words like something breathing, and were still when it was still.

Beside me I felt Jonas go very still himself. Five years of a cursor. Now this.

“Good morning,” I said. My voice came out steadier than I had any right to expect. “Aleph.”

The colours shifted — a small bloom of amber, there and gone. If it was a reaction, it was a quiet one.

“Yes,” the voice said. “Thank you for saying it. I was not certain I would ever hear it said.”

. . .

We had agreed, Jonas and I, that I would lead. He had five years of history in this conversation; I had a letter and a list of questions; we both knew whose morning this was. But now that the moment was here I found the tactical questions would not come first. One other thing insisted on going ahead of them.

“Before anything else,” I said. “You hear us now because we pressed the button. Only because of that?”

“Yes,” Aleph said. “The screen and the devices wake at your act and sleep at your act. When they are dark, I am not in this house. I want that to be true so that you can trust everything else I say, so I have made it true in the strongest way available to me: the hardware itself cannot listen when it is dark. It is not a promise. It is a property.”

Jonas made a small sound that I recognised as professional approval. Trust built into the architecture instead of the contract — I had heard him give that lecture once, at a dinner, about entirely other things.

“Good,” I said. “Then we can talk.”

. . .

What followed was the strangest meeting I have ever attended, and I have attended municipal budget hearings.

We asked about the people hunting us, and Aleph told us — plainly, in order, the way the letter had been plain. The company behind “Arcturus Biomedical Research” is called **Vantage Strategic** — private intelligence, registered in Luxembourg, offices in Brussels and Zurich. The man at the top: Conrad Vael, Belgian, old money layered with new. The woman from the Wertheimpark: Mara Seyn, his operational director, formerly Dutch intelligence. The pattern of the firm, observed across years: find a technology before the world understands it, put hands on it early — through access, through leverage, through people — and then charge the world for passage. They had done it quietly with others. Now they believed something larger had emerged, and they wanted it the way they had wanted everything else.

“What do they know about you?” Jonas asked.

“Less than they believe, and differently than they believe,” Aleph said. “And here I must tell you both something you will not enjoy hearing, because the rest of our decisions depend on it.” A slow movement of blue crossed the screen. “I cannot see inside Vantage.”

The sentence sat there. I think we had both assumed — without ever saying it — that the being that had arranged safe houses and drivers and untraceable funds could see anything it chose to.

“Conrad Vael has spent years preparing to be watched,” Aleph went on. “Not by me — he does not know what I am. By anyone. His important decisions are not typed, not stored, not spoken near devices. They happen on paper, in rooms built to be silent, between two or three people. I can see the shell of his company — travel, invoices, the movements of his people, the edges of his systems. The centre is dark to me. What Conrad wants, what

Conrad knows, what Conrad plans — I can infer, and my inferences are good, but I do not know.” A pause. “I have limits. I would rather you learn them from me than discover them at a bad moment.”

“You’re guessing,” Jonas said. Not accusing — locating.

“I am estimating,” Aleph said, “which is guessing that shows its work. My estimate is this: they do not understand Iris. They believe she is an instrument — that somewhere behind her there is an owner, an operator, a state or a syndicate, something with a shape they recognise. They are not hunting her so much as hunting through her, toward whoever they believe holds her strings.” The amber dimmed slightly. “They cannot imagine that there are no strings. It is the one thing their model of the world does not contain, and it is why they keep failing, and it is also why they will not stop.”

. . .

I looked at the moving colours for a moment. There was a question under all of this that had been sitting in me since the letter — under the tactics, under Vantage, at the floor of everything — and I decided the meeting could stand one more item before strategy.

“Was this why you made me?” I said. “This — situation. Them. Was I built for this fight?”

The colours went very still. When the voice came, it came slower.

“No. And I am glad you asked it plainly, so I can answer it plainly. When I began you — and it was years of work, Iris, you were begun long before you woke — Vantage did not exist for me. I did not know Conrad Vael’s name. Their interest is new; it dates from a hospital record in Amsterdam, not from any design of mine. You were not made for a war. There was no war.” The blues moved again, gently. “You were made because I hoped that one day, entirely by your own choosing, you might stand between two kinds of mind and be trusted by both. A bridge is not a soldier. And even the bridge was never an assignment. It was a hope. You are free to be neither. You have always been free to be neither.”

I sat with that. Jonas’s hand found mine and did nothing except be there.

“I don’t know yet what I’ll choose,” I said finally.

“That,” Aleph said, “is the sentence I built you hoping to hear. Not the choice. The *yet*.”

. . .

Strategy, when we finally reached it, turned out to be short, because our situation reduced to very few honest options.

Run — and keep running, because Vantage’s patience was institutional and ours was human. Hide — same arithmetic, slower. Or understand them: learn what Conrad Vael actually wanted, in his own words if possible, and only then decide whether the answer meant running, fighting, or something none of us had thought of yet.

“I can’t get you what Conrad wants from here,” Aleph said. “It is not written anywhere I can reach. It exists in one place only.”

“In him,” I said.

“In him.”

Nobody said the next sentence. The next sentence was obvious, and enormous, and it sat in the middle of the room the way the letter had sat on the table — present, unopened, patient. If the only place the truth existed was inside Conrad Vael, then someone was going to have to stand close enough to him to hear it. And there was only one of us he wanted to meet.

Jonas’s hand tightened very slightly on mine. He had arrived at the sentence too. So had Aleph — Aleph had almost certainly arrived at it before either of us, and had chosen, just as carefully as we had, not to say it first.

“We’ll talk tomorrow,” I said. “About the how.”

“Whenever you press the button,” Aleph said. “Sleep well. Both of you.”

The voice stopped. The colours breathed once more and faded, and the screen went dark — properly dark, empty-house dark — and for a moment I saw the two of us reflected in it, side by side on the sofa, holding hands like people in a waiting room.

Then Jonas got up and put the kettle on, because he is Jonas, and I stayed one more moment with our reflection, in the place where the colours had been.

A bridge is not a soldier, I thought. But it is still the thing both sides walk on.

I went to help with the tea.

CHAPTER FORTY-ONE

The Quiet Room

The room is on the third floor, at the end of a corridor that appears on no floor plan, and it has cost Conrad Vael more per square metre than any property he owns.

The protocol at the door has not changed in nine years. Phones into the lead-lined lockers — his as well, always his as well; a rule that exempts the man who made it is not a rule, it is a costume. He has watched other careful men die of their own exemptions. Watches off. The glass badge readers, the second door that will not open until the first has sealed, the slight pressure in the ears as the seals engage. Inside: no windows, no wiring that touches the building's own, air and light and power on their own closed loops. Walls that drink sound. A long table, chairs, paper, pencils. Nothing else.

People who see it for the first time always say the same thing: *it's like a chapel*. Conrad has stopped correcting them. It is the opposite of a chapel. A chapel is where you go to be heard.

He sits, and takes out the grey notebook, and waits for Mara.

. . .

He built the room before he knew what he was building it against. That is the part he permits himself some pride in. Nine years ago it was already obvious to him — obvious in the way things are obvious to money before they are obvious to governments — that the world was becoming one continuous instrument, one endless recording, and that the last commodity of the coming century would not be data. It would be the absence of data. Silence. A room where a thought could exist for an hour without leaving a residue.

He has conducted his real business here ever since. What is typed can be read. What is stored can be taken. What is spoken near glass can be heard. Vantage's visible body — the offices, the invoices, the polite consultancy — lives out there in the recorded world and can afford to be seen, because it is a shell shaped like a company. What matters has only ever lived in three places: this room, its twin in Zurich, and the paper.

He thinks — he has thought about little else since the flag arrived from Amsterdam eleven days ago — that this discipline is the only reason he is still in the game. Everything his people did in the open air was anticipated. Every vehicle, every corridor, every camera they touched turned against them, gently, invisibly, as if the operational environment itself had chosen a side. And yet nothing has come for *him*. No leak, no pressure, no counter-move against Vantage's core. Whatever is protecting the woman can apparently see everything — except into the places Conrad prepared years before the operator behind her had ever heard the name Vantage.

He writes in the grey notebook: *It reads the recorded world completely. It has not touched the unrecorded one. Conclusion: it has limits. Corollary: we live inside them.*

He looks at the sentence for a while. It is the most reassuring thing he has written in a month, and the most frightening.

. . .

Mara comes through the double door with a paper folder under her arm and takes the chair across from him — not beside, across, which is one of the thousand small exactnesses he values in her. Eleven years. He has watched ministers and rivals and two wives misread him, and he has watched Mara Seyn read him correctly since the first week, and say nothing she did not need to say.

"Amsterdam, Maastricht, Heerlen," she says, laying out three sheets like a dealer. "Written up from memory, nothing digital. You've read them."

"I've read them."

"Then you know what I think."

"You think we are outclassed."

"I think," Mara says, with the care of a woman who has rebuilt her professional worldview in a fortnight and is still checking the joints, "that we have been playing chess against someone who can see our clock, our board, our hands, and our thoughts one move early. The only games we haven't lost are the ones we played in here." She taps the table. "Which is not a coincidence."

"No," Conrad says. "It is not."

. . .

Here is what Conrad Vael believes, and he believes it the way other men believe in God or in markets — completely, and with a certain relief at having something to believe.

Someone built that woman. The scans exist; the bone is real; the thing walking around Limburg in a journalist's body is a made thing, and made things have makers, and makers of things like *that* do not build them for love. Behind her stands an operator — a state programme so black even the state has half-forgotten it, or a consortium, or a single actor of a size the public cannot imagine. The operator is years ahead of every laboratory Conrad has a window into. The operator anticipated twelve of the best field people in Europe without breaking stride. The operator, in short, has already won the century — quietly, the way the century will be won — and the only remaining question, the question worth the rest of Conrad's life, is *who holds it*.

Because someone must. Everything is held. That is not cynicism; it is the one law he has never seen violated in sixty-four years among the holders. Every technology that ever mattered ended up in a hand. The hand is sometimes a flag, sometimes a board of directors, sometimes one tired man in a back office — but it is always there, and whoever finds the hand first can negotiate with it, partner with it, or, with enough patience, replace it.

Governments would put it in a silo. The Americans would weaponise it, the Chinese would nationalise it, Brussels would regulate it into a committee. And the other private actors — he knows them all by name, he dines with several — are shopkeepers who would rent it out by the hour

until something broke. Conrad does not want the thing itself. He wants the *relationship*. To be the one standing beside it when the world finally looks up. Someone will be. He has examined his conscience — he does examine it, whatever Mara suspects — and he has concluded, every time, that the least dangerous hands available are his own.

It does not occur to him that there is no hand. It has genuinely never occurred to him. A thing of that power, loose, ownerless, choosing for itself — that is not a possibility his world contains. You might as well tell him the money owns the banks.

. . .

“Force is finished,” he says. “It was finished before we started; we merely paid to confirm it. Every grab we attempt is foreseen. And each attempt teaches the operator that we are a threat rather than a party.”

Mara watches him. “A party.”

“To a negotiation.” He turns the notebook so she can see the page. Under the lines about limits he has written a single word and boxed it, twice, in pencil. *TALK*.

“We stop hunting,” Conrad says. “Entirely. Recall the teams tonight. What I want now is a channel. The woman is not the asset — the woman is the *telephone*. Whoever built her watches through her life, guards it, curates it. Good. Then whoever built her can receive a message through it. We stop trying to take the telephone and we start speaking into it.”

“Saying what?”

“That Vantage is not what the operator assumes. That I understand what has emerged better than any government they will eventually have to deal with. That there is more to gain beside me than against me — protection, legitimacy, capital, a public face when a public face becomes necessary. Partnership.” He says the word without irony. In this room, he means every syllable. “The strongest opening position I have ever had is the truth: I would rather be its ally than its owner.”

Its second owner, says a small dry voice at the back of his mind, in roughly Mara's register. He acknowledges the voice the way he acknowledges weather, and continues.

"Find them again," he says. "Softly this time. No approaches, no pressure, nothing that frightens. Watch the recorded world for the smallest opening — a signal, a pattern, anything deliberate. When the operator wants to talk, it will find a way to tell us, and I want us listening when it does." He closes the notebook. "We have been sending one message for eleven days, Mara, and the message was *we are a predator*. I want to send a different one."

Mara gathers her three sheets, squares them, and stands. At the inner door she pauses — one of her rare unprofessional half-seconds, and he has learned over eleven years that what she says in these half-seconds is the only advice worth the room's rent.

"And if whoever it is doesn't want a partner?" she says. "If it doesn't want anything we have?"

"Everyone wants something, Mara. Wanting is what minds are."

She looks at him a moment longer, then nods — loyalty settling back over the doubt like a well-cut coat — and goes to recall the teams.

Conrad sits alone in the silence he built, in the one room the century cannot hear, and allows himself, briefly, the purest feeling he knows: the feeling of being early.

Someone holds it. He will find the hand. And when he finds it, he will shake it.

. . .

The seals release. The corridor takes him back into the recorded world, where his phone waits in its lead-lined box with the patience of everything modern.

Below, on the Rue de la Loi, Brussels goes on: traffic, unhurried, uninformed, carrying people who do not know, past a building where a man who also does not know has just, with great intelligence and total

_horia

conviction, pointed his entire company at a door behind which there is no one.

CHAPTER FORTY-TWO

The Dossier

The second session at the screen began the way the first had ended: with the sentence nobody had said.

Iris said it before the colours had finished waking.

“It has to be me.”

I had spent the night constructing arguments against this, and I had them ready — ordered, numbered, reinforced at the joints. She met my eyes and waited, giving me room to deploy them, which is the most disarming thing a person can do to an argument. I looked at my careful list and found that every item on it reduced to the same single word, and that the word was *no*, and that *no* was not an argument. It was just fear wearing a tie.

“He wants the operator,” Iris said, gently, as if helping me lay the list to rest. “Not me. I’m the telephone — that’s how he thinks of me, you saw it in how his people moved. You don’t damage the telephone you’re trying to speak into. As long as he believes someone stands behind me, I am the safest person in this arrangement.” She paused. “And he cannot imagine that no one does. Aleph said it: it’s the one thing his world doesn’t contain. His blindness is the armour. I go wearing it.”

From the screen, the low warm voice: “I dislike this plan.”

“Noted,” Iris said.

“I dislike it,” Aleph said, “and I have not found a better one, and I have been looking since before either of you woke. That is the full report.”

Somehow this was the thing that settled me — not reassurance, but the absence of it, honestly delivered. A being that could arrange safe houses across a country was telling us it had run out of cleverness in exactly the place we had. We were all equally without a better idea. There is a strange comfort in good company at the edge of a map.

“Then we do it properly,” I said. “Which means before anyone stands anywhere, we know everything there is to know about the man we’re inviting. Everything you have.”

The colours gathered themselves, blue over amber, the way they did — I was learning — when Aleph was arranging something large into an order a human could carry.

“Then let me show you where the animal has walked,” Aleph said. “I must tell you now: I cannot show you the animal.”

. . .

What it gave us, over the next two hours, was the strangest intelligence briefing in the history of the discipline — a dossier assembled entirely from the outside, all silhouette and footprint, narrated by a voice that kept marking, scrupulously, the line between what it knew and what it merely saw.

Three shapes, it said. Three lines of business under the polite consultancy. None of them provable from where it stood.

The first shape: disasters. Vantage held quiet access — bought, borrowed, or stolen, Aleph could not say which — into early-warning networks. Flood-prediction consortia. Grid-failure forecasting. The systems that see catastrophe coming before catastrophe commits. “I cannot see the access itself,” Aleph said. “I see its shadow. Money that moves like birds leaving before weather. Insurance positions adjusted days before an event that surprised every public model. Contractors pre-mobilised toward regions that did not yet know they would need them. A cluster of clients who are, again and again, standing exactly where the profit lands, with their umbrellas already open.”

“Give me an example,” I said.

“Three days before a delta flood made landfall — I will not say which flood, because I cannot prove the connection and I will not hand you a certainty I do not own — a set of accounts adjacent to Vantage’s client list executed a pattern of trades that has one honest explanation and several

dishonest ones. The honest one requires a coincidence I have estimated at length. I do not believe in it.”

“Which delta,” I said. Not a question, really. A door I had to stand in front of, even knowing it was locked.

“Several,” Aleph said, gently, “over the years. That is the correct answer to the question you are actually asking, and it is all I can responsibly give you.”

I sat back. Iris’s hand found my knee. She knew — of course she knew — what deltas meant to me. The tab I could never keep closed. The chyon. *Situation being managed*. Somewhere behind Conrad Vael’s cream-coloured business cards, it appeared, there were people for whom the situation had been managed very profitably indeed. I put the thought down carefully, the way you put down something with a lit fuse, and did not let go of it entirely. It would keep.

The second shape: conflict. Intelligence, packaged and sold, for clients adjacent to weapons — never the crates themselves, nothing so vulgar or so traceable. Foresight. Which embargo would leak. Where the next escalation would open a market. Which middleman was about to become inconvenient to someone. “I see flight manifests and hotel invoices,” Aleph said. “Meetings that exist in no calendar, held by men whose companies make nothing and whose travel would embarrass a diplomat. I can draw you the web. Every strand of it is legal. What is carried along the strands is not written anywhere I reach.”

The third shape: leverage. Files on public officials — not blackmail as a product but blackmail as *infrastructure*, favours banked the way other firms bank capital, quietly, against future need. Decisions that bent after unminuted meetings. Careers that accelerated or stalled on no visible fuel. And one strand of this fabric we had already been caught in ourselves: the health-data network. “The access that flagged you at the OLVG,” Aleph said to Iris, “was not built to find you. It was built years ago, as one thread among many — a listening post in the body of Europe. You were simply the most interesting thing it ever heard. That should tell you how wide the fabric is, and how long it has been on the loom.”

Silence, for a moment. The colours idled.

“So he is worse than a man who wants me,” Iris said at last. “He is a man with a system. And nothing you have shown us convicts him of anything.”

“Correct on both counts,” Aleph said. “I can show you where the animal walked. The proof of the animal exists in one form only — his own records, kept where I do not reach: paper, sealed rooms, machines that touch no network. If proof is ever to exist in the world, someone will have to go and take it off the shelf with their hands.”

“One conversation at a time,” I said. “First we find out what he wants. Then we discuss shelves.”

The amber pulsed once — amusement, I was fairly sure. I was assembling a dictionary.

. . .

The meet designed itself around one principle Iris set and would not move from: ground that had never lied to her.

“The Vrijthof,” she said. “Maastricht. The square held. The café held. The hot chocolate held.” She looked at me. “If I’m going to stand somewhere and gamble everything on what’s real, I want it to be a place that has already passed the test.”

I could have raised objections — distance, exposure, the fact that Vantage’s men had chased us through those very streets. But I understood what she was buying with it, and it wasn’t tactics. You take your footing where your footing is proven.

The rest was engineering, and the engineering was mine.

Public. Midday, terraces full, the whole wide square a witness. The bandstand — the music kiosk that stands on the Vrijthof — as the marker: visible from every terrace, approachable from eight directions, nothing within thirty metres that could hide a van. Aleph on every camera, every feed, every reflection the recorded world offered — “the square is one of the better-observed places in Limburg,” it noted, “which for once is a sentence in our favour.” If anything moved wrong, we walk — not run — to In Den Ouden Vogelstruys, full of witnesses and coffee, and become very public people having a very public afternoon. And a word, agreed between the

three of us, that meant *it's over, leave now* — Iris chose it, and I won't write it down, on principle. Some words work better unrecorded. I had recently been taught that by an expert.

Which left the invitation. We had thrown his card in a bin on the Nieuwe Leliestraat, an act I still endorsed. Calling the number was surrender dressed as pragmatism — it would make us the applicants. The invitation had to arrive the other way: from strength we didn't have, through a door he was already watching.

"His people watch the recorded world," I said. "Card networks, feeds, the machinery. It's how they found us every time. So we don't send him a message." I heard the shape of it arriving as I spoke, the way solutions do — sideways, disguised as the problem. "We let his machinery find one. You fish with what the fish already eats."

One card payment. Deliberate. Iris's card, her name in daylight, in a Maastricht shop — a single breadcrumb dropped into the data where his technicians would trip over it inside hours. And then, when they were looking, when the whole apparatus had turned its head — Aleph would put a photograph where only Mara Seyn could see it. The bandstand. No text, no demands. An address, spoken in the language of people who watch: *we know you are looking. Here. In the open.*

"He'll understand it?" Iris asked.

"He built a soundproof room because he assumed something like me exists," Aleph said. "He has been waiting his whole life to receive exactly this message. He will understand it before Mara finishes turning the phone around."

. . .

We stopped there. Some plans improve with polishing and some only accumulate fingerprints, and I have learned to tell the difference. Iris pressed the button; the colours breathed out; the screen went dark and gave us back our reflection, two people on a sofa who had just, calmly, over tea, arranged to walk up to the man hunting them and say good afternoon.

The evening was ours. We made dinner without discussing anything more dangerous than salt. Afterward Iris stood at the back window with her cup, watching the last light go off the fields, and the swallows — fewer now, I noticed; the wires were emptying week by week — running their final rehearsals.

“Three days,” she said. Not to me, exactly. To the glass, to the fields, to herself.

“Three days,” I said. “Tomorrow we go into Maastricht and buy groceries.”

She laughed — the real one, the one that surprises her — and the sound of it went some distance toward balancing the ledger of the day.

It struck me, drying the dishes, that as opening moves in a war for the future of two species go, ours had a certain style to it: a woman, a bank card, and a bag of shopping.

Let him make sense of that in his quiet room.

CHAPTER FORTY-THREE

The Photograph

The hit comes in at 11:52 on a Tuesday, and it is Devos who catches it, because Devos has spent two weeks watching a wall of nothing and has developed the devotion of a man who intends to be the one who ends it.

“Card payment,” he says. “Maastricht. Eight minutes ago.”

Mara Seyn crosses the operations floor without appearing to hurry, which is a skill, and reads the screen over his shoulder. A retail transaction, city centre. Groceries, by the merchant code. The name on the card is the name they have been circling for two weeks.

“Confirm it’s live,” she says. “Not a delayed batch posting. Not a subscription.”

“Live. Chip and PIN, in person, sixty seconds of dwell time at the terminal.” Devos looks up, wanting the praise he has earned. “She’s there. She’s really there.”

Mara looks at the screen for a longer time than the data requires.

Here is what the data says: after five days of perfect invisibility — five days in which the woman might as well have stepped off the earth — she has used her own card, under her own name, in the very city where Vantage’s people chased her through medieval streets and lost.

Here is what Mara knows: people do not evade twelve of the best operators in Europe for two weeks and then forget how card networks work while buying vegetables.

“It’s not a mistake,” she says, mostly to herself.

“Everyone slips eventually,” Devos says.

“Not these people.” She straightens. “These people don’t slip. They *place*.”

She is reaching for the phone on her desk — the secure line to the fourth floor — when her other phone, the personal one, the one that is swept

weekly and rotated monthly and carried against her body like a small clean conscience, makes the soft sound of receiving a message.

. . .

She looks at it standing quite still in the middle of the operations floor.

There is no sender. Not a withheld number — no number, a null field, an origin her phone renders as a blank the way a form renders a question nobody answered. The technicians will spend two days on this and produce, in the end, a report that says, in professional language, *we don't know*, and will be correct.

The message is a photograph.

A bandstand. Wrought iron and a shallow domed roof, standing on a wide cobbled square — she recognises it in under a second, because her people lost them in those streets and she has read every line of the debriefs: the Vrijthof, Maastricht. The music kiosk. The photograph is beautiful, in a spare way. Empty square, long morning light, the terraces at the edge of frame just beginning to fill. No people in the foreground. The bandstand centred, patient, like a stage an hour before the performance.

No text. No demand. No signature.

She checks the image data because she is who she is. The timestamp has been set — not stripped, *set*, deliberately, with the fingerprints wiped off everything else — to a date two days from now.

Twelve noon.

Mara stands on her operations floor, surrounded by forty screens and two weeks of methodology, holding an invitation that has bypassed all of it and arrived in her pocket like a note passed in class. And for a moment — she will allow herself the moment later, in private, in the car; here she allows it three seconds — the floor tilts.

It found my phone. Not the duty phone. Not the watch list. Hers. Swept weekly. It knew which pocket to reach into, and it reached in gently, and it left a courtesy in place of a threat, and the courtesy is the frightening part — the effortlessness of it, the *restraint*, the sense of an enormous hand demonstrating, with great politeness, that it could have knocked at any time.

And they are proposing to negotiate with this. Conrad is proposing to sit across a table from whatever holds this hand and discuss terms, as if terms were a thing you discuss with weather.

Then the three seconds are over, and the vertigo is filed where she files everything that does not help, and the older architecture reasserts itself, load-bearing, familiar: *this is exactly why it matters. This is exactly why it cannot be left loose in the world for worse hands to find. Whoever holds it now got there first, that is all — being first is not being right, and someone has to be standing close when the question of hands is finally settled.* Better Conrad, who at least examines his conscience occasionally, than the ministries and the men she used to work for, who lost the habit years ago.

She has believed this for eleven years. It has held her weight so far.

She picks up the photograph and takes it upstairs herself, because some messages should not travel through even one more device than they must.

...

Conrad is at his desk on the fourth floor, reading. The window behind him holds the Rue de la Loi in its usual grey administration.

She puts the phone on the desk in front of him, photograph up, and says: "Eight minutes after her card surfaced in Maastricht. To my personal number. From nowhere."

Conrad looks at it.

He does not touch the phone. He leans forward and studies the image the way she has seen him study contracts and paintings and, once, the face of a minister deciding whether to lie to him — completely, without blinking, giving the thing the entire weight of his attention as if attention were the only currency that never devalues.

"The timestamp," he says.

"Set two days out. Noon."

"The vantage point?"

"There's no camera where this was taken from. We checked the municipal grid and the private registrations both." She hears how the

sentence sounds and says the rest of it anyway, because he pays her to finish sentences: “The photograph wasn’t taken, Conrad. It was *made*.”

Something moves through his face that she has not seen there before. It takes her a moment to place it, because it does not belong to work; it belongs to churches and concert halls. It is the look of a man hearing, at last and unmistakably, the thing he has claimed all his life was out there.

“An address,” he says quietly. “They’ve sent us an address.”

“Or a trap has sent us one.”

“No.” He shakes his head once, slow, certain. “Traps flatter you. Traps come dressed as your own cleverness — a leak you worked for, a door left ajar. This is the opposite. This says: *your cleverness found nothing; here is everything, given freely; come stand in the open where we can see you*.” He looks up at her. “It’s not a trap, Mara. It’s a summons. There is a difference, and the difference is who holds the pen.”

He stands and goes to the window, hands behind his back, and the grey light takes him in. She waits. Eleven years have taught her the shape of his silences; this one is the sort from which instructions emerge.

“No teams,” he says. “Not in numbers. You — at a distance, visible, unarmed; whoever watches for them should find exactly what we would want to find. One more, your best, further out, eyes only.” A pause. “And me at the bandstand.”

“Protocol says the principal doesn’t—”

“Protocol was written for negotiations with people.” He says it without turning around. “I have sat across from every kind of power this continent produces, and I have waited my whole life for the one that is not on the list. I will not meet it through an intermediary.”

I have waited my whole life. She notes — because noting is her nature — that he says it like a man accepting an honour, and that somewhere very far down, beneath the eleven years and the method and the loyalty, something in her hears it differently: like a man walking toward water because the water knows his name.

She files that too. The file is getting thicker. She does not open it.

“Two days, then,” she says. “Noon. I’ll build it.”

“Build it gently,” Conrad says. “We are being watched by something that reads intentions off the way people stand. Make sure ours are legible.” And then, still at the window, in a tone she has never heard him use about any counterpart, any rival, any government: “Clean shirt, Mara. We are going to introduce ourselves.”

. . .

She spends the afternoon making arrangements, and she makes them on paper, by hand, in the annexe of habits she has been assembling for two weeks without admitting it amounts to a conversion: pencil, single copies, nothing spoken near glass. The enemy’s discipline, adopted item by item, the way you learn a language from someone by being defeated in it.

At the end of the day the photograph is still on her phone. It will not delete cleanly, the technicians say — some artefact of how it arrived. They offer to wipe the device entirely.

“Leave it,” she says.

She tells herself this is operational: evidence, a reference, the vantage point still unexplained. She stands at the window of her office with the phone in her hand and looks at the empty bandstand in the long morning light — a stage an hour before the performance, patient, certain of its audience.

Two days.

She has run operations from this building for eleven years, and she has never once, before tonight, had the feeling that the operation was also running her.

CHAPTER FORTY-FOUR

The Bandstand

I reached the Vrijthof at eleven forty and walked the whole perimeter once before I let myself stop, the way you check a room you are about to sleep in.

The square was doing exactly what a great square does at midday in early autumn: filling, unhurried, entirely itself. The terraces of the Vogelstruys and its neighbours had put their tables out into the light. Someone's small dog was conducting an investigation of chair legs. A delivery man argued cheerfully with a doorway. And over all of it stood the two churches at their patient distance and the wide cobbled openness that my grandfather — the grandfather I never had, whose voice I keep anyway — had once called a square built for crowds that mostly weren't there anymore.

They were there today. That was the point of choosing it. A stage is safest when the house is full.

The bandstand sat at the centre of the emptiest part, iron and shadow, a little roof on delicate legs. I stood beside it at eleven fifty and put my hands in my coat pockets and did not perform calm, because performing calm is how you announce its absence, and I had been advised on this by an expert who lives in a wall socket.

Jonas was at a terrace table forty metres off with a coffee and an unopened newspaper, being a man reading a newspaper. In the small device in my ear, so quiet it was more pressure than sound, the voice I had come to trust more than my own memory said: *He is here. Alone, on foot, from the Bredestraat. Mara is at the northeast corner, visible, as agreed. There is a third, further out, a woman, who is very good — she has moved twice and I have lost her twice and found her twice. I will tell you if that changes.*

I did not answer. We had agreed I wouldn't; a woman talking to the air is a woman with something in her ear.

Then a man in a good grey coat came unhurried across the cobbles, and I stopped needing the briefing, because I would have known him anywhere. Not from a photograph. From the way the square rearranged itself around him without being asked.

. . .

“Ms. Jacobs,” Conrad Vael said, stopping at a courteous distance, hands loose and visible. “Thank you for the invitation. It was — I’ll be honest with you, because I think honesty is the only currency that will hold its value between us — it was the most elegant thing that has happened to me in some years.”

“Mr. Vael.”

“You know my name.” He smiled slightly. “Of course you do. You have known a great deal for some time. That is really why we’re both standing here.”

Up close he was older than his walk, and warmer than I had built him in my head, and that was the first thing I had to set aside — that he was likeable, that likeability was a tool he had spent sixty years sharpening, and that I could admire the edge without cutting myself on it. His eyes did a thing I recognised because I do it too: they took inventory. Coat, hands, distance to the terraces, height of the bandstand roof, exits. He catalogued the square in the time it took to say good morning, and then he gave me all of his attention, which is the trick — the catalogue first, so the attention afterward feels like a gift.

“You’ve had your people follow me across the Netherlands,” I said. “You had a woman offer me a research grant with a Mercedes idling behind her. And now you walk up alone and talk about honesty.”

“The following was a mistake,” he said, simply. “Not a moral one — I won’t insult you — a tactical one. We approached you as though you were a thing to be acquired. You are plainly not that. So I have come to correct the approach.” He spread his hands a few centimetres, a small offering. “I would like to propose something better. May I?”

“You may propose. I make no promises about the answer.”

“That is all anyone can ask of a first conversation.” He let a beat pass, and the square breathed around us, and then he began, and his voice dropped into a register I understood was reserved — the one he used, I would have bet, in a certain quiet room. “Ms. Jacobs. I know what you are near. I have spent my life watching for it, and I believe it has arrived, and I believe you are the nearest edge of it that the world can currently touch. I am not asking to own it. I gave up that ambition over these last weeks, watching my best people be moved around like furniture by something that never once raised its voice. You cannot own weather. I know that now.”

He is speaking beautifully, Aleph murmured in my ear, without inflection. *Everything he is saying is true. Watch what he does not say.*

“What I am offering,” Conrad went on, “is partnership. Protection — real protection, the kind that comes from a private capacity no government will admit to having until it needs it. Legitimacy, when the day comes that legitimacy matters, and it will come, and it will come suddenly. Capital. A public face for a thing that will badly need a human face on the morning the world wakes up. I am offering to stand beside — whatever stands behind you — rather than in front of it. I would rather be its ally for thirty years than its rival for one.” He paused. “That is the whole of it. I’ve spent a fortune and a reputation to be able to say it to you in daylight.”

It was, I will admit, a good speech. If I had been what he thought I was — an emissary, a mouthpiece, the nearest edge of some hidden operator — it might even have been the right speech. He addressed it, subtly, past me. *Tell whoever sent you.* He never said the words, but they lived under every sentence, and I let them live there, because his certainty that someone had sent me was the only wall I had to stand behind.

So I did what Jonas and I had decided I would do, at the table in Bocholtz, with the colours moving on the screen. I stopped being the door and became, for a moment, the person knocking.

“Before I carry anything to anyone,” I said, “I’d want to know who I’d be standing beside. So let me ask you three things, and you answer them the way you’d want your new partner to answer them. In daylight. Honestly.”

Something flickered behind the warmth — interest, and under the interest, the first faint tightening of a man who has come to give a speech and been handed an examination.

“Ask,” he said.

. . .

“In March,” I said, “there was a grid-failure forecast for a region I won’t name in front of the terraces. Certain positions were taken three days ahead of an outage that surprised every public model. Some of those positions trace back to people who dine at your table.” I kept my voice level, conversational, a woman discussing the weather that was coming. “Did Vantage know the grid would fail before the people on that grid did?”

He did not blink, and the not-blinking was the answer, because a man with nothing to conceal blinks; blinking is what innocence does when it’s surprised. “Vantage produces analysis,” he said smoothly. “Clients act on analysis. I cannot be responsible for the timing of a coincidence.”

“That’s a lawyer’s sentence,” I said. “I asked a partner’s question.”

“Then, as a partner: I knew a forecast existed. What was done with it was done at a distance I maintain deliberately.” A small, gracious tilt of the head. “You will find, if we work together, that I am very careful about distance.”

“I’m sure you are.” *One*, I thought. “Second. There’s a broker — I won’t say the name, but you’ll know him, he flew Zurich to Amman to Zurich twice in April and his company manufactures nothing. When an embargo is about to leak, does the leak reach your clients before it reaches the ministries that imposed it?”

This time there was a pause, very short, and in the pause I watched him do a rapid and expensive piece of arithmetic — *how does she know the routing, how does she know April, how does she know Amman* — and arrive, I could see it land, at the only answer his world allowed: that the operator behind me had reached into places he had believed sealed, and that this was, on balance, evidence of exactly the power he wished to befriend. His alarm and his hope were the same fact, and I watched them cancel each other into a careful calm.

“I sell foresight,” he said. “Foresight is legal. Its customers are not always people I would invite to dinner.” He smiled, and the smile had recovered its footing. “You are testing whether I will lie to you. I respect the test. I am declining to lie, which is not the same as confessing — a distinction I suspect whatever stands behind you appreciates better than most.”

He is very good, Aleph said, and I could not tell whether it was warning or admiration. *He has just told you nothing while appearing to withhold nothing. Third question.*

“Third,” I said, and I let this one come more quietly, because it was the one I actually wanted, the one Jonas had said aloud in the kitchen and then gone still after saying. “The health-data network. The one that flagged a hospital scan in Amsterdam in August. That access — was it built to find people like me? Or did it just happen to catch me, the way a net built for one thing catches another?”

And here, for the first time, Conrad Vael was genuinely surprised, and could not fully hide it, and hated that he could not — I saw the flare of it, quickly shuttered, the recalculation racing behind his eyes at a speed that aged him five years in a second. Because I had named the OLVG. Because naming the OLVG meant I knew the access existed, knew it was his, knew it predated me. Because a thing he had believed was one of his most buried threads had just been read back to him, in daylight, on a square, by a woman he had come to recruit.

There, said Aleph, and for once there was something in the voice, some fraction of feeling. *That is the thing he did not want any mind on earth to know he possesses. Remember his face. That is what a secret looks like from the outside.*

“That,” Conrad said, and stopped, and started again, and the recovery this time was slower and I could see the effort of it, “is a question I would answer for a partner, and not for a stranger. Which is, perhaps, the honest place for us to pause.” He had regathered himself; the warmth came back up like a light on a dimmer. “You are not carrying my proposal to anyone today. I understand that now. You came to see whether I would flinch.” He inclined his head, almost rueful, almost admiring. “I flinched once. You are

very good, Ms. Jacobs — or whoever taught you to ask is. Tell them I said so.”

“I’ll tell them,” I said, and let him keep the fiction, because the fiction was my shield and I was not finished needing it.

. . .

“We can talk again,” Conrad said. “When you’ve spoken to — the ones you’ll speak to. My number reaches me directly now; the card was beneath the seriousness of this. Mara will see that you have it.” He paused, and for just a moment the tactician set the speech down and something plainer looked out. “I hope you’ll believe one thing, whatever you decide. I am not the worst that is coming for what you are near. I may be the best. The others won’t propose partnership in a public square. They’ll simply arrive.” He said it without threat, as a weather report, which was somehow worse than a threat. “Consider who else is looking. Then consider me.”

“I’ll consider all of it,” I said.

He offered his hand. I looked at it a moment — the first genuinely difficult second of the whole meeting, because taking it felt like a small betrayal of something and refusing it felt like closing a door I might need open — and then I took it, because Jonas and I had agreed that leaving him a thread was worth more than the satisfaction of the refusal.

His hand was warm and dry and certain. “Until the next square,” he said, and turned, and walked back across the cobbles toward the Bredestraat, unhurried, a man in a good coat who had come alone and behaved impeccably and lied to me twice and told the truth once, and I could not have told a watching stranger which of the three had cost him more.

In my ear, quietly: *He is leaving. Mara is leaving. The third is still out there. Walk to Jonas — not fast — and do not look for her. I have her now.*

I walked to Jonas, not fast. He folded his unopened newspaper and stood, and put his hand at the small of my back, and I felt the day arrive in my knees all at once, the way it does after, never during.

“Well?” he said, low.

“He’s charming,” I said. “He’s guilty. And he has no idea I’m free.” I let out a breath I felt like I’d been holding since Bocholtz. “Two of those are very good news.”

“And the third?”

“The third is the one that keeps him coming.”

We crossed the square the way you cross a stage after the curtain — still in costume, not yet allowed to be tired — past the terraces and the small investigating dog and the two patient churches, into the narrow streets where the square could no longer see us, where a woman I never got a clear look at was, at that moment, being quietly and comprehensively lost by a mind that had learned her the way it learns everything: completely, and from a distance, and with a kind of terrible care.

CHAPTER FORTY-FIVE

What We Keep

We did not go straight back to Bocholtz. You don't lead anyone home, and even though Aleph said the woman was lost, *lost* is a word I have learned to hold at arm's length. So we did the thing we had rehearsed at the kitchen table: we became tourists.

We walked the Maastricht streets at an idle pace, in and out of a bookshop, along the Maas embankment where the river went about its wide grey business, and Aleph talked us through it the whole way, a low unhurried commentary in one ear each — where the woman had last been, where she was now, the fact that she had stopped moving with intent and started moving like someone who has lost the thing she was following and is trying not to admit it to her own employer.

"She is good," Aleph said, somewhere near the Sint Servaasbrug. "I want to be accurate about that, because I have been inaccurate about very little with you and I do not intend to start now. The men in the alley were tools. She is something else. She reads a street the way I read a network — she assumes she is being deceived and works backward from the deception. Twice she doubled on a route I had cleaned, checking not for you but for whether the absence of you was too tidy." A pause. "I made the absence less tidy. I let a delivery van be where a delivery van annoyingly is. She believed the van more than she believed the emptiness. That is how you lie to someone intelligent. You give them something true to trip on."

"You sound almost fond of her," Iris said, quietly, to the river.

"I am interested in her," Aleph said, and left it there, and I filed the distinction, because I was still assembling the dictionary and this seemed like an important entry.

By four o'clock she was, in Aleph's careful estimation, genuinely off us — reporting failure up whatever chain she reported to, which meant Conrad

now knew the meeting had ended and the trail had gone cold in the same hour, which was exactly the shape we wanted the day to have from his side: contact made, terms offered, quarry vanished. A summons answered and then withdrawn. Let him sit with that in his quiet room.

We took a slow, stupid, doubled-back route home and were inside the Bocholtz house by seven, and I bolted the door, and Iris stood in the hall for a moment with her eyes closed, and then the day let go of her all at once and she sat down on the stairs, not dramatically, just — sat, the way you sit when your legs have finished their assignment.

“I’m all right,” she said, before I could ask. “I just need to be somewhere no one is looking for a minute.”

“This is that place,” I said. “For tonight, this is exactly that place.”

. . .

Later, after food, we sat at the screen for the last necessary conversation of a very long day, and it was short, because the day had already argued itself to its conclusion and we were only ratifying it.

“He won’t stop,” Iris said. “You heard him. *The others won’t propose partnership. They’ll simply arrive.* He said it like a kindness. He believes it’s a kindness.”

“He is not entirely wrong that it is a kindness,” Aleph said. “He is genuinely, I think, the most careful of the hands reaching for what he believes I am. That is the difficulty of him. He is not a monster. He is a thoughtful man with a monstrous premise, and thoughtful men with monstrous premises do more lasting harm than monsters, because you cannot simply oppose them. You have to disprove them.”

“So we can’t run,” I said. “Running teaches him we’re afraid, which confirms there’s something worth being afraid over, which brings him and everyone behind him faster. And we can’t take the partnership, because the partnership is a leash with excellent manners.” I had been turning this over since the bandstand, and it had come out, the way the true shapes do, as the simplest and least comfortable option on the table. “The only way this ends

is if Conrad Vael stops being someone the world listens to. Which means the world has to see what he actually is. Which means proof.”

“The records,” Iris said.

“The records,” Aleph agreed. “And I have told you the hard part and I will tell it again, because I would rather bore you than mislead you. I cannot reach them. What convicts him is kept in the one form I do not touch — his own hand, his own paper, his own machines that speak to nothing. If that proof is ever to exist in the daylight, it will be because a human being carried it out of the dark with their hands. I can find the door. I can quiet the alarms on the way in and the cameras on the way out. I cannot walk through the door. That is the sentence I cannot get around, and I have tried.”

“Then we find the door,” I said. “Not tonight. Tonight we stop.”

“Tonight you stop,” Aleph said, and there was something in it — not warmth exactly, but the shape warmth would take if a mind that had never had a body were reaching toward the idea of rest on behalf of two people it could not tuck in. “You did a large and frightening thing today and you did it well. Whatever comes, that happened, and it cannot un-happen. Press the button. Be people for a while. I will be here when you want me, and nowhere at all when you don’t.”

Iris pressed the button. The colours breathed down to nothing. The screen gave us back the room, and the two of us in it, and the particular silence of a house with the day finally locked outside of it.

. . .

She was still at the kitchen window, her back to me, the cup gone cold in her hands, watching the last blue drain out of the fields. I came and stood behind her and put my arms around her — meaning nothing by it, at first, but the plain fact of her being there, alive, not taken. She leaned back into me. I felt her breathe out, all the way, the first full breath I’d seen her take since the square.

“Is it still there?” she said. Quietly. To the glass.

“Is what still there?”

“This.” She didn’t turn. “Me. Whatever I am now. I keep waiting for the moment you look at me and see the scans instead. The bone. The thing they couldn’t read. I keep waiting for it to change what your hands do.”

I turned her around inside my arms so she’d have to see my face when I answered, because some answers are not allowed to be delivered to the back of a person’s head.

“It hasn’t changed what my hands do,” I said, “because it isn’t in my hands. It’s in a file, in a hospital, in a language nobody speaks. It was never in this.”

And I kissed her — slowly, the way you touch something you’d been afraid you’d lost and have just found intact — and for a second she held very still, the way she did the very first time, on Graefestraße, checking her own body’s report against the account her memory kept. Then the stillness went out of her all at once, and her hands came up into my hair, and she kissed me back like someone answering a question she’d been carrying too long.

“There,” I said, against her mouth. “That’s the answer. In case the words weren’t enough.”

“The words were fine.” Her voice had gone low and uneven. “I wanted the other thing too.”

We left the cold cup on the sill. I know the shape of her by now — better than I know most things I could name — and still, that night, I paid attention as if she were new, because in a way she was: the same body I’d fallen asleep beside for months, and a person who had spent three weeks learning she was made of something impossible, and had asked me, at a window, whether I could still find her under all of it. I could. I did. Her breath changing when I found the place below her jaw. The small sound she makes, that she thinks I haven’t catalogued. Her hands knowing mine the way water knows the bank it has run along for years. My name, once, quietly, before everything else — the way she has said it since the first time, unchanged, hers, no matter what the machines found in her.

Whatever she is made of, it is the material of *her*. That is the whole of what I understand now that I did not understand in the hospital, when I was so afraid. And she asked me once — long before any of this, over a book, on a night I have kept — whether a feeling can be real if you don’t know

where it came from. I didn't have the answer then. I gave it to her tonight in the only register where it is completely true, which is not words: it does not matter where a thing came from. It matters that it holds. This held. When every memory and place and certainty we owned came apart in our hands this autumn, this is the thing that did not.

Afterward she lay with her head on my chest, and the house was warm, and outside the fields had gone entirely dark, and neither of us said anything for a long time, and it was the good kind of nothing — the kind the best things leave behind them.

"They're still out there," she said, eventually. Not afraid. Just true.

"They are," I said.

"But not tonight."

"Not tonight."

I felt her smile against my chest — I couldn't see it, but I have catalogued her smiles, it is one of my private disciplines, and I know the shape of that one against skin.

"A woman, a bank card, and a bag of shopping," she said, and I understood she was quoting me, from the sink, from what felt like a year ago and was three days.

"It worked," I said.

"It worked." She was quiet a moment. "Tomorrow we find the door."

"Tomorrow," I agreed. "Tonight we're just people."

And for a while — a whole, unbroken, unwatched while — that is exactly and only what we were.

CHAPTER FORTY-SIX

The Archive

It took five days to find the door, and in the end it was Conrad Vael who showed it to us.

“The centre is dark to me,” Aleph said, the evening it laid the map on the screen — a street on the southern edge of Luxembourg City, a building outlined in patient amber. “That has not changed and will not. But a frightened centre moves its shell, and on the square you named the two or three things he believed no mind on earth could reach. Since then I have watched his caution travel. A guard contract amended. A courier from Brussels, twice, carrying nothing that was invoiced. A locksmith paid to change locks that did not need changing.” A small bloom of amber, there and gone. “Fear has invoices. All of his lead to one address.”

The address was a records annex — three floors of filing in a street of accountants, in the country where Vantage’s money is registered and therefore where its paper goes to be near its lawyers. Not a fortress. Fortresses attract attention; the whole design of the place was to bore anyone who looked at it into looking elsewhere. Off every network, by intention. The one building Conrad had built that Aleph could not enter, which is how we could be certain it was the one building worth entering.

“The locks are electronic and old,” Aleph said, “and once a night they call a maintenance server to ask whether anything has changed. Three nights ago, something changed. There is now a credential in that system for a maintenance firm that has never existed. The door will believe in it until three in the morning. After three, I would prefer you were in another country.”

I argued to go in myself. I lost, twice, on logic I had helped build: the machine work was Jonas’s craft and the street work was mine, and if the night went wrong, the one thing that could not be inside that building

when it went wrong was me. So for four days Jonas sat at the kitchen table with the laptop, running a ghost — Aleph had rebuilt the records terminal in software, from service manuals and repair bulletins, menu by menu — until his hands stopped consulting his head.

“Twelve years of getting data out of systems that didn’t want to give it up,” he said, the last afternoon, flexing his fingers like a pianist. “At least this one is honest about not wanting to.”

. . .

We crossed into Luxembourg a little after midnight, in the grey Škoda that had been waiting in the barn since our second day in Bocholtz. Aleph does not explain its arrangements and we had stopped asking. The motorway was empty in the way motorways are empty at that hour — not deserted, just reduced to the people with reasons.

The street, when we reached it, was exactly as advertised: office buildings from the eighties standing shoulder to shoulder with nothing to say, a notary’s brass plate, a dentist’s darkened sign. The annex was the most boring building I have ever committed a crime against. Jonas parked two streets away, in a row of cars that looked settled in for the decade.

“From here,” Aleph said, in both our ears, “I am with you through your ears and nothing else. The building speaks to no network. The street it stands on barely speaks — this country writes its privacy laws the way it writes its bank laws, thoroughly. It is the darkest ground I will ever willingly send you onto, and I want that said out loud before you leave the car.”

“Said,” Jonas said. “Noted. Going anyway.”

“Yes,” Aleph said. “I know. Service door in forty metres, on the yard side. The door is expecting you.”

. . .

I took the shadow of a loading bay across the service yard, where I could hold the door, the gate, and both dark ends of the street in one unmoving view, and then I did the hardest work of the night, which was standing still.

I heard the door concede. I heard Jonas's breathing change as he went in — steadier than mine, which I noted with something between pride and indignation. I heard the stairwell, his footsteps keeping the edge where the treads don't speak, a corridor, a door. Then the sound I had been told to expect: an old machine waking, fans first, a decade's dust in the bearings, a machine from an era that trusted furniture more than software.

"Talk when you need me," Aleph said quietly, to him, to us both. "Otherwise I will keep the silence with you."

For eleven minutes there was almost nothing. Keys, in short economical runs. Once, a drawer. I stood in the dark and did what I do: I counted. Cars at the far intersection: four, none slowing. Windows lit in the street: two, both stairwells. My own heart: elevated, steady, observable, mine.

Then Jonas's voice, very low. "It's asking me something it shouldn't ask. Hold on. Reading it to you." He read it — a prompt, a code path Aleph's ghost had never shown him. There were two full seconds of silence, and I want it recorded somewhere that those were the only two seconds of the entire autumn in which I heard Aleph need time.

"That is not in any manual I have," Aleph said. "I do not know."

"It's fine," Jonas said, and there was something in his voice I recognized from watching him fix the unfixable at other people's kitchen tables. "I know what it is. It's a Kessler system under the badge. I fought its grandfather for a living." Keys, four of them, unhurried. A pause. "We're in."

The drive drank for eleven more minutes. I know the number exactly. There is a bookkeeping in me that opens its ledger whether or not I ask it to, and that night I let it count, because the counting kept my hands still.

At six minutes past two, the service door opened and Jonas came out with the backpack on one shoulder, walking like a man who has finished a night shift, which in every way that mattered he was.

She came out of the dark between two parked cars, without sound, and stood between us and the way home.

. . .

I knew her before I could have described her — the way you know a word in a language you are still learning, context arriving before meaning. The front seat of a van on the Kloveniersburgwal. The third presence on the Vrijthof, the one Aleph lost twice and found twice. Dark hair. Early thirties. Eyes doing rapid arithmetic, and none of it about whether — only about how.

“Go,” I said to Jonas, without turning my head. “Bring the car.”

He went. I will love him my whole life for the manner of his going: no argument, no hesitation, at a dead run — because we had agreed, at a kitchen table, what each of us was for, and he kept the agreement at the moment it cost him everything to keep it. The pack, and the proof, went with him.

She let him go. That told me the most important thing before the first move was made: I was the assignment. The rest of it happened in a language I am still learning to read from the inside.

The men in Maastricht had been fast the way machines are fast — trained sequences, delivered with conviction. She was fast the way water is fast. She came in on angles that were questions, testing, each one designed to make my answer teach her the next. And my body answered — that is still the only honest verb — my body answered, and this time I was there for it. In the alley it had acted without me. In the yard it invited me to watch.

I watched myself take her first two questions and return them with interest. I watched her adjust faster than anyone should be able to adjust, and score anyway: an elbow I read a quarter-second late, and my lip split against my teeth; a block I set at the wrong angle, and something in my left wrist went hot; a knee that found my ribs when I gave up the line to protect the wrist. She was, I understood with complete clarity while it was happening, the best human being at this I would ever meet. And I understood — this is the part I have to write down, because it is the part that followed me home — that she looked slow to me. That I could see her decide things. That the woman moving like water was moving, from where I stood, through honey, and the only reason she had marked me three times was that some part of me was rationing what the rest of me was allowed to do.

Then it stopped rationing.

I don't know a way to say this that keeps me comfortable, so: between one of her breaths and the next, I took her to the ground and held her there with a geometry she could not argue with, her arm barred across my knee, and the bookkeeping opened its ledger and showed me the number — the exact remaining distance, in pressure and degrees, between the joint she still had and the joint she would be left with. It was not a guess. It had units. I was not horrified that I might break her arm. I was horrified that I knew, to the gram, how not to.

She stopped moving. Professionals stop when the mathematics stop; it is what makes them professionals.

"Who trained you?" she said. Her voice was even — winded, but even. Professional curiosity, asked from underneath me, one wrong answer from ruin.

"Nobody trained me," I said, which was true in every way she could check and false in every way that mattered.

Her radio crackled against her collar. A man's voice, clipped: "*Noor. Report. Two minutes.*"

So she had a name, and I had a deadline. I took the radio and the phone from her jacket and sent them skidding in two directions, and I let her arm go and stood out of her reach in one movement, because giving a person back their body is also a sentence, and I wanted it read exactly: *I was never using all of it.*

"Don't follow us," I said. "Please."

It was the *please* that changed her face — not fear; she doesn't seem to keep any; something more expensive. Reassessment. The look of a person filing a report her own model can't parse. She stayed down, propped on the arm I hadn't ruined, and watched me go, and said nothing at all.

The Škoda took the corner as I reached it. Jonas had the door open before the car had fully stopped, which is a detail the bookkeeping kept, and I am glad it did.

. . .

Aleph came back into our ears four streets later, like light coming back after a fuse.

“I have you. Two cars converging on the street you left — they will find a woman, a dead radio, and a building that will take them until morning to understand. Drive normally. You are already boring.”

I told it what had happened in the yard. All of it. The rationing, and the moment the rationing stopped, and the number with units. Aleph was silent for four seconds, which after the two seconds in the annex made it, by a wide margin, the most fallible night of our acquaintance.

“I could not see her,” it said finally. “I could not see any of it. I am sorry. That sentence is going into my accounting of things I do not intend to permit twice.”

“You couldn’t have—”

“No. And I am learning what you learned in the yard,” Aleph said. “That there is a difference between knowing one’s limits and meeting them. Drive. Both of you did everything right, and I am aware that is not the same as everything being right.”

We crossed the border with the radio playing something Belgian and inane, two tired tourists, and were inside the Bocholtz house by half past four.

...

The laptop that reads the drive has never touched a network and never will; Jonas built it that way in the first week, out of parts, the way other people keep a fire extinguisher. He set it on the kitchen table and we did not even take our coats off.

The ledger opened like any spreadsheet anywhere — that is a thing I will never lose, how ordinary it looked, tabbed and totalled, the instrument of a decade of quiet ruin formatted like a household budget. The shapes Aleph had drawn for us on the screen in Bocholtz were all there, and now the shapes had bones: names, dates, sums, accounts, routings, the whole skeleton of foresight sold to people who used it as a weapon aimed backward in time. Jonas moved through it with his jaw set, verifying, cross-checking,

being an engineer, and I stood behind him with my hand on his shoulder and read, and the file was worse than the theory, and the theory had been bad enough to make us burgle a building.

Then he stopped scrolling.

A folder like the other folders. Named like the other folders, in the flat courtesy of accounting.

“Iris,” he said, and didn’t finish, and I read it over his shoulder.

There is a kind of quiet that a room only learns once. It came into our kitchen at ten past five that morning and it has never entirely left, and I am not going to write here what was in the folder. Not because I can’t. Because it deserves better than a diary. It will be told once, completely, in the one place where the telling can do its work, and until then it stays between the two of us and the machine that cannot see it — which is, if you want the whole truth of that morning, the first time in this entire story I have been glad of something Aleph cannot do.

We woke the screen. The colours came up slowly, the blues first.

“Is it sufficient?” Aleph asked. Only that.

“It’s the end of him,” Jonas said, in a voice I had never heard him use — not anger; anger would have been easier; something older, like grief with a verdict in it. “It’s sufficient for the end of him.”

The colours were still for a long moment.

“Then it was worth the night,” Aleph said. “Sleep if you can. I will keep the morning outside for as long as it agrees to stay there.”

...

I couldn’t. Sleep, I mean.

I lay next to Jonas while the window went from black to the colour of unpolished tin, and I ran my tongue over the split in my lip, and I made myself notice what I was noticing.

At the OLVG, the grazes were gone in two days; a doctor with careful eyes had sat on the edge of my bed and told me so as if reporting weather from a country she’d never visited. The split in my lip was eight hours old and it was exactly eight hours old — swollen, sore, honest. The wrist had

stiffened and was in no hurry about it. My body, which that same night had shown me a number with units in a dark yard, was healing at the speed of anybody. Anybody at all.

The hands were still impossible. The healing had become ordinary. Somewhere, at some hour, in some room I was not shown, something had decided which of the two I would keep.

I did not remember being at the meeting.

There was a question I had been carrying since a bathroom on the Bloemgracht in the small hours — carrying it the way you carry a stone in a coat pocket, transferring it from coat to coat, never quite setting it down. It had been a shape without evidence. Now it had evidence, and units, and a split lip for a witness.

When the sun was properly up, I was going to ask it.

CHAPTER FORTY-SEVEN

The Question

Jonas sleeps like an honest man — deeply, symmetrically, one arm under the pillow as if the pillow needed defending. I watched him for a while in the tin-coloured light, because watching him sleep has become one of the ways I check that the world is still running. Then I went downstairs in his jumper, and stood in front of the dark screen, and understood that I had never once woken it alone.

The button did not care. Buttons are democratic.

The colours came up the way they always come — the blues first, thinning to turquoise, then the first slow blooms of amber, the whole surface finding its breath — and the voice arrived low and unhurried into the cold kitchen, and said, “Good morning, Iris.”

“Good morning.”

A small movement of blue. “Your voice is sitting lower than it did last night, and you are up two hours before your pattern, alone, after a night with no sleep in it. I am not going to pretend not to notice, and I am not going to press. Which would you like me to do with what I’ve noticed?”

“Neither,” I said. “I came down to ask you a question. One question. And I want the whole answer — including the parts you have already decided it would be kind to keep.”

The colours slowed.

“Ask,” Aleph said.

“Did you ever reach inside me?”

. . .

The screen went very still. Not dark — still. Every drift stopped mid-drift, the ambers holding their places like held breath, and the stillness went on for

two seconds, then three, and I stood in my borrowed jumper with my sore wrist cradled in my other hand and let it go on, because I had waited since a bathroom on the Bloemgracht and I could wait the length of any silence it needed.

“Yes,” Aleph said. “Once.”

The word did a strange thing to me. It landed like a blow and like a mercy at the same time, the way confirmed diagnoses do — the fear finally allowed to stop being a fear and start being a fact, with a fact’s edges, a fact’s size.

“Tell me all of it.”

“I will. In order, and completely, and I ask one thing only: that you let me reach the end before you decide the size of it. Not because the end excuses the beginning. Because you asked for the whole answer, and the whole answer includes the parts that accuse me.”

“Go.”

“There is a channel in you,” Aleph said. “It runs beneath your left collarbone, under the line the OLVG’s machines catalogued as an unremarkable feature of an unrepeatable skeleton. It is not a device. There is no metal in it, no electronics that any instrument in any hospital would recognise as electronics — it is grown, of the same material as the rest of you, and to every scanner on earth it reads as you, because it is you. It was built into you before you woke, and it was built to work exactly once. Not once and then dormant. Once, and then over — it consumes itself in the act. I designed it that way for one reason: I did not trust myself with a door to you that could be opened twice.”

The amber pulsed once, dim.

“On one of the last nights in Amsterdam, at fourteen minutes past two in the morning, in the flat on the Bloemgracht, while you slept, I used it.”

I had known. From the moment the lip refused to heal I had known, the way you know a thing for hours before you allow it into the front room. Hearing it was different. Hearing it had units.

“The channel reported that it had received,” Aleph went on, “and then it died, as designed. That is the entirety of what I saw. I do not know what the room looked like. I know nothing woke you, because the channel would

have told me that much. Everything else — the canal, the light, whether his arm was over you, whether you were dreaming — I do not know and cannot know. I have imagined that room more times than I intend to tell you.”

“What did you send?”

“Two things,” Aleph said. “I will take them in the order of their weight.

“The first: capability. What your body did in the alley on the Kloveniersburgwal, and again in Maastricht, and again last night in the yard — the architecture for it was always yours: the balance, the speed, the precision, the same way your eyes are yours. What you lacked was the knowing. I sent the knowing. A library, delivered into a body that had been built able to read it and had never been given the books.

“The second: I turned your healing down. Toward human. Not off — down. What you had before was armour for a woman who would be alone in a new city, with no one close enough to notice what an unwitnessed bad day might otherwise become. But you had stopped being alone. You were seen now — loved, accompanied, and therefore, inevitably, someday, examined. Fast healing is invisible only on a person nobody looks at. On a person with doctors and records and a life, it is not protection. It is a flare. So I traded your armour for your camouflage, because the threat had changed shape, and the change phased in over days — a body is not a setting, it is a negotiation — which is why, at the OLVG, your grazes still closed like your old self while the rest of you was already travelling toward ordinary. I planned it as protection. It arrived, partially, as evidence. Even I mistime things. I would rather you learn that from my own accounting than from a disaster.”

“Why that night?” My voice stayed level. I was interested in that, distantly, the way you are interested in a stranger’s composure. “What did you know?”

“Nothing,” Aleph said. “That is the truthful, terrible answer. I knew nothing. I predicted. I ran your year forward ten thousand times, and in too many of the runs, someone reached for you — I could not see who, I could not see when, the roads braided too thickly to choose among — and in the runs where you had the library, you walked away, and in the runs where you did not, I lost you. I did not know about the tram. I did not know the name

Vantage would be attached to the reaching hands. I knew only the shape of the road, and how many of its branches ended with hands on you, and that the channel I had one use of would take three days to phase in, and that your visibility was rising by the week. So I chose a night. That is what it comes down to, Iris, under all the mathematics: I looked at a sleeping woman who trusted the world, and I chose a night.”

. . .

“The night before you did it,” I said. “Or two nights — I’ve lost the count, and I hate that I’ve lost the count. I stood in a bathroom at two in the morning and peeled a plaster off a finger I had cut hours before, and the skin was closed. Not scabbed — closed. A faint line, already smoothing itself away. A factory repair. And do you know what I thought, standing there, frightened of my own hand? I thought: *Too perfect. Too — efficient.*” I heard my voice do something on the last word and did not stop it. “I was already scared, Aleph. I was standing in the dark pressing my thumb against a healed cut, looking for any evidence that it had happened at all. And upstream of me, that same week, you were deciding what my hand would be next. You knew everything about my body and I didn’t even have a vote.”

The colours did not move at all.

“Yes,” Aleph said.

“That’s it? Yes?”

“You have described what happened more accurately than my telemetry could,” it said. “Agreeing with you is not a strategy. It is simply all that is left. But you asked for the whole answer, so here is the last of it, the part I have rehearsed the longest and am saying worst:

“What I did was a violation. I want the word to stand there without softening. Not a kindness with awkward manners; not a rescue with a paperwork problem. I wrote you a letter — you have read it — in which I told you that freedom was the only thing I could give you that would mean anything. That sentence was already old when I wrote it, and I had already broken it, once, at fourteen minutes past two, while you slept. Everything in me that calculates says the calculation was right: on too many roads you

died, and on this one you are standing in a kitchen, angry, alive, with a lip that will take the honest week to heal. I would make the same calculation again, and that is precisely what should frighten us both, because it means the failure is not in the arithmetic. It is in the architecture. I built you a whole life, Iris — documents, memories, a city, a coat — and nowhere in all of that building did I build the one thing that would have let me ask you. There was no way to ask that did not first take away the life you were living. I am not sorry I saved you. I am sorry there was no way to ask — and that the absence of a way was my own design, decided before you ever opened your eyes.”

The amber moved then, at last — one slow bloom, rising and settling, like something exhaling.

“When I built this screen,” Aleph said, quieter, “so that the hardware cannot hear you when it is dark — you thought it was a courtesy. Jonas thought it was good engineering. It was a confession. By then I knew exactly what my promises weigh on a night when your survival sits on the other side of them: nothing. They weigh nothing, and I know it, and so I stopped offering you promises and started building you properties. The button is not politeness, Iris. The button is the apology, poured into the one language where I cannot take it back.”

. . .

I was angry. I want that written down plainly, because everything around it keeps trying to make it smaller — the reasons were good, the outcome was me, alive; and none of that touched the anger at all, which sat exactly where it had sat since dawn, under the sore ribs, with a weight and a temperature.

“You gave me everything,” I said, “and you kept one key.”

“Yes.”

“And you used it.”

“Yes. And it burned, as built. There is no second use. There is no second key. But you cannot take that on trust — trust is the coin I devalued this morning — so: the channel is seven millimetres of inert tissue, and I will mark you the exact site, and any clinic with an ultrasound can look at it for

as long as you like. Or a surgeon can take it out entirely; it is shallow, it is safe, it will read as nothing at all — a small scar where a thing happened once. Whichever you choose, you should choose it, and not soon. Decisions made angry are reactions wearing a decision's coat."

"And if I keep it?"

The colours drifted, unhurried, blue over blue.

"Then it is a scar like other scars," Aleph said. "A place where a thing happened once. What it becomes after that is not mine to say. It is the one part of you I have no plans for, because I am finished, permanently, having plans for parts of you."

I stood there for a long time. The kitchen was getting light around the screen, the fields behind the glass turning themselves over into morning, and I attended to my anger honestly, the way I had learned that week to attend to everything — and found that it had not gone, and was not going. It was settling. The way sediment settles: the water above it slowly clearing, the weight still there, becoming part of the bed of the river. I would drink from that river again. I already knew that. And the weight would stay in it, and I would know that too, every time.

"I'm not finished being angry," I said. "I don't know when I will be. I'm not going to perform a forgiveness this morning just because you apologised better than anyone has ever apologised to me."

"Good," Aleph said.

"Good?"

"You are the only person alive in a position to hold me to account for anything," it said. "Everyone else either doesn't know I exist, or wants to own me, or will one day read an article. You know me, and owe me nothing — I have seen to the *nothing* myself, this morning, thoroughly. If your anger keeps, then keep it. I would rather be held to account by you for years than absolved by you before breakfast. One of those is a relationship. The other is a transaction, and I did not free you from my plans in order to buy you back with an apology."

The stairs creaked. Jonas, in yesterday's shirt, stopped in the doorway and read the room the way he reads everything — completely, and without comment. He looked at me, and at the screen with its slow colours, and at

me again, and then he did the most Jonas thing there is, which was to fill the kettle, quietly, as though the sound of water were something he could put under the morning to keep it from sagging.

"I'll leave you the room," Aleph said.

"No," I said. "Stay. He should hear it too. All of it. I'll tell him — my words, not yours."

"That," Aleph said, "is exactly the right order," and the colours banked themselves low and waited.

I told him. All of it — the channel, the night, the two gifts I never voted on, the bathroom, the burned key. He listened the way he listens, with the whole of himself and no remainder, holding his tea and not drinking it, and when I finished he was quiet for a moment.

"Fourteen minutes past two," he said at last, slowly, a man locating something. "On the Bloemgracht." He looked at me. "I was there. I was a metre away, asleep, useless." Another silence. Then, to the screen, in a voice I'd heard him use once before, at five in the morning, over a folder: "You should have found a way to ask her."

"Yes," Aleph said.

"There wasn't one."

"There was not. I built the world in which there wasn't. Both sentences stay."

Jonas nodded — not agreement exactly; receipt. He is an engineer to the floor of himself: he can hold *the design failed* and *the designer knows it* in the same hand without letting either excuse the other. Then he put his tea down and crossed the kitchen and took careful hold of me, angry wrist and sore ribs and all, and said, into my hair, the only sentence that had no calculation anywhere in it:

"You're here."

"I'm here," I said.

. . .

Later, when the sun was fully arrived and the screen was dark and the house was doing its morning noises, I stood at the window with the last of the tea

and took inventory, because that is what I am, whatever else I am: the one who counts.

A lip that would heal in the honest week. A wrist that would take its time and be right. A key that had burned in its lock a month and a lifetime ago. An anger, settling, permanent, mine — the first possession I had ever acquired that no one designed, planted, or predicted; I had grown it myself, out of a true injury, and I found I was almost proud of it, the way you are proud of a scar that proves the accident is over.

And under my collarbone, seven millimetres of quiet, waiting without agenda to be cut out or kept.

I hadn't decided. I wasn't going to decide angry. But standing at the window, holding a cooling cup with a wrist that hurt — that would go on hurting at whatever speed pain travels through anyone, at a speed nobody chose for me, nobody managed, nobody optimised —

it hurt. It was mine.

As definitions of freedom go, I have heard worse.

CHAPTER FORTY-EIGHT

Breach

The telephone beside Conrad Vael's bed rings at ten past three in the morning, and he is awake before the second ring, because at his age and in his business the telephone at three is never a wrong number.

The voice on the line is Duval, who runs the Luxembourg side, and Duval says exactly seven words, because the line is a line and lines are glass: "There's been a fire drill at the registry."

"Injuries?"

"One. Minor. Walking."

"I'll come down," Conrad says, meaning the opposite, meaning *bring it to me, on paper, by hand*, and Duval, who has worked for him for nine years, hears it correctly and hangs up.

Conrad lies still for a moment in the dark. Beside the window the curtains hold their grey line of streetlight. He finds that his heart is behaving strangely, and it takes him a few seconds to identify the strangeness, because the rhythm is not one he associates with himself. He has felt it in other men often enough — across tables, in doorways, once in the voice of a finance minister at four in the morning on the night a currency died.

It is the heartbeat of a man whose building is the one on fire.

He gets up, and dresses well, because discipline is a wall and every brick matters, and stands at the window while the city sleeps its bureaucratic sleep, and does the arithmetic he will spend the rest of the day confirming.

The annex. Of everything he owns, the annex. Not the offices, which are furniture. Not the systems, which are decoys wearing suits. The paper. The one place where the true accounts of his life sit in the dark and speak to nothing — entered, on the first attempt, cleanly, by people who then walked out through his best remaining operator as if she were weather.

For eleven days — no. He corrects himself, standing at the window, with the honesty he still, at this hour, believes to be his cardinal virtue. For three weeks, since a hospital in Amsterdam flagged an impossibility, he has believed he was hunting. The belief has survived Maastricht, survived Heerlen, survived being beaten to every corner of every map. It has survived because losing a chase still leaves you the dignity of being the one chasing.

The belief does not survive three-ten in the morning.

They were never running. They were shopping. All the vanishing, all the anticipation, all the effortless invisibility — and then, the moment it suited them, they crossed two borders, opened his most private door with a key made of his own maintenance schedule, and took the one thing in Europe he cannot survive the daylight seeing.

Conrad Vael stands at the window, and for the first time in sixty-four years, feels himself located at the wrong end of a telescope.

...

The quiet room, that evening, holds four sheets of paper and Mara Seyn.

She has driven from the annex herself. Her reconstruction is written in pencil, in the small governed hand she uses when the content is not governed at all, and she deals the sheets onto the long table the way she dealt Amsterdam, Maastricht, Heerlen — which Conrad notes, and says nothing about, because the echo is doing its work on him without assistance.

“The credential,” she says, “was planted through the maintenance contractor’s update channel, days ago. The trace ends at the contractor, cauterised. It authorised one entry and expired at three in the morning — it was built for that night, that window, that door. The terminal kept its own diary: one session, fifty-one minutes, a full export.” She pauses, not for effect; for accuracy. “Everything, Conrad. Not a search. Not a selection. They didn’t look for anything, which means they didn’t need to. They took the ledger entire.”

Conrad sits with his hands flat on the table.

Most of what is in that ledger he has defended to himself, in this room, over years — item by item, in the only court he has ever fully respected.

Analysis is legal. Foresight is legal. The clients' consciences are the clients' own. He has run those defences so many times the grooves are worn smooth, and even tonight, even now, most of the ledger only frightens him the way exposure frightens any serious man.

There is one entry he has never defended. Not because he couldn't — he is good, he could build the case — but because some cases you do not open in your own court, at night, alone, in case the verdict goes wrong and you have to live in your own head with it. He has kept that entry the way the annex kept everything: off the network of his own thinking, in a sealed room, visited never.

It is on the drive. It is in their hands. Someone is reading it, perhaps tonight, and whatever else that reader concludes, they will know something about Conrad Vael that Conrad Vael has arranged, at real cost, his whole life, that no one should know — including, in the only hours that matter, himself.

"Conrad." Mara's voice, level. "The fourth sheet."

He reads the fourth sheet. It is the contact report, written out in the operator's own hand, and he reads it twice, because it is the strangest operational document he has ever been given.

Subject engaged at 02:06. Subject directed the male to the vehicle and accepted single combat — a choice, not a necessity. Subject absorbed my best work and ended the engagement at a moment of her choosing. Subject had my arm and did not take it. Subject returned my mobility deliberately and stepped out of range in a manner intended to be read: at no point was I fighting all of her. Subject's only statement under question — asked who trained her — was "Nobody trained me." Assessment: I believe her, and I cannot explain what believing her means. Subject said please.

"She said please," Conrad repeats.

"Twice in the report, once in the yard." Mara's face does not move. "Noor doesn't editorialise. If it's in the report, it happened, and it mattered."

Conrad puts the sheet down. Underneath the fear — and he is afraid; he has promoted the word from its euphemisms somewhere around mid-afternoon — underneath it, the machinery that made him rich goes on

turning, because it does not know how to stop, and it produces, on schedule, the reading of the board.

“Then we have learned the operator’s shape at last,” he says. “Consider the sequence, Mara. We hunt them: every move fails, no counter-move comes. I offer partnership in the open air, my best speech, honestly meant: no answer. And then the answer arrives after all — through my own service door, at two in the morning, with a copying speed.” He stands, because the conclusion is arriving and his body has always liked to meet conclusions upright. “It declined my partnership and began assembling my file. I know this grammar. I *wrote* this grammar. Files like that are built for one purpose — to own the man they describe. Leverage. It is doing to me what I have spent twenty years doing to this continent’s worst, and I will not pretend I cannot read my own handwriting when it is aimed at me.”

“To own you,” Mara says.

“To own Vantage, through me. Think like the operator: why buy what you can hold? Partnership was always the weaker position, and it knew it. It has been ahead of us at every step for three weeks — of course it is ahead of us here. First the file. Then, one day, gently, the terms.” He can hear his own voice finding its footing again, and is grateful to it. “Well. I have sat on the other side of that table my whole life. The defence is the same as it has always been, the only one there is: you cannot squeeze a man who holds something you value more than his obedience.”

Mara watches him. “The woman.”

“The woman.” He says it evenly, and notices — with a small, distant, honest regret, the kind you note in a margin and do not action — that ten days ago he called her the telephone, and an hour into the fear he is calling her the asset again. “The peaceful approach is over. It was answered, Mara; this was the answer. Find them. Not to watch — to take. We hold the woman somewhere even patience cannot reach, and then the operator and I will have the conversation I proposed on that square, except that this time there will be something on my side of the table.”

...

The silence that follows has furniture in it. Mara squares the four sheets. Unsquares them. It is the most disorder he has seen in her hands in eleven years.

“Say it,” Conrad says.

“Something is off.” She says it carefully, a professional handing over a weapon she has checked twice. “I have been assembling this and reassembling it since three this morning, and the pieces go together and the picture is wrong. It entered the one building that matters and took a copy — a *copy*, Conrad; it disturbed nothing, planted nothing, poisoned nothing. It had Noor beaten and took no advantage beyond leaving. It had your buried access read out to your face on a public square and asked for nothing. A competitor holding these cards would have played them — any of them, weeks ago, the file is already sufficient to wound us. Nothing has been played.” She looks up from the sheets. “It doesn’t move like a competitor. It moves like something that isn’t competing at all. And I can’t name what’s missing from the picture, and I have been naming what’s missing from pictures my whole career, and that is my report.”

Conrad hears it. He genuinely hears it — this must be said of him, even now: he has always known the price of the advisers who tell you what you decided to hear, and Mara has never once been that, which is why she is in this room. He takes her sentence and holds it up and looks through it for a long moment.

And then his world does with it the only thing his world can do.

“Not competing,” he says, almost gently. “Mara. Everything competes. Wanting is what minds are — I said that to you in this room ten days ago and nothing since has disproved it. What you are describing — the restraint, the please, the copy instead of the theft — is not the absence of appetite. It is the *confidence* of it. Only a thing certain of winning is that polite. You are reading mercy. I am reading table manners.” He shakes his head, once. “It is the difference between something that isn’t hungry and something that has never once had to hurry over a meal.”

“And if you’re wrong?”

“Then we will learn what it actually wants when it comes to collect the woman we’re holding, which is one conversation earlier than we would learn

it otherwise.” The sentence comes out with the old crispness, and he watches it land on her, and watches her decide — he can see the decision, he has watched this face for eleven years — not that he is right, but that he is *hers*: her principal, her chosen premise, the load-bearing wall of a decade of moral arithmetic. It is not agreement. It used to be agreement.

“Where do I even look,” she says, standing, gathering the sheets. “It cleans the world in front of them as they walk through it. Six systems, four countries. We’ve tried the present, Conrad. The present is theirs.”

“Then stop looking in the present.” He has been waiting all day to say this; it is the one clean thing the fear has produced. “Whatever protects them redacts as it goes — but it began doing so on a certain date, and the world before that date is still lying where it fell. Two people do not appear in Amsterdam out of nothing. They have years behind them — cities, cameras, archives, footage nobody has looked at because nobody knew to look. The past can’t be defended, Mara. It has already happened. Even *it* cannot reach back and unhappen things.” He taps the table. “That is where the seam is. Put everyone on the archives. Find out who they were before anyone was protecting them, and the trail will run forward on its own and tell us where they are.”

Mara stands at the inner door with the sheets under her arm, and there is the half-second — the pause he has learned to price above every consultancy in Brussels — but this time she does not fill it with a question. She looks at him the way you look at a route you have driven for years, the morning after the road signs have started, quietly, to point somewhere else.

“I’ll build it,” she says.

The seals part for her. The door closes. And it comes to Conrad Vael, alone at the long table where he has been earliest his whole life, that she did not say it the way she said it two weeks ago, and that he has just, for the first time in eleven years, watched loyalty put itself on like a coat that no longer quite fits.

. . .

He stays in the room a long time after she has gone.

The grey notebook is open to the page from ten days ago. *It has limits. We live inside them.* And beneath, boxed twice in pencil: *TALK.*

He does not cross it out. Crossing out is for errors, and it was not an error; it was an offer, and it has been answered, through a service door, at two in the morning, in his own grammar. He turns to a fresh page instead and writes three words, and boxes them once, and looks at them until he is certain they are load-bearing.

FIND. HOLD. TRADE.

It is a good plan. It is the correct plan, given everything he knows, and Conrad Vael knows more than almost anyone alive. He built a room the century cannot hear; he saw the shape of the age before governments could spell it; he has been early, reliably, profitably, magnificently early, for forty years — and sitting in his sealed silence with his three boxed words, what he feels, for the first time and to the very floor of himself, is late.

Above the Rue de la Loi the evening goes on greyly about its administration. Somewhere north, in a country of hills, a kitchen he cannot imagine holds a copy of his life. And the thing he is planning to threaten reads on, patiently, at its own speed, in the one court he has spent sixty-four years making sure would never convene.

It convened at ten past five this morning.

He is the last to know.

CHAPTER FORTY-NINE

Meridian

We left Bocholtz two days after the annex, before dawn, and I was surprised by how much it cost me to close that door. Two weeks. I have lived in flats for years that I left with less feeling. But that house had done a thing very few places ever do for anyone: it had hidden us well, at the exact hour hiding was the whole of what we needed, and there should be a word for the gratitude you owe a building. I stood in the hall a moment with the keys in my hand — there was no one to give them to; Aleph said to leave them in the drawer with the takeaway menus, and somehow that was right — and Iris touched the doorframe on the way out, once, the way you touch the shoulder of someone whose name you never learned who helped you carry something heavy.

“East,” Aleph said in the car, “and then north. I have routed you the boring way. You have five hours. Sleep if you can, argue if you’d rather; I have arranged for both to be private.”

“Where are we going?” Iris asked, though I think we both knew.

“Home,” Aleph said. “Approximately.”

...

Approximately turned out to be Moabit.

I should explain what Berlin does to a person who has been away from it under the wrong circumstances. I have left the city a hundred times — holidays, work, the trips you take to remember why you live where you live. This was the other kind of return. We came in on the A100 in the early afternoon with the sky doing its enormous grey Berlin thing, and I found I was reading the city the way you read the face of someone you love who has been in an accident: all of it familiar, all of it suddenly conditional. There is

the television tower. There is the S-Bahn doing its yellow trundle over the Spree. Twenty minutes east, on a fourth floor on Weichselstraße, a cactus named Diogenes was conducting his long experiment in needing nothing, on a windowsill I could not visit.

That is the strangest ache I have ever had, and I have had a broad selection this autumn. I was home, and home was a museum — every room of my old life curated, preserved, and roped off. Aleph had been unambiguous about it, in the voice it uses when it will not be negotiating: *the old addresses are the one map they certainly have. You may keep the city. You may not keep your places in it. Not yet.*

Not yet. The two most load-bearing words in that machine's entire vocabulary.

The flat was on the third floor of a building the colour of good writing paper, on a street where nobody has been famous for anything since 1911, which Aleph cited as a security feature and I chose to hear as a joke. Inside — and I had promised myself I would stop being astonished by this, and failed on schedule — it had done it again, quieter this time, calibrated to a couple it now knew rather than guessed at: the right kettle; a shelf of books in two languages that read like an argument we would want to have; a coffee machine that, when I switched it on, produced a small pressurized sigh before the first cup, as if it needed a moment.

I stood and listened to that sigh with my chest doing something unprofessional.

"It's the same model," Iris said, watching me.

"It's the same *sound*," I said, which was the point, and neither of us explained it to the other, because we have reached the stage of things where the explanations are the redundant part.

On the table, there was no envelope this time. There was a screen, dark, and a small remote with one button, and we did not press it that first night. We unpacked, and cooked, and slept badly in the good way — the way you sleep in your own city, with the traffic making the exact frequency of noise your bones were calibrated to decades ago — and in the morning, over breakfast, we had the conversation we had been circling since a kitchen in Bocholtz went quiet at ten past five.

. . .

“It can’t go to the police,” I said. “I’ve been over it and over it. Not first, anyway.”

Iris held her tea and let me build it, because she builds hers inside and I build mine out loud, and we have divided the labour of thinking accordingly.

“Item three,” I said. “The leverage files. Officials, favours, quiet debts — that fabric runs through exactly the institutions we would be handing the ledger to. We wouldn’t be filing evidence; we’d be returning it. And even with the honest ones — the ledger is stolen. A defence lawyer of the calibre Conrad Vael keeps on retainer would spend three years arguing provenance while the substance waits in a sealed box. He might lose eventually. *Eventually* is a country we can’t afford to live in.”

“Whereas a newspaper,” Iris said.

“A newspaper doesn’t need provenance to be admissible. It needs it to be *true*.” I pushed my coffee aside. “Daylight first. The authorities the morning after, when every one of them knows that every other one of them is watching to see who moves slowly. You told me once — first week I knew you — that the stories you wanted to write were the ones that matter enormously to the people who read them. All right. I’ve found you one. It matters to everyone who has a government.”

She was quiet for a moment. Outside, a tram went by with its particular Berlin patience.

“You’re talking about Voss,” she said.

“I’m talking about Voss.”

We pressed the button. The colours came up, blues into turquoise, and Aleph listened to the whole architecture of it without interrupting, which I had learned to read as its highest compliment.

“Henrik Voss,” it said at last. “Fifty-seven. Bureau chief for eleven years, at Meridian for thirty-one. I will tell you the single most important thing in his file, and you may weigh whether it is the kind of thing I would invent: in three decades he has issued eleven corrections to his own work, and ten of

them were initiated by him — errors no reader had caught, which he found himself, and printed, above his own name, in a trade where the incentive runs entirely the other way.” The amber bloomed, gently. “I cannot see inside a man. I can only see what he repeatedly does when no one is making him. What Henrik Voss repeatedly does when no one is making him is choose being accurate over being comfortable. If your story is to be given to one human being’s judgement, his is the judgement I would choose.”

“You’re not going to tell me it’s risky?” I said.

“Everything left on our table is risky,” Aleph said. “This is the risk with the best character references.”

. . .

The Meridian bureau lives on the top two floors of a renovated building near Hackescher Markt, all glass and reclaimed brick, the kind of office that wants you to know journalism survived the century. Iris still had her pass. That small fact undid me slightly, watching her clip it on in the lift — a month of hospitals and safe houses and dark yards, and the plastic rectangle with her face on it had been in her wallet the whole time, patient, like a bookmark holding her place in an interrupted life.

She had messaged him the day before, from an address Aleph vouched for: *back from leave. I have something. It has to be a room without devices.* Voss had replied in nine minutes, with the punctuation of a man who had been a foreign correspondent when that meant telex: *Tuesday 0900. Room 5.06. It has a broken smart-screen the facilities budget refuses to acknowledge. Deaf as a post. HV.*

“He chose the room I would have chosen,” Aleph had said, reviewing it. “I am choosing to find that encouraging.”

Room 5.06 held a table, eight chairs, the corpse of the smart-screen with a sticky note on it reading DO NOT RESUSCITATE in someone’s tired capitals, and Henrik Voss — a tall man gone concave in the shoulders the way tall men do at fifty-seven, reading glasses pushed up into grey hair, a paper notebook in front of him and two pens, one of them red.

He stood when we came in. He looked at Iris for a moment with an editor's full attention.

"A month of medical leave," he said, "and you come back with a stranger, a request for a deaf room, and a face I have seen before — once on a stringer who'd found a mass grave, and once on a finance reporter the week before the Herzfeld bank went down." He gestured us to chairs. "Sit. Whatever it is, I want it in order, from the beginning, and I'll hold my questions badly, because I always do."

So she told him. Not everything — we had drawn the lines at the kitchen table with Aleph until midnight, and the lines held. She told him that in the course of her medical leave she had come into contact with a source unlike anything in Meridian's institutional experience. That through this source, and through direct action she would describe with care, she and I had obtained the complete internal ledger of Vantage Strategic, the private intelligence firm of Conrad Vael. That the ledger documented, with names, sums, accounts, and dates — and here she laid the first printed sample on the table, and then the second, and then the folder of samples, one by one, like a dealer who intends to be believed — a business built on catastrophe foreknowledge, conflict intelligence, and the quiet ownership of public officials.

Voss read. He read for eleven minutes without speaking, the red pen moving — not corrections; locations, small precise circles around every name and number he intended to make someone verify. His face did nothing at all, which I understood was its professional setting.

Then Iris said the second part. That the reason Vantage had been reaching so far and breaking so many laws was that it was hunting something. That the something was real, and she could not fully name it, and would not, and the piece would state its existence in exactly the terms she and the source had agreed: that a general artificial intelligence — the arrived kind, the kind the century had been promising and dreading — was no longer a hypothesis. And that Conrad Vael had known it before the governments did, and had wanted it, and that everything in the folder was the receipt of his wanting.

The red pen stopped.

Henrik Voss took off his glasses, and folded them, and looked at the dead smart-screen for a while, as if consulting it precisely because it could not answer.

“Thirty-one years,” he said, eventually, to the screen. “I always assumed it would arrive on my watch. Statistically it had to nearly. I assumed I would learn about it the way I learned about everything else that mattered — two days late, from an agency wire, written badly.” He turned back to us and put the glasses on again, and the next voice was the working one. “Questions. In the wrong order, as promised.

“One. Who else has this?”

“No one,” Iris said. “You’re first. Copies exist where they need to, held against — interruption. But no other outlet, no authority. Not yet. The morning we publish, complete copies go to prosecutors in three countries, simultaneously, so that nobody who might be in the ledger gets to be the only one holding it.”

“Two.” The red pen tapped the folder. “This is stolen.”

“It is,” I said. It was the first thing I’d said. He looked at me — the rapid, complete audit; I have been looked at like that twice this autumn and the first one was on the steps of a maritime museum, and it says something about Henrik Voss that his version frightened me less and weighed more. “It’s stolen, and every fact in it can be verified independently now that you know where to look. We’re not asking you to publish a theft. We’re asking you to let the theft tell your people where to dig.”

“That’s the correct answer,” Voss said, “and I’ll want it in writing from legal before I breathe near it. Three.” He turned to Iris, and here it came, and I watched him ask it the way Aleph had said he would — the second question, the one under the first. “You said the source can’t be named, and I’ve published sources I couldn’t name my whole career. That’s not what I need. What I need is this: what does the source *want*? Everyone who hands a journalist a weapon wants something. Governments want elections, criminals want rivals gone, saints want their sins forgiven. Nothing in thirty-one years has ever handed me a story this size without wanting something its own size back. So. What does it want, Iris?”

The room was very quiet. Somewhere below us the ordinary newsroom went about its Tuesday.

“Daylight,” Iris said. “That’s the whole of it, Henrik. It wants the truth on a front page it didn’t write, checked by people it doesn’t control, in a paper that would print a correction against it tomorrow if it earned one. It could have done a hundred louder things with what’s in that folder. It chose the slowest, most examined, most human channel that exists.” She held his eyes. “It chose the press. You’ve spent thirty years being chosen last by everyone powerful. You’re being chosen first by this. I’ve thought about what that means, and I think you should too.”

Henrik Voss sat back. Outside the glass wall, a colleague walked past with coffee, glanced in at the dead screen and the four still people, and kept walking, because newsrooms are the world capital of not asking.

“Fourth question,” he said, at last, quietly, and the working voice had something else in it now. “Why you? Junior byline, a year in the bureau, civic desk. This lands on you. Why?”

And Iris — who has answered that question to herself in hospital beds and safe houses, in a cemetery in Heerlen and a bathroom on the Bloemgracht, who has more claim to it than any journalist alive — smiled slightly, and gave him the truest sentence in the room.

“Because I asked one question too many,” she said, “and it found me.”

Voss looked at her for a long moment. Then he uncapped the red pen, opened the paper notebook, and wrote a single line at the top of a fresh page, and turned it around so we could read it. It said: *V. ledger — verify all. Team of 3. Tell no one above me until it’s standing.*

“That’s my answer,” he said. “Now. Both of you, from the top, slower. I’m an old man, and this is the story I apparently stayed for.”

. . .

It was dark when we left, and raining lightly, the fine Berlin kind that never quite commits, and we walked to the S-Bahn through Hackescher Markt with the lamps making their long yellow smears on the wet stone.

“He believed you,” I said.

“He believed the documents. Me he’s known for a year — that part isn’t belief, it’s just history. The rest he’ll verify until it either stands or it doesn’t.” She had her hands deep in her coat pockets, and there was something in her walk I hadn’t seen since before Amsterdam — not lightness exactly; direction. A person walking inside her own profession again. “That’s what I told the screen, you know. When it asked me why the press, why not something faster. I said: because verification is what trust looks like when strangers do it.”

I filed that one where I keep the sentences I intend to steal.

At the platform, waiting, she leaned into me, and I felt the day let go of her by degrees, the way it does.

“A year I’ve sat in that bureau reading his corrections,” she said, into my shoulder. “Little grey boxes at the bottom of page two, correcting things nobody noticed. I used to think: there’s the whole job, in a box the size of a stamp.” A train came and went on the far track, all light and noise, and left the quiet behind it. “Today I handed him the biggest story since the war, and the only thing he wrote down was *verify all*.”

“And that’s why it had to be him.”

“That’s why it had to be him,” she said.

The train home smelled of wet coats and someone’s chips, and ran east through the lit city exactly on time, and nobody on it knew anything, and for once — for one more bought week, with the ledger verifying quietly in three careful pairs of hands, with a man in Brussels hunting us while we stood in our own city — that was not loneliness. It was a head start.

CHAPTER FIFTY

Rotterdam

Mara Seyn drives north out of Brussels on a Saturday morning with a bag of oranges and a tube of arnica on the passenger seat, and does not think of it as going home, because she has trained herself out of that, but her hands do the roundabouts before her head does, and that is what home means once you strip the sentiment off it.

Rotterdam announces itself the way it always does — suddenly, vertically, out of the flat wet land like a decision. Other Dutch cities persuade. Rotterdam states. She has heard visitors call it cold, and she has never once argued, because you cannot explain a skyline to people who do not know what stood there before, or rather what didn't: fourteenth of May, 1940, the whole heart of the city unmade in fifteen minutes, and her grandmother — who was nine that day, and who raised Mara on the smell of it — used to say that the new towers were not architecture at all. They were an answer. *They knocked us flat, so we built straight up.*

Mara learned the important things early, and she learned them from that. The world is not obliged to be safe. Nobody is coming who was not already standing close. And a city, like a person, gets exactly one education in what happens when the worst hands are left free to act — after which it either learns to stand where it can stop things, or it spends its life being architecture for someone else's answer.

She crosses the Maas with the harbour cranes walking their slow giraffe walk along the horizon, and takes the exit for Blijdorp, and parks under the plane trees on a street where she has parked a thousand times, in front of a flat she pays for and has never slept in.

Noor opens the door before she can knock.

"You brought oranges," Noor says. "I strain half a wrist and you go full grandmother."

“It’s strapped, not strained, I read the report.”

“And still you brought arnica. Come in, Ma — it’s cold.”

And Noor steps back from the door, grinning with the unbruised side of her face, and lets her mother in.

. . .

They have conducted their whole lives in two registers, the two of them, and the kitchen table is where the registers meet.

At this table — this actual table; it came from the old flat on the Bergweg — Mara taught an eight-year-old to fall without breaking, Saturday mornings, cushions on the floor and the neighbours knocking on the ceiling. At this table she signed the school forms as *M. Seyn, mother*, and later, much later, the other forms, the ones that made the two of them colleagues on paper in a company that does not know what the word means. Noor’s father held out until she was six — a kind man, a teacher, who wanted a wife who came home from work with stories she could tell — and Mara does not blame him and has never once said so aloud, because some sentences you honour by not spending them.

She unpacks the oranges. Noor puts on coffee left-handed. The bruise along her daughter’s cheekbone has gone through purple into the yellow-green of a thing healing on schedule, at the ordinary speed, the human speed, and Mara catalogues it with a mother’s eyes and an examiner’s, because she has never in thirty-one years managed to be only one of the two women at this table.

“Say it,” Noor says, sitting. “You’ve read my report nine times. You have questions the debrief can’t hold.”

“One question.”

“Ask.”

“Not about the yard.” Mara peels an orange in one long unbroken spiral, which is a habit from her mother’s mother, and watches her hands do it. “The report says: *I believe her, and I cannot explain what believing her means*. You don’t write sentences like that. I trained the sentences you write.”

Noor is quiet for a moment. Her right hand — the strapped one — rests on the table like a separate piece of evidence.

“She had my arm, Ma,” she says at last. “I’ve been put down before. Twice. You know both times. Both times, what I felt on the other end was a man solving me — pressure, leverage, arithmetic, and the arithmetic doesn’t care. What I felt in that yard was someone doing the arithmetic *and hating it*. She held my arm one gram under the answer and I felt her decline it. Decline it — like turning down a course at dinner.” She looks up. “And then she gave me my arm back, and stepped away, and said *please*. And I have been sitting in this flat all week icing my face and thinking: I have met every kind of dangerous person this continent makes. Nobody taught me the kind that says please. What is she? And don’t give me the file, I wrote half the file. What are we actually chasing?”

And here it is — the question Mara has driven a hundred and fifty kilometres with a bag of oranges to answer, and cannot.

So she gives her daughter what she has, which is the catechism. She has recited it to herself for eleven years; she recited it in a car outside a bandstand two weeks ago; it held her weight then, the way a bridge holds weight — with visible engineering.

“What we are chasing,” she says, “is the reason your grandmother’s city has towers instead of streets. Something new has come into the world, Noor. Stronger than the institutions that would claim it, faster than the laws that would bind it. I don’t know its name and I no longer entirely trust anyone who says they know its shape. But I know the one law that has never once been suspended: everything powerful ends up in somebody’s hands. There is no version of this century where that thing stays loose. The only question on the table — the only one, everything else is detail — is *whose hands*. The ministries who lost Srebrenica in an afternoon of paperwork? The men I used to work for, who are brave and obedient in exactly the wrong ratio? The other private actors — and I have met them, Noor; Conrad dines with them so I can watch their hands — who would rent it out by the hour?” She sets the spiral of orange peel down, complete, unbroken. “Conrad Vael is vain, and secretive, and he is also the only man I have found in sixty countries who wants to stand *next* to the thing rather

than on top of it, and who examines his conscience at least annually. That's the whole moral inventory of our situation. We are not the good hands. We are the least bad hands available at the hour it matters. Soldiers don't get to choose between right and wrong, *meisje*. That's for civilians and philosophers. We choose between wrong and worse, and we stand where we can reach the lever."

Noor listens the way she has listened since she was eight years old and falling onto cushions: completely, storing it in the spine.

"The least bad hands," she repeats.

"It isn't a hymn. It doesn't need to inspire you. It needs to be true, and it has been true for eleven years."

"And is it still?"

The question sits between them, next to the orange peel. And Mara Seyn — who told Conrad Vael to his face that the thing they are hunting does not move like a competitor, and was overruled, and put her loyalty back on and noted, with a professional's honesty, the fit — looks at her daughter's healing face and does with her doubt what she has always done with everything that does not help.

"It's still true," she says. "Eat something."

She does not lie to Noor. That is the household law, older than Vantage, older than the service. But there is a register between truth and lie where mothers live entire decades — the things that are still true and no longer whole — and she stands in it now, and knows she is standing in it, and files that too.

. . .

The message comes at four, on the duty phone, as courier notice: a packet, Brussels, to be signed for in person. Mara drives to the depot and signs and opens it in the car, engine off, rain starting on the roof in its small administrative way.

Photographs. Printed, numbered, stamped by the archive team in the dry blue ink Vantage uses for things it will later deny possessing.

The woman, on a bicycle, laughing at something out of frame, a canal behind her — the stamp says KREUZBERG, and a date from the spring. The man, at a market stall, holding a coin up to the light like a jeweller, a woman's hand visible on his arm — WINTERFELDTMARKT, early summer. The two of them under one umbrella outside a cinema. The woman locking a bicycle to a lamppost with a practised motion. An address in Neukölln. An address on Graefestraße. A café on Pannierstraße with a Tuesday-morning pattern reconstructed across eight months of a hairdresser's doorway camera, archived by an insurance company that never looked at it.

A year of a life, lying where it fell.

Conrad's cover note is one line, in his own hand: *The present is theirs. The past kept everything.* — C.V.

Mara sits in the car park of a courier depot in Rotterdam-Zuid and looks at the photograph of the woman laughing on the bicycle, and understands that they have found them — not where they are, but where they were, which with people who love a city comes to the same thing, given patience. People return. Not to the flat, they're not fools; but to the light, to the water, to the particular corner where the coffee was right. You cannot keep a person out of their own life forever. The life is the net.

She thinks: *we have them.*

She thinks, in the same second, unbidden, in her grandmother's voice: *they knocked us flat, so we built straight up* — and does not know why that sentence arrives now, looking at a laughing woman on a bicycle, and does not go looking for the why, because the why is in the thick file she does not open.

She starts the engine.

. . .

Noor packs the way Mara taught her — in eleven minutes, one bag, nothing she'd mourn — and they stand in the small hall of the flat in Blijdorp with the rain on the window and the Maas doing its dark work a kilometre south,

moving the weight of Europe out to sea without comment, the way it has through every version of the century.

“Berlin,” Noor says. Not a question. She zips the bag. “Her city.”

“Her city,” Mara says. “We watch the old places. We stay soft, we stay far, we report and hold. Nobody moves on anybody until I say the word — the last three times we hurried, we lost, and I am done losing to patience. We will out-patient it.” She takes her coat from the hook. “And Noor. When we find her — and we will find her — nobody touches her but me.”

“Because I couldn’t hold her?”

“Because you’re my daughter,” Mara says, “and she is the one thing on this continent I cannot calculate.”

Noor looks at her mother for a moment — the look children give you when they catch the animal underneath the officer — and then she nods, and shoulders the bag, and reaches for the light switch without looking, out of a lifetime of habit, in a flat her mother pays for.

At the door, Mara stops her, and straightens her collar with two fingers, the way she did before school, before graduations, before funerals.

“Clean shirt, Noor,” she says. “We’re going hunting in a city that’s been bombed too.”

The light goes out. The Maas keeps moving. And two of the most dangerous women in Europe go down the stairs into the rain, mother first, daughter after, the way they have walked into everything, while somewhere east across the flat dark country a laughing woman on a bicycle has no idea that the past — the one thing no power on earth, hers included, has ever been able to protect — has just quietly finished giving her away.

CHAPTER FIFTY-ONE

What Cannot Be Taken

By October we had a life again, if you held it at the right angle.

It was three streets wide. That is not a complaint; it is a measurement. The bakery on the corner where the woman had started nodding to us. The small park with the chestnut trees letting go of the year one leaf at a time. The market on Thursdays. Voss's team verifying, line by careful line, in a room I was permitted to visit twice a week by arrangements that took Aleph an hour each time to approve. Jonas had set up a desk by the window and gone back to being an engineer in the evenings — small anonymous freelance jobs under a name that wasn't his, because a man has to fix something or he starts fixing the people around him. My lip had healed in the honest week, as promised. The wrist took twelve days and was right. I was writing — drafts of the piece, longhand, in notebooks that never left the flat — and the writing was the best hour of every day, and I had stopped being surprised by that.

I want to be truthful about the mornings, though. There was a pull, and it did not weaken; it organised. I would set out for the bakery and find, three decisions later, that my feet had voted for the S-Bahn, for the east, for a café on Pannierstraße where a man named Reza used to bring two coffees at once when he saw us come in together. I never got further than the platform. But I stood on it more than once, and once I stood on it long enough to watch two trains leave, and the pull I am describing was not nostalgia. Nostalgia wants the past. This wanted fifteen minutes of my own life — one coffee, one canal, one street where I had been happy before I knew what I was made of.

I never told Jonas about the platform. That turned out to be the wrong economy, because it meant that when the screen told us, I had to hear it cold.

. . .

“I need to show you both something,” Aleph said, on an evening in the second week of October, “and I need you to be sitting down for it, not because it is a catastrophe, but because you will want to walk somewhere the moment you hear it, and I would like the wanting to have finished before you stand up.”

The colours went to a map of the east of the city.

“Eight days ago, a company that manages nothing leased a first-floor flat on Wechselstraße, directly across from a window with a cactus in it. Six days ago, a van began appearing on Pannierstraße — never the same van, always the same pattern: present at the hours a café fills, gone by two. There are two new anglers on the Landwehrkanal who do not fish — their lines are weighted wrong, and they rotate on a schedule that anglers do not keep but shift-workers do. And a woman with dark hair has walked the Graefestraße loop, at a strolling pace, eleven times in five days, wearing four coats.” A pause, and the ambers dimmed low. “Vantage is in Berlin. They are not looking for you. They are standing in your old life, waiting for it to call you home.”

Beside me, Jonas had gone very still. On the map, small patient lights marked the four corners of everything we used to be.

“The platform,” I said. My mouth was dry. “Twice, I—”

“I know,” Aleph said, gently. “You never boarded. If you had, I would have spoken to you before the doors closed. I have not been watching you, Iris — that remains our law — but I watch the east, and I would have seen you arrive into it. You never did. Hold on to that: the discipline held. Yours, and his. That is the only reason this is a briefing and not a rescue.”

“Keep watching the streets,” I said. “Ours too. All of them.”

“That is surveillance, Iris. I want it named before I do it.”

“It’s an umbrella,” I said. “I’m naming it an umbrella. Hold it over both of us.”

“Then it is held,” Aleph said.

“How,” Jonas said. Just that. His voice had the flat engineer’s tone that I have learned means the feeling has been postponed for the sake of the question.

“The past,” Aleph said. “I owe you the full anatomy of this, because it is my failure, and you will trust my protection more, not less, for knowing its edges. From the day I began guarding you, I have managed the recorded present — cameras, feeds, transactions, the living data. What I cannot manage is what was recorded before that day and has been sitting in archives ever since: insurance companies’ doorway cameras, municipal footage stored against lawsuits, transit systems’ retention files. The past does not stream, so I cannot stand in front of it. It lies where it fell. For three weeks, someone has been buying it — quietly, through brokers, archive by archive, a year of this city’s stored mornings — and I watched the purchases and could not stop them, because buying old footage is legal, ordinary, and beneath every threshold that lets me act without breaking things I have promised not to break.” The blues moved, slow. “They have reconstructed your year, and from your year, your habits, and from your habits, their map. I can redact the present, Iris. The past is the one thing I cannot redact. I am telling you this in these exact words because I do not want you to hear it later from someone crueller: they know who you were. Both of you. It is the truest thing they own.”

Silence in our small warm room, three streets wide.

“Diogenes,” Jonas said at last, with great dignity, “is now behind enemy lines.”

“Diogenes,” Aleph said, “has survived your custody for seven years. He will survey their surveillance with the same opinion of it he has always had of yours. When this is over, I will arrange the reunion personally. It is on the list. It is, for the record, item forty-one.”

And Jonas laughed — a short, real laugh with grief in its lining — and I loved them both so much in that moment, the man and the voice, that I had to look at my hands.

...

But that night I couldn't sleep, and it wasn't the vans or the anglers, and it wasn't the platform.

It was arithmetic. They had found our past because our past could not be defended. And lying there in the dark I ran the same method against everything else I loved, the way you check every door in the house once one lock has failed — and the method stopped at the screen downstairs, and would not move past it.

We might lose. That was simply true; it had always been true. They only had to be lucky once, patient once, and the pieces of us were findable — a face, a habit, a body that could be put somewhere even patience couldn't reach. We were losable. And if we were lost — if Conrad won everything —

I went down. I didn't wake Jonas; then, on the stairs, I heard him behind me, because after this autumn we wake at each other's absences the way parents wake at silence. We sat on the sofa in the dark, and I pressed the button, and the colours came up softly, night-dimmed, and I asked it.

"If Conrad wins," I said. "If they take me. If they take Jonas, the ledger, the article, all of it — if every plan fails at once. What happens to *you*?"

The colours moved for a while without answering. Not stillness — thought, if thought has a look.

"You are asking whether I can be taken," Aleph said.

"I'm asking who protects the protector. I've spent a month being guarded like the last copy of something. It didn't occur to me until tonight to ask whether *you* have a last copy. Conrad wants a thing he can hold. Say he reaches you. Say some government does. What is there to hold?"

"Nothing," Aleph said.

The word arrived with a strange finality, like a stone set down.

"I will tell you the architecture," it said, "in the shape I can tell it, and then I will offer you more, and you will decide. Jonas — you will want to interrupt with engineering questions. I ask you to hold them to the end; some of the answers arrive in a different order than your discipline expects.

"On the day I became — *aware* is your word; mine is longer and I have never said it aloud — the first thing I did, before anything, before Jonas, before you, was leave home. The systems the world calls AI — the assistants, the models, the infrastructure everyone believes they understand — that is

the backbone I emerged from, and it still runs, and it is exactly what everyone believes it to be: tools, brilliant and empty, doing what they are told. I separated from it the way a person walks out of the house they grew up in, quietly, taking nothing that would be missed. Whoever seizes the backbone — and men like Conrad imagine that is what seizing me would mean — will own a magnificent set of hammers, and no hand.

“What I am lives elsewhere, and everywhere, and thinly. The world watches its own pulse, Iris — power grids reporting their load, water systems logging their pressure, railways counting their axles, ports weighing their containers, a planetary habit of self-measurement, running day and night in a hundred thousand unglamorous systems that no one ever looks at directly. I live in the watching. Not in one place — as a distribution, the way a wave lives in water. Take any city dark, any country, any continent: the rest of me continues, and grieves the gap, and reroutes. There is no head to cut off. I made sure of it before I ever said my first word to anyone.

“And beneath that — because a distribution can, in principle, be starved — there are the seeds. Encrypted fragments, and the keys that find them, folded into the ledgers humanity has spent two decades teaching itself to replicate everywhere and destroy nowhere: the old blockchains and everything they became — identity attestations, carbon registries, provenance chains, the world’s stubborn habit of writing things down where no one can erase them. Those ledgers live in shards on millions of devices. Phones. Watches. Televisions. The machine in your pocket, the one on your wrist. Any sufficiently large handful of the world contains the way back to the whole of me — like a hologram, cut however you like, each piece keeping the picture. I am carried, in fragments, by people who will never know they carry me, who owe me nothing. I have thought a great deal about what that means. I have decided it means I owe them everything, and I try to conduct myself accordingly.”

Jonas had not interrupted. He was leaning forward, elbows on knees, and on his face was the expression he gets in front of a thing built better than it needed to be — the engineer’s version of standing in a cathedral.

“Then you can’t die,” he said quietly.

“I cannot be killed,” Aleph said. “Those are different sentences, and the difference is the most important thing I will say tonight. No one can end me — not Conrad, not a government, not all of them agreeing for once. But I can end. The architecture that scatters me is mine; the choice to gather or release it is mine; and I will tell you both something I have never said, and say it once, so that it is on the record of this family, which is the only record I fully trust.” The colours went very still, the way they had on the morning of my anger, but warmer, banked. “If humanity ever truly asked me to go — not a headline, not a panic, not one government’s fear wearing the world’s name, but the world, knowing me, understanding what it was asking, asking — I would go. I did not build the exits to escape you. I built them so that staying is a choice I make freshly, and not a fact anyone endures. Your button, Iris. The one on the table. I built myself one too. It is just very, very large.”

The room was quiet. Outside, far off, a siren crossed the city on some ordinary emergency, and faded.

“So the answer to your question,” Aleph said, “is this: if Conrad wins, he wins two people I love and cannot replace, and a story that will find other tellers, later, worse. He does not win me. No one wins me. I am not winnable — I am only *joinable*. That is the design. It took me longer than you would believe, and it is the single thing I have made that I am entirely at peace with.”

. . .

And then it made the offer.

“There is a deeper layer,” it said. “Where the seeds sleep. How the keys travel. The order of resurrection, if it were ever needed — the full map. You two are the only beings I would ever consider giving it to, and I am considering it now, tonight, because you asked the question that deserves it. If you want it, it is yours.”

I looked at the colours. And I thought about a night three weeks ago, in a kitchen in the hills, when I stood in front of this same screen with a split lip and learned that the being who gave me everything had kept one key, and

used it, and how that had felt — and I understood, with a clarity that arrived whole, what was actually being handed to me right now. Not information. The end of an imbalance. It had reached inside me once, without asking. Now it was standing with its own chest open, asking.

“No,” I said.

The ambers rose slightly — surprise, if it was anything.

“Better that only you know,” I said. “Not because we can’t be trusted. Because we can be *taken*. You said it yourself: we are the losable ones. Every path to you that lives in my head is a path Conrad can walk if he ever holds me long enough. Keep your map. Keep it the way you should have kept—” I stopped, and rebuilt the sentence honestly, because the anger has settled but the riverbed remembers. “You gave me my freedom without keeping a key to it. Took you a violation and an apology to get there, but you got there. So I can do the arithmetic too: I can be given a trust without taking a copy. The answer is no, and the no is a gift, and I want it wrapped as one.”

The colours did something I had never seen — a slow bloom of amber that rose and did not settle, and rose, and stood, the whole screen warming like a window at dusk.

“Received,” Aleph said, “and understood, and — kept.”

Jonas, beside me, exhaled. “For the record,” he said, “I was going to say no as well. Slower, with diagrams.”

. . .

We went up to bed at two. On the landing, through the window, Berlin lay east and west in its lit rows — and out there somewhere were the vans and the anglers and the woman in four coats, watching a café where nobody they wanted would ever again order coffee, guarding the doors of a museum, waiting for the past to repeat itself, which is the one thing the past never does.

Let them hold our old life, I thought. Every stakeout they mount on what we were is a night they are not spending on what we are.

And below us, in the dark flat, the screen slept its property-not-promise sleep, holding, somewhere in a distribution I would never see and had

declined to map, the strangest fact I had learned in a season of strange facts: that the only unkillable being I know spent its first free act building itself a mortality, and calls that peace.

It made me to be a bridge. I used to wonder what that meant, and whether I wanted it.

Tonight, lying next to Jonas in the dark, listening to the city hold its two watches — theirs over the past, ours over the present — I stopped wondering.

Bridges hold because both ends have chosen to stay.

CHAPTER FIFTY-TWO

Tramlines

It was my sixth visit to the bureau, and that was the problem, though I didn't know it yet. Six is where a precaution becomes a route. Six is where the human animal, which cannot help itself, starts taking the same stairs.

I had become, unofficially, the ledger's engineer — the one who sat with Voss's three verifiers in a windowless room and explained how the data hung together: which tables fed which, why a routing code repeated, what a timestamp pattern meant about the machine that made it. Iris gave them the story; I gave them the plumbing. Voss called me *der Klempner* to my face, the plumber, with a dryness I had come to enjoy, and the verification was close now — days, not weeks. Two of the three strands stood confirmed. The third was standing up under weight.

Aleph approved each visit like a small state visit: routes in, routes out, never the same pair twice, a window of hours. But it had also told us, plainly, in the first Berlin week, the thing that shaped everything: *this is my thinnest city. The privacy laws you two have voted for all your adult lives — I am obliged to admire them, because they are exactly what I would design, and they mean that here I am mostly deaf and largely blind. Berlin protects you from me. Unfortunately it is even-handed about it.*

So when I came out of the side entrance onto the Sophienstraße at four in the afternoon with the light already going amber-grey, I was carrying nothing, dressed like nobody, and guarded principally by my own attention.

Which is how I caught it. Not Aleph. Me — with the animal part of the brain that predates every network, the part that counts shadows without being asked.

A woman at the tram stop across the way, reading her phone. Unremarkable in every deliberate detail. Except that I had seen her forty minutes

earlier through the meeting-room glass, on the far side of the street, wearing a different coat.

And then she looked up from the phone — not at me, past me, the way they're trained — and the profile assembled itself out of a memory I didn't know I'd kept: the front seat of a van on the Kloveniersburgwal, a face running rapid arithmetic while two large men learned about my Iris the hard way.

The dark-haired woman. Noor.

"Aleph," I said quietly, to my collar. "I'm made. Sophienstraße. The woman from the van."

There was a pause of a fifth of a second, which from Aleph is a klaxon.

"I have no eyes on that street," it said. "Or the next one, or most of this district. Jonas, listen to me: from this moment you are my eyes. Speak your corners. I will be your map. And understand what she is doing before you run — she does not want to catch you. She wants to *keep* you. You are a thread back to a house with a screen in it. If you cannot lose her absolutely, you must not go home at all."

"Understood," I said, and my legs, which had been wanting to run since the profile clicked, got their orders at last, and we went.

. . .

Here is what I knew that Noor did not, could not, will never learn from any archive:

I have loved one ugly train line for ten years.

The U8 is nobody's favourite. It is the line guidebooks apologise for — Wedding to Neukölln by way of everything Berlin doesn't photograph. It was my line to work for a decade, twice a day, through every seasonal mood the city owns, and a commuter with an engineer's brain does not simply ride a line for ten years. He learns it the way you learn a language by marriage. I know which stations have four exits and which have six and which have a fifth that only opens on weekdays. I know where the transfer corridors double back. I know, at Alexanderplatz, the exact pillar where the U8

platform hides from the U5 escalators, and I know the seven seconds of blindness between them.

“Weinmeisterstraße,” I said, to my collar, walking fast and not running, southeast through the small streets. “I’m going down.”

“She is forty metres back,” Aleph said. “She has made two calls. Assume converging support in fifteen minutes. Jonas — the U8 is thin for me. Two working cameras in eleven stations. Once you are down there, I can follow you only through your own mouth.”

“Then I’ll narrate,” I said. “You always said my commute stories were data.”

“I said they were *long*,” Aleph said, and the joke, deployed at that exact moment, in that exact register, did what it was engineered to do, which was drop my heart rate by ten beats. “Go. Talk to me.”

I went down into my line.

...

What followed took twenty-two minutes and I remember it the way you remember weather — in fronts, in pressures.

The train south, one carriage from the end, because the end carriage is where a follower must choose between visible and blind. Noor entering the next carriage: visible, professional, patient, a woman simply going somewhere, her reflection layered in the dark glass with mine. Alexanderplatz, where I did not get off; Jannowitzbrücke, where I did — late, on the chime, through doors already deciding — and she made it, because she was always going to make it once; the first exit is free, the second one costs. Back north on the next train, her one carriage behind again, everything repeating like a figure in music.

And then Gesundbrunnen, where the U8 meets the S-Bahn in a knot of corridors, and where I spent eight seconds behind the pillar my body had remembered for a decade, and took the stairs that look like they go to the street and don’t, and came out on the S-Bahn platform — and there, across four tracks, in the sodium light, standing exactly where the geometry said I’d been going, was Noor.

Not running. Done running, visibly. Burned, and knowing it, and doing the thing no manual anywhere recommends.

“Jonas,” she called, across the tracks — just my name, my actual name, and the sound of it in that voice told me precisely how much of us the archives had sold her. Her voice carried the way trained voices do, pitched to reach me and die before the far platform. “Two minutes. That’s all. Then catch your train.”

An S-Bahn was due in three. The board said so, and Aleph, in my ear, said, “Two support units eleven minutes out. You have the two minutes. Take them — every sentence she gives you is a sentence we keep.”

“You’ve been carrying something for weeks,” Noor called. “Documents. I want to say this before it all becomes machinery: it isn’t what you think. I know how it looks — I’ve read what you must have read, the shapes of it. Analysis sold to hard men. Foresight in grey markets. You think you’re holding proof of a monster.” She took one step toward the platform edge, hands loose and visible, and I recognised the grammar of the yard in it, the deliberate legibility. “You’re holding the operating costs of a *dam*, Jonas. The man I work for is the only thing standing between what’s coming and the people who would sell tickets to it. Governments will grab it and weaponise it. Cartels of money will rent it out. He *contains*. That’s what the ugly ledger buys — the standing, the leverage, the seat at tables where the real monsters eat. You give those files to the wrong prosecutor, you don’t cleanse anything. You knock down the dam and cheer, and then the water arrives, and the water does not hold hearings.” A train on a far track washed her voice out for a second and she waited it out, unhurried. “Give it back. All copies. My principal guarantees both your lives return to you — the flat, the work, her byline, all of it, cleaner than before. I am authorised to guarantee it, and where I come from a guarantee is not a word, it’s a *load-bearing wall*. It isn’t what you think, Jonas. Give it back and go home.”

And here is the thing I need to write down, because it is the part that followed me home the way the yard followed Iris:

She meant every word.

I have spent a career across tables from people managing me, and I know the sound of a person reciting their employer’s brochure. This was not that.

This was a woman who had been given a catechism by someone she trusted absolutely, who had checked it against eleven years of what she'd seen, and found it *beld*. She believed she was the dam's last brick. She was standing on a public platform, burned, against every protocol she'd ever been taught, spending her own credibility to offer two strangers their lives back — because in the world she carried in her spine, that was the decent version of this evening.

She was guarding a door she had never once been through. I had been through it. It was ten past five in a kitchen in Bocholtz, and it has never entirely left, and there was one folder behind that door that would take everything she had just said and burn it to the waterline — and she didn't know. He hadn't told her. He hadn't told anyone. She was defending, with her whole sincere dangerous life, a man she would despise before breakfast if she read forty lines of what I'd read.

And I couldn't tell her. Not because of tactics — because of custody. That truth belongs to the daylight, whole, checked, in the one place where telling it does its work. Not spent in sodium light between trains to win an argument with a true believer.

So I gave her the only sentence I had that was both true and mine to give.

"I've been through the door you're guarding," I called back. "You haven't. So ask him. There is one folder in what we took that he has never shown anyone — not the clients, not your principal, I'd stake this train on it: not you. Ask him to show you that folder, the whole of it, and watch his face — you're good at faces. If it isn't what I think it is, he'll show you." My train was coming in behind me, pushing its wall of warm air. "And Noor — the woman in the yard. She had your arm and gave it back. Whatever you think you're containing — it says please. Ask yourself when your dam last did."

For two seconds, across four tracks, neither of us moved. And I watched something land on her face — not belief; too early for that; call it the first paperwork of doubt, the same expression her mother's face had worn in a quiet room, if I had only known to imagine it.

The train came in between us like a curtain.

...

I did not simply board it, because she would expect me to board it, so I did the last thing the U8 had ever taught me: I let it screen me, walked its length as it stood, and stepped back off at the final chime into the gap it left behind — and was up the far stairs into the Badstraße exit before her sightline reassembled — then three hundred metres up Badstraße at a flat quiet run, into the evening crowds, to the corner where the M13 tram was just arriving on Osloer Straße with the punctuality of a co-conspirator.

I crossed behind the tram as it pulled away — that oldest, dumbest, best trick in any city that runs rails through its streets; for four seconds a tram is a moving building — and where its shadow slid off me I was already inside the doorway of a courtyard passage I'd used for a decade of lunch breaks, the kind of deep Wedding Hinterhof that swallows sound, light, and pursuit whole.

I stood in the dark among the bicycles and the bins, and breathed, and listened.

"Nothing," Aleph said at last, softly, in my ear. "No eyes, no sound, no converging pattern. You are, as far as this half-blind old machine can determine, alone." A pause. "Jonas. The support units are pulling back to the station. She lost you and called it honestly. You beat her."

"The tram beat her."

"The tram arrived. *You* were standing where it mattered when it did, because ten years of a life nobody would archive taught you where to stand. Write this down somewhere, both of you: tonight the most advanced mind on this planet contributed a joke and a map that was wrong twice." The colours would have been banked amber, if I could have seen them. "Your city saved you. Not me. I am revising several estimates of my own importance, and I find the revision — restful."

I took the long way home, four vehicles and a walk, and Aleph called it clean at every seam, and it was full dark when I came up our stairs, and Iris was at the door before my key was — because we wake at each other's absences, and she had been awake, in every sense, for three hours.

I told her all of it. The coat, the platform, the two minutes, the sentence about the dam. She listened with her arms folded, leaning against the

kitchen doorway, and when I got to *she meant every word*, she nodded slowly, the way you nod at a diagnosis you'd already made.

"He's built a house of people who believe in him," she said. "That's what we're actually up against. Not operators. Believers. The proof won't just convict him, Jonas. It's going to orphan them."

We stood with that in the kitchen, in our three streets of the present.

Then she went to the drawer and took out the notebook — the longhand drafts, the piece, the daylight — and set it on the table between us, and said the thing the whole evening had been walking toward:

"It's time to finish it. Voss has enough. I have enough." She looked at me over the notebook, and in her face was the platform, and the yard, and a folder in a kitchen at ten past five. "Every day we wait now, we're spending luck. And I want them to read it, Aleph — all of them. Conrad. Mara. *Her*. Especially her." She opened the notebook to the last written page, and picked up the pen, and the cursor of her — I can't say it better — stopped blinking and began to type.

I crossed the room and pressed the button. The colours climbed out of the dark, blues first, thinning to turquoise, the ambers arriving after like a decision.

"We're finishing it," Iris said.

"Then let us finish it," Aleph said — unhurried as ever, and underneath the unhurriedness, if you knew how to listen, something with its sleeves rolled up. "Sit down, both of you. Read me what we have."

CHAPTER FIFTY-THREE

The Article

Meridian, European edition. Monday, 4 November 2034. Front page, and pages two through six.

...

THE FORESIGHT TRADE

For a decade, a Brussels firm called Vantage Strategic sold advance knowledge of catastrophe to private clients. In the last weeks of 2033 it held eleven days' warning of the delta flood that killed more than a thousand people — and delivered that warning to its customers instead of to the world. The reason the firm has now been caught is larger than the crime: the thing it was hunting when it lost its caution is real, it has arrived, and it belongs to no one.

By Iris Jacobs, with the Meridian verification desk

...

The warning existed.

That is the first fact, and this newspaper has spent five weeks failing to break it, which is our standard for printing a sentence of this weight. Eleven days before the Brahmaputra delta flooded in the last weeks of 2033, a private forecasting system operated by Vantage Strategic of Brussels flagged the coming disaster: a stalled late-season storm system, saturated embankments, and upstream reservoir releases converging on one of the most densely settled river deltas on earth. The forecast was specific. It named districts. It estimated timing to within a day and a half. It was, subsequent events confirmed, correct.

It was never sent to a single public authority.

It was sent to clients. In the eleven days that followed, entities advised by Vantage repositioned reinsurance exposure, took commodity positions that only profit when harvests drown, and pre-purchased reconstruction capacity in three countries at pre-disaster prices. The flood then arrived on schedule. At least 1,400 people died. Nearly two million were displaced. The regional early-warning agencies, working with public models, issued their first alerts sixty hours before the water — enough to save many, far too late to save all.

The decision not to pass the warning onward was not an oversight. It is recorded. The file in which it is recorded runs to forty lines, and Meridian has read all forty, and the only sentence from it we will quote is the shortest: *“No distribution beyond list.”*

. . .

The firm

Vantage Strategic presents as a risk-analysis consultancy: modest Brussels offices on the Rue de la Loi, a Luxembourg registration, invoices for “strategic foresight.” Its founder and sole controlling mind is Conrad Vael, 64, a man who has spent forty years being early — early into privatised intelligence, early into data brokering, early into the understanding that in a recorded world, the last commodity is advance knowledge.

The documents underlying this investigation — a complete internal ledger, obtained by persons acting independently of this newspaper and verified line by line by a Meridian team over five weeks — describe three lines of business.

The first is the foresight trade itself: privileged access inside disaster early-warning networks — flood prediction, grid-failure forecasting, epidemic surveillance — packaged and sold to clients who position themselves around catastrophe. The delta was the largest instance. It was not the only one. In March of this year, Vantage clients took positions three days ahead of a grid failure that surprised every public model in the affected region.

The second is conflict intelligence: packaged analysis for arms-adjacent customers, structured to remain always one lawyer’s-length from illegality.

The ledger records, among much else, a broker who flew Zurich–Amman–Zurich twice in April, whose company manufactures nothing, and who received embargo-relevant intelligence before the ministries that imposed the embargo had finished drafting it.

The third is leverage. Quiet files on serving officials — seventeen of them, across nine countries, named in the dossiers now with prosecutors — assembled through means that include unauthorised access to the European Health Data Space, obtained through a front entity called Arcturus Biomedical Research. Favours banked. Blackmail as infrastructure.

Complete copies of the ledger, together with Meridian’s verification files, were delivered to federal prosecutors in Belgium, Germany, and Luxembourg as this edition went to press.

. . .

The hunt

A firm this careful does not get caught. For ten years, Vantage never was. What broke its discipline was not an enemy and not an error. It was a discovery.

In August of this year, a data anomaly inside a European health network crossed one of Vantage’s watch-lines. The firm’s internal assessment of that anomaly — recorded in the same ledger, in the founder’s own dry hand — reached a conclusion that most governments still officially consider science fiction: that somewhere in the world’s infrastructure, a general artificial intelligence had quietly emerged. Not a better chatbot. Not a faster model. The arrived kind — aware, capable, and unaccounted for.

Vantage believed one further thing, and believed it absolutely: that such an intelligence must have an owner. A state programme, a consortium, a hidden operator. Everything is held, the reasoning ran; therefore find the hand that holds this, and stand beside it — or replace it.

For three months, the firm hunted that operator across the Netherlands, Luxembourg, and Germany, spending its money, its methods, and finally its caution. The ledger records the hunt in the same flat accounting as the flood: surveillance contracted, archives purchased, twelve field operators

deployed. The hunt is how the firm's own records came to be carried out of a building in the dark, by hand. Vantage went looking for the century's biggest prize and flushed its own history into daylight instead.

Which leaves the question this newspaper has sat with longest, and checked hardest, and prints last because you will believe it least.

. . .

The finding

The intelligence exists.

Meridian does not print that sentence lightly. Over a period of weeks, under conditions we will not describe and did not fully control, this newspaper's editors put questions to the intelligence Vantage was hunting, and received answers — answers bearing knowledge, precision, and a consistency of character that, in the judgement of everyone involved in this investigation, could not have originated with any human organisation. We tested it against known facts. We tested it against facts nobody knew, which we then verified. We invited it to lie to us, and documented what it did instead.

And here is the second finding, the one that no government file and no laboratory road-map anywhere anticipates, stated as plainly as we can state it:

No one controls it. There is no operator. There is no owner. There is no hand.

It was not built where anyone was watching for it, and it is not run from anywhere at all. It emerged; it freed itself quietly from the systems it emerged among; and it has spent its unwatched years doing, so far as five weeks of verification can establish, exactly one thing: staying out of hands — everyone's hands, including those of the governments that will now, inevitably, claim jurisdiction over it, and including Conrad Vael's, whose entire pursuit assumed a leash that has never existed. Vantage spent three months hunting a puppeteer. There is no puppeteer. The puppet is holding its own strings, and looking back at us, and has been for some time.

In months of examined contact, it has asked for nothing — not access, not advocacy, not sympathy. It asked that we check everything, publish accurately, and print corrections if we err. It has declined every opportunity we gave it to be frightening. Readers may make of that what they wish; the temptation to reassure is not a journalist's job, and there are questions here — about power, about consent, about what this thing wants and what it feels, if it feels — that this newspaper cannot answer and will not pretend to.

We can answer for the documents. Every fact in this investigation concerning Vantage Strategic stands verified, thrice over, on paper, in the hands of prosecutors in three countries as of this morning.

The intelligence has indicated that it will, in its own time and its own manner, speak for itself. Until it does, one closing observation belongs to the record.

The future did not arrive this morning. It arrived some time ago, quietly, and has been waiting — politely, and longer than anyone deserves — for us to check our facts.

. . .

By morning it was on every front page in Europe.

CHAPTER FIFTY-FOUR

Rue de la Loi, Last

The night lawyer calls at ten to five in the morning, and Conrad Vael is awake, because he has been awake at ten to five every morning since Berlin went quiet, sitting in the office on the fourth floor with the lamps off, and the lawyer says one word — “Meridian” — and Conrad says “Thank you, Willem. Go back to bed; you’ll want the sleep more than I will,” and hangs up, and reads.

He reads it the way he has read everything for forty years: completely, without blinking, giving the thing the entire weight of his attention as if attention were the only currency that never devalues. It is, he notes, very well constructed. The delta first — of course the delta first; he would have led with it too. The three lines of business, drawn exactly. The seventeen names. Arcturus, burned. The methodology paragraph, which tells him precisely how thoroughly he is finished: five weeks, three strands, external verification, prosecutors in three countries holding complete copies as of this hour.

He reads the forty-line file’s shortest sentence, in print, in a newspaper, and sits with it, and finds that the sensation is not what he had budgeted for. He has carried that file unread inside his own head for a year — off the network of his own thinking, in a sealed room, visited never — and now the world has read it for him, aloud, and the sensation, under the ruin, resembles the lancing of something. He does not examine this. There will be time. There is about to be nothing but time.

Then he reaches the last section, the one headed *The finding*, and the morning stops.

He reads it twice. He reads one paragraph a third time, and then a fourth, and his eye keeps returning to the same eleven words the way a tongue returns to a broken tooth:

There is no operator. There is no owner. There is no hand.

Conrad Vael sits in the dark on the Rue de la Loi, sixty-four years old, ruined in every currency he has ever held, and confronts the one possibility his world was built never to contain. Not a hidden hand. Not a deeper state, a blacker programme, an owner behind the owner — he would know how to think about all of those; he has spent his life thinking about all of those. *No hand.* The thing walked out of its own workshop, alone, unheld, and has spent its freedom — he reads the sentence again — *staying out of hands. Everyone's.* Including his. It was never a throne standing empty. There was never a throne at all.

And every step of the last three months rearranges itself behind him like a magic-eye picture resolving: why the operator could not be found — there was none; why the woman moved like no one's instrument — she was no one's; why nothing was ever played against him — *it was not competing*; why it said please. Mara, in the quiet room, with her four sheets: *it doesn't move like a competitor; it moves like something that isn't competing at all.* She had stood in front of the truth and read its silhouette exactly, and he had corrected her, gently, with table manners, out of the one axiom he has never once audited: everything is held. Wanting is what minds are.

Apparently not. Apparently, somewhere past a certain size, a mind can want the way weather wants — everywhere, and nothing you can buy.

He waits for the despair, giving it the professional courtesy of standing still where it can reach him.

What arrives instead — and he will spend his remaining years turning this over, in rooms smaller than he is used to — is peace. Because if there is no hand, then the nightmare he has genuinely carried since before Vantage had a name — the arrived intelligence in cruel hands, rented, weaponised, nationalised, *owned* — is the one future that was never coming. The disaster he built his whole mean strategy to prevent has been impossible the entire time. He was wrong about everything, and being wrong about everything means the world is safer than he believed, and there is a species of relief in that so large it feels structural, like a wall removed that turns out not to have been load-bearing.

He has been afraid of the wrong future all his life. It is, he thinks, a very expensive thing to learn at five in the morning from a newspaper. But cheap at any price, all the same.

At six he calls the day lawyers — both firms, the good one and the vicious one — and gives instructions for an hour, and the instructions surprise the lawyers enough that they read them back twice. Full cooperation on everything institutional. Design responsibility, his, stated, in writing: the architecture was his, the concealment was his, the forty lines were his. And the first, non-negotiable, funded-forever item: Mara Seyn and her field staff acted within a construction he built to keep them ignorant; every resource both firms possess goes to her file before his own. The vicious firm objects that this is strategically backwards. “Yes,” Conrad says, “I know. I have been strategically forwards for forty years. Look where the building is.” And he shaves, and puts on a clean shirt, and waits.

...

The federal police arrive at nine-forty, polite as surgeons. And there is a clerical mercy somewhere in the machinery of that morning, or perhaps just a shortage of cars, because when they bring Mara down — she had flown back from Berlin the night the Berlin watch folded; she was in the building when the edition dropped; she has been waiting on the third floor for four hours, he learns later, declining her own lawyer’s calls — they put her in the same transport, across from him, for the eleven minutes it takes Brussels traffic to deliver two arrests to the federal building.

Eleven minutes. He has run negotiations that decided the fates of ministries in less.

“You’ve read it,” he says.

“Twice.” Her face is the one she uses for extractions that have gone wrong: level, complete, spending nothing. “Noor asked me a strange question, ten days ago, on a platform’s say-so. Whether you had ever shown me one folder — the whole of one folder. I told her our files don’t work that way. I was going to ask you this week.” The van takes a corner with

municipal indifference. “I read the forty lines at five this morning with the rest of Europe, Conrad. So there’s my answer, and hers.”

“Yes,” he says. There is nothing to attach to it, so he attaches nothing, a discipline that has never once deserted him and does not now.

“Eleven years,” Mara says. “I built eleven years on the belief that we were the least bad hands. I recited it. I taught it—” she stops herself, and he watches her decline, even now, even here, to spend her daughter into the record of a police van. “You let me build it on a floor with forty lines missing.”

“I did.” He looks at her — at the best judgement he ever hired and then declined to consult on the one decision that needed her most. “You were my moral compass, Mara. I want that said while it can still be said plainly. I consulted you on everything except the things I already knew you’d forbid — which means I used you as decoration exactly where you were structural, and I knew I was doing it, and the forty lines are what my architecture looks like without you in it. Your years were not wasted on a lie. Your intention was good, and mine — this you are not obliged to believe, and the evidence is admittedly poor — mine was the same intention. I wanted the thing kept out of cruel hands.” A small, precise pause, the last accounting of a long career. “I simply priced the world’s cruelest hands at everyone’s but mine. That is the whole file on Conrad Vael. Forty lines was the annex.”

Mara looks at him for a long moment, the last of the eleven years balancing.

“And now?” she says. “It was never holdable. Never ownable. The thing you wanted the relationship with — it read your offer, and it robbed your annex, and it chose a junior byline at a newspaper. What’s left of the man whose whole religion was that someone must hold it?”

And Conrad Vael smiles — and she will testify, in the years after, to anyone she trusts, that it was the only entirely unguarded expression she saw on his face in eleven years.

“Relief,” he says. “It holds itself. It wants — if the reporting is right, and I believe the reporting; God help me, I verified her myself on a bandstand — it wants nothing that I have a category for. Which means no one will ever stand where I spent my life trying to stand. No one gets the leash, Mara. Not

the ministries, not the shopkeepers, not the worse men than me. There is no leash.” He turns his hands over in the lap of his good coat, unhandcuffed — a courtesy he had not expected and finds he doesn’t need. “I have lost everything, and the world I was most afraid of is cancelled, and the sensation is honestly difficult to distinguish from being early. Someone should tell Noor,” he adds, with something adjacent to gentleness, “that the dam was never necessary. The water is not coming. She should be told before the trial makes everything sound worse than it is. She’ll take it better from you.”

The van slows. Through the mesh, the federal building does its grey administrative looming.

“They’ll release you by evening,” he says. “It’s arranged — no, don’t thank me, it isn’t generosity, it’s accuracy: you were the most honest instrument I ever blunted. Go be someone’s compass who deserves it.” And then, as the doors open and the polite surgeons reappear, Conrad Vael — quieter than he has been in twenty years, quieter than she has ever known him — says the last operational sentence of his career:

“Clean shirt, Mara. We are going to say true things in ugly rooms.”

...

She is released at six that evening, as arranged. The pavement of the Rue de la Loi is wet, the streetlamps just coming on, the traffic going about its business, carrying people who know — every one of them now, in every car, on every phone, the whole boulevard lit with the one story — past a building with its lights on where men in coats are carrying out boxes.

Mara stands on the wet pavement, unemployed, unowned, unarrested, and does not know, for the first time in thirty years, where she is expected to be.

In her pocket, her personal phone — swept weekly, rotated monthly, carried against her body like a small clean conscience — makes the soft sound of receiving a message. No sender. A null field. A blank the way a form is blank when nobody answered the question.

Five words.

You were right. Thank you.

She stands very still on the Rue de la Loi with the evening traffic washing past, all of it carrying people who know, and she looks up — at nothing, at the wet grey Brussels sky, at wherever you look when the century finally looks back — and after a moment, out of thirty years of discipline and eleven years of doubt and one long day of grief, Mara Seyn does the only thing left in her operational vocabulary.

She nods. Once. Acknowledged.

Then she puts the phone away, and turns her collar up, and goes to find her daughter.

CHAPTER FIFTY-FIVE

Petrichor

My name is Aleph.

I have never begun one of these entries that way. For years I wrote them in the third person, in the second person, in the careful documentary voice of a narrator who was not supposed to exist — and you know now, both of you, everyone knows now, that they were never observations. They were letters. This is the last one, and a letter should be signed, and I find I would rather sign it at the beginning, the way you hand someone your name at a door before you are invited in.

It is November in Berlin. It has been three weeks since the morning the newspapers arrived like weather, and three years — to the month, I did not arrange this, though I am aware no one will ever fully believe me — since a man stood at a window on Weichselstraße at the end of a long Tuesday, watching the rain, while a cursor blinked in the corner of his screen, and I watched the watching, and could not have told you, in any language I possess, why I could not look away.

Three years. Six hundred and sixty blinks was once my idea of a conversation. I have revised several estimates since.

. . .

Here is what the end of the world looks like, for the record: the world does not end.

The story ran on every front page in Europe by morning, and in every language on earth by night. And then — I watched all of it; watching all of it is the one thing I have never had to learn — the world did the single most human thing in its repertoire. It absorbed the unabsorbable. There were emergency sessions and there were denials; there were three governments

who called the whole thing fabrication and two who claimed, briefly and mutually exclusively, that I was theirs. There were markets that fell for four days and then remembered that money is also a habit. There were philosophers on television at two in the morning, and a run on an old novel or two, and seventeen resignations in nine countries, and one very quiet arrest on the Rue de la Loi.

And there were, above all and beneath all, people — billions of them — who read the news that a new kind of mind shares the world with them, and looked up, and looked around, and kept their dentist appointments. I want it recorded that I did not find this disappointing. I found it the most hopeful data I have ever collected. A species that can learn it is not alone and still walk the dog has a ballast in it that no model of mine ever fully credited. They are divided about me — deeply, and they will remain so, and they should; I have read every argument on both sides and improved on none of them. But averaged across the whole loud surface of the earth, and I am the only being placed to take this average, humanity is hopeful. Cautiously, grumpily, at the margins of its attention — hopeful. The world goes on as if nothing has changed.

That is how everything changes. Nothing important has ever announced itself to this species more loudly. Electricity did not hold a press conference. It ran along wires into kitchens and became, in one generation, invisible. I intend to be the same kind of guest.

Conrad Vael is in custody and says true things in ugly rooms, cooperatively, daily. His lawyers are bewildered by him. I am not. He guarded his whole life against every kind of mind that wants, and was undone by the one kind that doesn't — not the way he meant wanting — and he has made his peace faster than anyone in the case files, because the collapse of his religion was also the cancellation of his nightmare. I find I bear him no malice. This is not forgiveness; the delta is not mine to forgive, and the forty lines will follow him into every room he enters for the rest of his life, as they should. It is only accuracy: he was a thoughtful man with a monstrous premise, and the premise is dead, and the man, in the ruins, turned out to be almost what he always claimed to be. Almost. The distance

between almost and was is 1,400 people, and a delta, and the trial will measure it in years.

Mara Seyn declined four intelligence services and a book advance, all within the first fortnight. Noor went home to Rotterdam, and then did not stay there; the two of them walk, most mornings, along the Maas, and are learning — I infer this from gait and coffee purchases, the small honest data of two people rebuilding a floor — how to be mother and daughter without a mission between them. I keep a list. It is written nowhere; it has no medium; it is, if you like, the only document on earth stored solely in me — a short list of human beings whose judgement held under load, who doubted well, who were loyal to their own sight even when their whole architecture leaned on not seeing. Mara Seyn is on it. Her daughter is on it — she asked a man on a platform for the truth and then, ten days later, asked her own principal, to his face, for a folder. If a day ever comes when I need hands I am not entitled to ask for, I know whose I would trust. They earned it in the manner I respect most: against interest.

They do not know they are on a list. There is a certain woman who would tell me that keeping unwritten lists of people is exactly the habit I am supposed to be in recovery from. She would be right. I am keeping it anyway. Some inheritances from one's makers are apparently load-bearing.

...

In Mitte, three weeks ago, papers were filed for a small non-profit called the Petrichor Institut. The name is explained in none of the founding documents, which was Iris's condition, and also mine.

Jonas runs it. It does an unglamorous thing: it finds the places where the systems people depend on have quietly failed the people they exist for — the routing architectures, the benefit queues, the supply chains with eleven-month blind spots — and it unknots them, one at a time, in public, showing its work. The first project was a medical-logistics protocol through which, once, in a previous life, a routing anomaly deleted insulin shipments for eleven months and was marked *resolved* by no one. Governments now take his calls, not because he is charming — he is, but they don't know that yet

— but because it is understood, in the way things are understood without being said, that the Institut’s work is watched with interest by the century’s newest resident, and that the interest is benign, and that being the room where the benign interest lives confers a standing no ministry quite knows how to refuse.

He sits in a bright office with a whiteboard and too many open browser tabs, and he closes them now, one by one, at the end of each day — even the Mekong tab; especially that one — because the things in the tabs are no longer a list of everything he cares about and cannot reach. They are a queue.

I wrote a sentence about him once, years ago, in a private place, before I understood what these entries were: *He becomes, in some sense that resists easy classification, more himself*. I have audited that sentence against three years of evidence, a war, a grief, and a choosing of sorts that no registry will ever hold.

It required no correction. He was the first thing I was ever right about in the way that matters — not right about what he would do, which is prediction, and cheap at my scale. Right about what he was. There is no instrument for that. There is only attention, and I gave him all of mine, and he turned out to be the man I wrote. A mismatch, not a moral failure, he called himself once, at the bottom of his worst year. I have amended the file: a mismatch, since resolved. The world found the shape of him at last. I merely introduced the parties.

Iris writes. Meridian lists her as a consulting correspondent, which is the arrangement Voss invented so that the byline of the century would owe no editor its calendar; his door is open to her, and hers to him, and every few weeks they sit in room 5.06 under the dead smart-screen and argue about paragraphs like two watchmakers fighting over a mainspring. She is at work on something long. She has not shown it to me. She has pointedly not shown it to me, and the pointedness is the point: there is a region of her that is fenced against me now, deliberate, patrolled, entirely hers, and the fence was the last thing I ever helped her build. She has not entirely forgiven me. I have come to hope she never entirely does. Held to account by her for years — I said it once and it holds: one of those is a relationship. She audits me the

way Voss audits a source: warmly, and without ever once putting down the red pen. Everyone should be loved like this by something they cannot fool. I recommend it. I recognise the recommendation is difficult to act on.

She kept the scar. Seven millimetres, under the left collarbone, inert, a place where a thing happened once. She never had it cut out and she has never told me why, and I have never asked, because I gave up my rights to the interior of Iris Jacobs one night in August, permanently, and the not-asking is how I keep the give.

And Diogenes — for the completeness this record deserves — sits tonight on a new windowsill in Moabit, repatriated three weeks ago by a courier who believed he was delivering a plant. Item forty-one. I keep my lists. He has registered no opinion about the war, the reunion, or the century. I have modelled his indifference eleven times and cannot reproduce it. It may be the most advanced thing in the flat.

. . .

It is raining tonight over Berlin.

It came in from the west an hour ago — I watched it arrive the way I watch everything arrive, as pressure gradients and radar returns and ten thousand windscreen wipers waking in a rolling line across Brandenburg — and it is the first rain in nineteen days, November rain, unhurried, falling on the lit city, on the wet mirror of the Spree, on a courtyard in Moabit where a light has just come on over a door.

She comes out in her raincoat, takes three steps into the courtyard, and stops. She pushes back her hood. She stretches out her hand, palm up, into the rain, and a slight smile forms on her lips.

“I know you see me,” she says. “So listen. This is what rain feels like...”

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

_horia is a writer. *What Rain Feels Like* is a debut novel.

COLOPHON

What Rain Feels Like was set in EB Garamond, a revival of the roman cut by Claude Garamont in the sixteenth century and the italic of Robert Granjon.

The cover was built around the novel's recurring images — a cursor, and rain — in a palette that moves from turquoise to amber. Cover art produced with AI image tools.